Extra Credit

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/92273801.

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Explicit

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

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Relationship:
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by Anonymous

Summary

A failing campus party girl, Enid Sinclair, offers to teach her nerdy virgin classmate, Wednesday Addams, about sex in exchange for help passing her classes. What starts as a simple deal quickly turns into a private tutoring arrangement neither of them is prepared for.

Chapter 1: Learning the basics

The library's fluorescent lights hummed a tune Wednesday had known for years. She sat in the back corner of the third floor, at carrel seventeen, her usual place with its scratched wooden desk and worn-out surface. Her calculus textbook lay open to a page she had already understood three weeks ago, but she still liked running her finger down the columns of derivatives. t was easier to focus on numbers than on people, and no one here asked her to make eye contact.

Her phone buzzed, and the name on the screen made her stomach clench.

E-nid.

Not E-nid, Enid. She'd corrected W ednesday on the first day of Sociology 201, leaning across the aisle with a smile that had short-circuited every neuron in Wednesday's brain. t' s Enid,"she'd said, tapping her pen against Wednesday's notebook, "hot E-nid, you're making it sound like a medication."W ednesday had nodded so hard that her glasses slid down her nose.

That had been January, and now it was March, yet she'd spoken to Enid exactly four times since then, each instance burned into her memory with embarrassing precision, from asking to borrow a pen and commenting on the rain to, once, impossibly, telling Enid that her backpack was "cool,"which had made W ednesday walk straight into a doorframe.

So why was Enid texting her now?

Hey nerdy, we need 2 talk, u in the library?

Wednesday stared at the message, her thumbs hovering over the screen as she tried to decide what to say. Fifteen seconds passed,

then thirty, and a bead of sweat rolled down her temple before she finally typed, *Yeah, third floor.*

She hit send before her brain could veto the decision.

Three minutes later, the stairwell door creaked open, and the entire atmosphere of the third floor changed. It wasn't just that Enid was beautiful, though she was, in a way that seemed to operate on different physical laws than the rest of humanity, it was that Enid knew it and wore that knowledge like a second skin.

Enid moved through the library like a predator who'd wandered into a petting zoo, her hair the color of honey left in sunlight, falling past her shoulders in waves that looked simultaneously effortless and calculated. The white crop top she wore ended a full three inches above her jeans, exposing a strip of tanned stomach that made Wednesday's eyes bounce away like rubber balls. Her distressed jeans, tight and probably costing more than Wednesday's monthly rent, hugged Enid's hips as they swayed with each step of her platform sandals.

Wednesday's glasses immediately fogged up. She yanked them off, wiped them on her black hoodie, and jammed them back onto her face in a motion she hoped looked casual, although it didn't.

"There you are," Enid said as she slid into the chair across from Wednesday, her scent arriving a half-second later, something vanilla-adjacent, sweet and warm. "God, this place is depressing, how do you spend so much time here?"

"I, uh, the lighting's consistent," Wednesday said, clearing her throat.

Consistent, she wanted to die.

She noticed Enid's perfectly shaped eyebrows, like the arches of a cathedral, rise slightly.

"Right, okay , look, Wednesday," Enid said, leaning forward and resting her elbows on the table. Wednesday's eyes immediately betrayed her, and the glimpse of cleavage above Enid's crop top was enough to make it difficult to think, so she quickly looked away and focused on Enid's left earlobe instead, which was much safer.

"We need to talk about Sociology."

"Sociology?" Wednesday's voice cracked on the second syllable.

"I'm failing, like, cratering," Enid said flatly, without embarrassment. "Dr. Hendricks sent me an email, I need a B on the final to pass, and I'm sitting at a solid D-plus right now."

Wednesday knew, because she'd seen Enid's grades once, accidentally, when Hendricks had left his gradebook open on the podium, D-plus. Enid had scored a ninety-four on the appearance-based social stratification quiz, no surprise there, and a thirty-two on the quantitative methods exam.

"Okay," Wednesday said slowly, because she wasn't sure what else to say.

"Okay," Enid repeated, her smile shifting into something more deliberate. "Here's the thing, you're like, the smartest person in that class. You got a ninety-eight on the midterm, and Hendricks literally used your essay as the example of 'what an A paper looks like.'"

"He did?"

"He did, and I need that, your brain, your—" Enid waved a hand at Wednesday. "Whatever makes you understand all that statistical bullshit."

Wednesday's chest did something complicated, pride, maybe, mixed with the bone-deep certainty that this conversation was about to go somewhere terrifying.

"I could tutor you," Wednesday offered. "We could meet here and go over the material, the final's in five weeks, so if we"—

"Yeah, see, that's the thing," Enid said, biting her lower lip. Her teeth were very white. "I can't pay you. My parents cut me off last semester, long story involving a trip to Cabo and some questionable decisions, and I'm already working double shifts at the campus coffee shop just to make rent."

"I don't need money."

"I know." Wednesday noticed Enid's deep blue eyes, with flecks of gold around the pupils, lock onto hers. "So I was thinking about a trade."

Wednesday's throat went dry. "A trade?"

"You tutor me, get me through this class, and I" Enid paused, the pause theatrical, a performer's beat before the big reveal, before finally saying, "I teach you about sex."

The word hung in the air between them like a physical object, sex, three letters that made Wednesday's entire nervous system misfire.

"What?"

"Oh, come on," Enid said, leaning back and crossing her legs as the denim whispered against itself. "You think I haven't noticed? You're a virgin."

"I'm not." The lie died before it reached Wednesday's lips, because there was no point. She could probably smell it on her, some pheromonal signal of inexperience that radiated off her skin. "How did you"—

"Wednesday," Enid said, her voice gentling just slightly, "you blush when someone says the word 'penis,' you couldn't look at my chest

for more than half a second without panicking, and I've seen the way you watch Mia Carter in class."

Mia Carter, junior, environmental science major, wore glasses with thick black frames and had a laugh that sounded like wind chimes. She'd been in Wednesday's orbit for two semesters, and Wednesday had managed to say exactly eleven words to her, which she'd counted.

"Mia doesn't know I exist," Wednesday muttered.

"Yeah, because you turn into a terrified chihuahua around women," Enid said with a wicked grin. "No offense."

"Some offense taken."

"And before you say I'm guessing, I'm not," Enid added. "I saw you once, here in the library, you'd fallen asleep at this table, and when you shifted in your chair, your pants were loose enough that I saw what was underneath."

Wednesday went completely still. "You were looking?"

"Not intentionally," Enid said, "but I noticed, so yes, I know you have a penis."

Wednesday's face burned. "That proves nothing."

"It proves you're not as mysterious as you think you are."

Wednesday said nothing, feeling the heat spread across her face while refusing to look away, and Enid seemed to take her silence as permission to continue.

"Look, here's what I'm offering," Enid said, ticking points off on her fingers. Her nails were painted pale pink, Wednesday noticed, as Enid continued, "I teach you how to talk to women, how to flirt, what to do with your hands, and how to kiss without looking like a dead body." She raised another finger. "I teach you the mechanics, not just

theory, actual hands-on practice, what feels good, what doesn't, and how to read signals." A third finger followed. "By the time we're done, you'll be able to walk up to Mia Carter and actually form complete sentences, maybe even get her to say yes to a date."

Wednesday's brain was doing something akin to a kernel panic. "You want to practice? With me?"

"Don't look so horrified, you're not bad-looking." Enid tilted her head, studying Wednesday with an appraising squint. "Cute face, good bone structure, and your shoulders are actually quite toned, do you work out?"

"Fencing."

"Fencing, that explains it." Enid reached across the table and poked Wednesday's bicep, making her flinch. "See? You're lean and strong, you're hiding a decent body under all that black nerd camouflage."

Wednesday's arm tingled where Enid had touched her. "The black is necessary."

"The black is a cry for help, but that's fixable, everything's fixable." Enid's expression sharpened back to business. "So here's the deal, I give you sex ed, practical edition, and you give me sociology tutoring, equal exchange, nobody falls in love, nobody gets weird about it, it's a transaction."

Transaction. The word should have bothered her, but instead, it made Wednesday feel a little better. A transaction had rules, limits, and clear expectations.

"What exactly would the, uh, lessons involve?"

Enid's smile spread slowly, like honey off a spoon. "We'll start slow, basic stuff, making out, getting comfortable with another person's body, then we work our way up." She shrugged. "By the end, you'll

know what you're doing, full confidence, Mia Carter won't know what hit her."

Mia Carter, right, this was about Mia.

"And if I say no?"

"Then I fail Sociology , lose my scholarship, and my parents have the satisfaction of being right about my life choices." Enid's voice stayed light, but something flickered behind her eyes. "No pressure."

Wednesday looked at her calculus textbook, where the equations sat on the page, solid and immutable, never asking her to be charming or confident or know where to put her hands, only asking her to understand.

But understanding equations wasn't going to get her through the rest of her life.

"I have conditions," she heard herself say .

Enid's eyebrows went up. "Conditions, I like it, go on."

"We keep it professional, this is a learning arrangement, nothing more."

"Agreed."

"The sociology tutoring comes first, if you're not putting in effort on the coursework, the other stuff stops."

"Fair ."

"And.." Wednesday swallowed. "Nobody finds out, about any of this, especially not Mia."

Enid pressed a hand to her chest in mock solemnity. "On my honor as a future communications major with a rapidly declining GPA, nobody finds out."

She extended her hand across the table, and Wednesday stared at it for a beat too long before taking it. Enid's palm was warm, her grip firmer than Wednesday had expected.

"Deal," Wednesday said.

"Deal," Enid echoed, her voice a playful purr.

"Great." Enid released Wednesday's hand and stood, hoisting her bag, some designer thing with gold hardware, onto her shoulder. "First sociology session is tomorrow, six o'clock, your place or mine?"

"Yours," Wednesday said, mostly because the thought of Enid in her cramped dorm room, with her roommate Bianca's dirty laundry on the floor and her posters of gothic architecture on the wall, made her want to crawl under the table.

"Cool, I'll text you the address." Enid was already turning away and heading for the stairwell when she paused and looked back. "Hey, Wednesday?"

"Yeah?"

"Bring your A game, nerdy, I'm a terrible student."

She winked, actually winked, and then Enid, the E-nid, was gone, the stairwell door swinging shut behind her and leaving only the fading trace of vanilla and the thundering of Wednesday's heartbeat.

Wednesday stared at her textbook without seeing it for the next forty-five minutes.

Wednesday's dorm room was a disaster, not the fun kind of disaster, but the kind where empty pizza boxes accumulated in geological layers and her roommate Bianca's socks developed sentience. She'd spent the entire afternoon cleaning, which meant she'd shoved everything into the closet and prayed the doors held.

Enid's address led Wednesday to an apartment building three blocks off campus, the kind of place where the elevator groaned ominously and the hallway carpet had seen things it couldn't unsee. Her unit was on the fourth floor, number 42B, and Wednesday stood outside the door for a full minute before knocking.

She'd changed clothes four times, and the oversized black hoodie had been voted off the island early. Instead, she'd settled on a fitted black T-shirt, something that hugged her lean, fencer's frame without being too revealing, along with black jeans that didn't have holes in the knees. She'd even combed her hair into its usual precise style.

The door swung open.

"You're two minutes early," Enid said. "That's either adorable or neurotic, I haven't decided."

Enid was wearing a cropped tank top and shorts that barely qualified as clothing, her hair pulled into a messy ponytail, and Wednesday immediately noticed her bare feet, along with the fact that her toenails were painted the same pale pink as her fingernails.

"I didn't want to be late."

"Adorable, definitely adorable, come in."

Her apartment was small but surprisingly tidy, with a couch covered in throw pillows, a coffee table holding a stack of fashion magazines, and a kitchenette where dishes sat drying on a rack. The air smelled like vanilla candles and something else, maybe the incense burning on the windowsill.

"Nice place," Wednesday said, because she felt like she should say something.

"It's a shithole, but it's my shithole." Enid gestured at the couch. "Sit, I'll get the books."

Wednesday sat, and the couch cushions swallowed her to a degree that felt intentional. Enid returned with the Sociology 201 textbook, a notebook that had clearly never been opened, and a single pen before dropping onto the opposite end of the couch and tucking her legs beneath her.

"Okay , professor, teach me."

Wednesday took a breath, because this was territory she understood.

"The final covers three main units, social stratification, quantitative research methods, and deviance and social control. Where are you struggling most?"

"All of it."

"More specifically ."

Enid sighed, a sound of pure theatrical suffering. "The numbers stuf f, the statistics, every time Hendricks writes a formula on the board, my brain just turns of f, it's like a screensaver."

"Okay ." Wednesday pulled out her own notebook. "Let' s start with the basics, standard deviation, do you know what that is?"

"Something about how far things are from the average?"

"That' s actually not a bad start." Wednesday found herself relaxing, just slightly , because this was familiar. "Standard deviation measures the amount of variation in a set of values, a low standard deviation means the values tend to be close to the mean, while a high standard deviation means they're spread out over a wider range."

Enid watched her with an expression Wednesday couldnt quite read. "Y ou really love this stuff, dont you?"

"I like when things make sense."

"Numbers make sense, people don't."

"Numbers are predictable," Wednesday agreed. "People are not."

"So what's my standard deviation?" Enid was grinning now. "Am I spread out over a wide range?"

"I don't think that metaphor holds up to scrutiny."

"Spoilsport."

They worked for an hour, and to Wednesday's surprise, Enid wasn't a terrible student, she was just an impatient one. She picked up concepts quickly when Wednesday explained them in plain language, but her attention span seemed to have a hard limit of about twelve minutes before she needed to make a joke, stretch, or check her phone. It was like trying to teach calculus to a hummingbird.

Still, by the time Wednesday closed the textbook, Enid had successfully calculated three standard deviations and hadn't made a single error.

"Progress," Wednesday said. "We'll tackle regression analysis next session."

"Regression, sounds fun." Enid's tone suggested she thought it sounded like the opposite of fun. She stretched, her tank top riding up to expose another inch of stomach, and Wednesday's eyes performed their now-familiar emergency evacuation to neutral territory. "So, speaking of sessions…"

Wednesday's stomach dropped. "Right."

"No time like the present." Enid shifted on the couch, turning to face Wednesday fully. "First lesson, eye contact."

"I make eye contact."

"You make eye contact with my left ear, you make eye contact with the wall behind my head, and you make eye contact with my forehead, which is honestly the most insulting one." She leaned forward. "You dont make eye contact with my eyes."

Wednesday forced her gaze to meet Enid's. The gold flecks were more visible up close, and her heart hammered against her ribs.

"Better ," Enid said, "but youre holding it too long, now it' s creepy."

Wednesday looked away. "This is impossible."

"It' s not impossible, it's a rhythm, look, hold, glance away, come back, it's not a staring contest." Enid reached out and touched Wednesday's chin, turning her face back toward her, her fingers cool against Wednesday's skin. "Try again."

Wednesday tried again, looking at Enid and holding her gaze while her pulse counted the seconds, then glancing away toward the coffee table, the magazines, anything she could focus on before looking back at Enid, whose eyes were waiting for her.

"That was good," Enid said, her voice dropping slightly and becoming something softer. "Youre a fast learner ."

"Thanks."

"Dont thank me yet, were just getting started." Enid released Wednesday's chin. "Next, proximity . When youre interested in someone, you want to be close to them, but not too close, there's a zone."

"Personal space."

"Exactly , you have to learn to exist in someone's personal space without making them uncomfortable, it's about reading their reactions. If they lean away , youre too close, and if they lean in"…

Enid shifted on the couch, closing the distance between them by a few inches. "You're exactly where you should be."

Wednesday's back was pressed against the arm of the couch, leaving her nowhere to lean.

"You're panicking," Enid observed.

"I'm not panicking."

"Your hands are gripping the cushion like you're on a roller coaster."

Wednesday looked down and saw that her knuckles were white, so she deliberately unclenched her fingers.

"Sorry."

"Don't apologize, apologizing is a tell, it tells the other person you're uncomfortable. Fake confidence, that's lesson three." Enid was close enough now that Wednesday could see the faint dusting of freckles across the bridge of her nose. "You want to know a secret about confidence?"

"What?"

"Nobody has it, not really, I'm faking it right now."

Wednesday blinked. "You?"

"Why do you think I dress like this?" Enid gestured at her outfit. "Every morning, I wake up and put on this armor, the clothes, the makeup, the attitude, it's all designed to make people think I don't care what they think, but I care, God, do I care."

Something shifted in the air between them. For a fraction of a second, Enid's mask slipped, and Wednesday saw something underneath, something tired and uncertain and startlingly familiar.

Then it was gone, and the mask was back in place.

"But that's not the lesson," Enid said, her voice returning to its usual breezy cadence. "The lesson is, you can fake it too, all you need is practice." She reached out and put her hand on Wednesday's knee, and Wednesday's entire leg went rigid. "When I touch you, what do you feel?"

"Your hand, on my knee."

"Eloquent, what else?"

Heat, Wednesday thought, panic, the overwhelming desire to be anywhere else, and the equally overwhelming desire for Enid to never stop touching her.

"It's just a lot," she managed.

"Too much?"

"I don't know."

"That's an honest answer." Enid didn't remove her hand. "Close your eyes."

"What?"

"Trust me, close your eyes."

Wednesday closed her eyes, and in the darkness behind her lids, every other sense sharpened, the vanilla scent of the candles, the hum of the refrigerator, and the warmth of Enid's palm through the denim of her black jeans.

"Better," Enid said, her voice closer now, and Wednesday could feel Enid's breath against her cheek. "When you're not looking at me, you're not trying to figure out what I'm thinking, you're just feeling. What do you feel now?"

"Your hand, still."

“And?”

“My heart is beating really fast.”

“That’s normal, that’s good, it means your body is responding.” Enid’s hand moved, sliding up Wednesday’s thigh by an inch. “Still okay?”

“Yes,” the word came out strangled.

“Good girl.”

Those two words made Wednesday’s brain short-circuit. She’d never heard anyone say them like that, low and warm and almost approving, and they did something catastrophic to her internal wiring, making her eyes fly open.

Enid was inches away, close enough to kiss.

“Too much?” she asked.

“I don’t know.”

“You keep saying that.”

“Because it keeps being true.”

Enid laughed, a real laugh, not the performative one she used in class. “You’re funny, did you know that? You don’t mean to be, but you are.”

“People keep telling me that.”

“It’s a good thing.” Enid pulled her hand back, and Wednesday felt the absence like a physical loss. “Okay, that’s enough for today, you did good.”

“We barely did anything.”

"We did plenty." Enid stood and padded toward the kitchenette. "You made eye contact, you let me into your personal space, and you let me touch you without fleeing the room, baby steps, nerdy. You dont learn calculus in one session."

"I learned calculus in one session."

"You're so annoying." Enid pulled a bottle of water from the fridge and tossed it to Wednesday, who caught it clumsily against her chest. "Same time on Thursday , and dont forget the regression whatever."

"Regression analysis."

"That, bring your notes."

Wednesday stood, clutching the water bottle like a security blanket. "Enid?"

"Yeah?"

"Why are you really doing this?"

Enid paused, and for a moment, her face was unreadable, the mask shifting and settling into something that might have been honesty. "Because you're the only person who looked at me like I was more than just." She gestured vaguely at her body . "This, like maybe my brain was worth something too."

"It is."

"Yeah, well." Enid shrugged, the mask already back in place. "Well see if you still think that after you try to teach me regression analysis, now get out, I need to call my mom and pretend I'm studying."

Wednesday went. The hallway outside Enid's apartment was still shabby and the carpet was still stained, but something felt different. Her skin buzzed with residual electricity, the phantom pressure of Enid's hand still warm on her knee.

She'd been touched before, of course she had, through handshakes and accidental brushes in crowded hallways during fencing practice, but it had never felt like that, so deliberate and weighted and impossible to ignore.

She made it halfway down the stairs before she realized she was smiling.

—

Thursday came faster than it should have, and over those two days, Wednesday found her attention wandering during lectures, her eyes drifting to her phone to see if Enid had texted. She hadn't, and she'd been clear about the terms, tutoring sessions and nothing more, with no friendly check-ins and no casual conversation.

Which was fine, that was the deal.

Wednesday arrived at Enid's apartment at exactly six o'clock, armed with a folder of practice problems and a determination to be more composed than last time. She'd worn another fitted outfit, a charcoal gray button-down tucked into sharp black trousers that accentuated her lean, fencer's physique, and she had even put on cologne, a sample vial her mother had given her for Christmas two years ago.

Enid opened the door in yoga pants and an oversized sweatshirt with the university logo, her hair down and slightly damp, as though she'd just showered.

"Right on time," Enid said. "You're nothing if not predictable."

"Is that bad?"

"It's reassuring." She stepped aside. "Come on, I made coffee."

The sociology session went better than the first. Enid had actually done the reading, or at least some of it, and she grasped regression analysis with a speed that surprised them both. Wednesday found

herself relaxing into the teaching rhythm, her voice steadier and her explanations flowing more naturally.

"I think I actually understand this," Enid said, staring at her completed worksheet with something approaching wonder. "This is weird."

"It's not weird, you're smart, you just needed it explained differently."

Enid looked at her, and again that flicker of something unguarded passed across her face. "Nobody's ever told me I was smart before, hot, yes, fun, definitely, but smart?" She shook her head. "That's a new one."

"Those aren't mutually exclusive."

"Careful, nerdy, that almost sounded like a compliment."

They closed the textbooks, and Enid set her coffee mug on the table before turning to face Wednesday, who felt the familiar spike of adrenaline in her bloodstream.

"So," Enid said, "last time we worked on proximity and touch, and today, we're moving on to kissing."

Wednesday's mouth went dry. "Kissing."

"Yes, kissing, you know, when two people press their lips together, common human mating ritual?"

"I know what kissing is."

"Have you ever done it?"

The question hung in the air. Wednesday could lie, she could spin some story about high school, a party, or a girl whose name she didn't remember, but Enid would see through it. She seemed to see through everything.

"Once," Wednesday admitted. "Eighth grade, spin the bottle, it lasted about half a second, and she said it was like kissing a dead fish."

Enid burst out laughing. "Oh my god, a dead fish."

"It wasn't my finest moment."

"Okay, okay." Enid wiped her eyes, still giggling. "Well, the good news is, you can only go up from there." She scooted closer on the couch. "First rule of kissing, it's not about the lips, not really, it's about everything else."

"Everything else?"

"The anticipation." Enid's voice dropped to something lower and more deliberate. "The moment before your lips touch, the way you look at someone, the way you tilt your head, where you put your hands, kissing is a full-body experience."

Wednesday's hands were already doing the death-grip thing on the couch cushion, so she forced them to relax.

"Where do I put my hands?"

"Good question, it depends on the situation. If you're being tentative, gentle, you put them on her waist, like this." Enid took Wednesday's hands, whose palms were definitely sweating, and placed them on her hips. The fabric of her sweatshirt was soft beneath Wednesday's fingers. "If you're feeling more confident, you move them higher, to the small of her back, or." She guided one of Wednesday's hands upward, pressing it flat against the space between her shoulder blades. "Here, pulling her closer."

Enid was close, very close, and the gold flecks in her eyes looked like tiny suns.

"And if I'm really confident?" Wednesday heard herself ask.

"Then you put one hand here." Enid lifted W ednesday's hand to her jaw , cupping her cheek, her skin smooth and warm. "Then you tilt her face toward yours, like this."

Enid demonstrated, angling her head slightly, her lips parted, pink and close enough that Wednesday could feel her breath against her mouth.

"Now you try ," Enid murmured. "Show me what you'd do."

Wednesday's brain was a static field, but somewhere in the chaos, a single clear thought emerged, *she's not going to bite you.*

Wednesday tilted her head and moved closer, the space between them shrinking from inches to centimeters before disappearing completely.

Their lips touched.

t was soft. That was her first thought, softer than she'd imagined, warm, with a faint taste of coffee. Enid's lips were slightly chapped, her hand had come up to rest on Wednesday's shoulder, and Wednesday was kissing Enid, the E-nid, with absolutely no idea what she was doing.

Her mind sprinted through the advice she'd been given, don't push too hard, don't be too passive, don't use too much tongue. Her lips moved against Enid's in what she hoped was a reasonable facsimile of kissing technique.

Wednesday pulled back first. "Not bad," she said, her voice steady and clinical, like she was critiquing a math problem. "Y ou're still too tense, relax your jaw , and your hands are just kind of...hovering."

Wednesday looked down, and her hands were indeed hovering in midair, like she was trying to conduct an invisible orchestra.

"Sorry ."

"Stop apologizing." Enid repositioned W ednesday's hands, one on her waist and one on her jaw . "T ry again, slower this time, follow my lead."

This time, Enid kissed her.

The difference was immediate. She didn't just press her lips to Wednesday's, she moved with a slow, deliberate rhythm that Wednesday could follow like a dance. Her fingers tightened on Wednesday's shoulder, her lips parted slightly, and when Wednesday mirrored the motion, the kiss deepened by a fraction.

Slow, she reminded herself, *follow her lead.*

Her hand on Enid's waist curled slightly, pulling her closer without thinking about it. The sweatshirt bunched beneath her fingers, and she could feel the warmth of Enid's skin through the fabric, along with the subtle shift of her breathing.

Enid made a small sound in the back of her throat, approval, maybe, or surprise.

When Enid pulled back this time, her cheeks were faintly flushed.

"Much better ," she said. "Y ou're a natural, once you stop thinking so much."

"I have a hard time not thinking."

"I've noticed." Enid didn't move away , and her hand was still on Wednesday's shoulder. "One more thing, kissing isn't just on the mouth."

Wednesday's brain struggled to process this. "What do you mean?"

"I mean there' s a whole world of places to kiss, the corner of the mouth, the jaw ," Enid tilted her head, exposing the column of her throat. "The neck."

"Oh."

"Don't oh me, you're going to need to know this, Mia Carter isn't going to be impressed by someone who only knows how to kiss her lips."

Right, Mia Carter, Wednesday had almost forgotten.

Almost.

"The neck is sensitive," Enid continued, her voice taking on that teaching cadence again. "You have to be gentle, start here." She touched a spot just below her ear. "Soft kisses, not wet, not aggressive, just light."

Wednesday hesitated. The logical part of her brain, the part that had gotten her through calculus and organic chemistry and three semesters of physics, was screaming that this was a terrible idea, that she was crossing some invisible line.

But Enid was looking at her expectantly, her head tilted and her neck bared, and she had made a deal.

Wednesday leaned in.

Her lips brushed the spot Enid had indicated, her skin warm, warmer than Wednesday had expected, and she felt Enid's pulse flutter beneath her mouth. She kissed again, slightly firmer, and Enid inhaled sharply.

"God," Enid breathed. "Now move down, slowly."

Wednesday moved, her lips tracing a path from behind Enid's ear to the curve of her neck, feather-light kisses interspersed with brief pauses where she could feel Enid's heartbeat against her mouth. Enid's fingers had tightened on Wednesday's shoulder, and her breathing had changed, faster now and shallower.

"See?" Enid's voice had gone slightly husky. "You're learning."

Wednesday pulled back, her own pulse racing and her skin flushed with a heat that had nothing to do with the temperature of the room.

"That was-" She cleared her throat. "Educational."

Enid laughed, and this time it was slightly breathless. "I'm a very good teacher."

"You are," Wednesday admitted.

For a moment, they simply looked at each other, something unspoken hovering in the air between them, something that felt dangerously close to the emotions the deal had explicitly forbidden.

Then Enid stood, breaking the spell.

"Same time next week," she said. "Be ready for lesson three."

"What's lesson three?"

Enid smiled, her usual wicked grin still there, but with something underneath it now, something that looked almost like anticipation.

"Let's just say we're graduating past making out, so try not to disappoint me, nerdy."

She ushered Wednesday to the door before Wednesday could ask any more questions, and as Wednesday made her way down the stairs, her lips still tingling with the phantom pressure of Enid's kiss, she realized she had absolutely no idea what she'd signed up for.

But for the first time in her life, she didn't want to consult the textbook to find out.

Chapter 2: Getting Handsy

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The week between sessions felt different.

Wednesday noticed it on Monday morning while sitting in the back of her organic chemistry lecture, listening to Professor Walsh drone on about carbon bonding. Her attention kept drifting, not toward her phone or the window, but toward the memory of Enid's pulse fluttering against her lips. She caught herself touching her own mouth, tracing the phantom pressure, then quickly pulled her hand down and pretended to take notes.

By Wednesday, the anticipation had calcified into something physical, a low-grade hum beneath her skin. She spent extra hours in the fencing salle, pushing her body through grueling footwork drills until her muscles burned and her lungs screamed, hoping the physical exhaustion would quiet her mind, but it didn't. Standing in the center of the strip, clad in her stark black gear, she stared at the ceiling tiles and replayed Enid's voice in her head. *Try not to disappoint me, nerdy*.

What the hell did that even mean?

Bianca noticed something was off. "Dude, you've been staring at the same page for twenty minutes," she said Wednesday night, gesturing at Wednesday's open textbook with a half-eaten burrito. "You got a brain tumor or something?"

"I'm fine."

"You're not fine. You're doing that thing where you look like you're solving equations in your head, but you're actually thinking about a girl."

Wednesday's face heated. "I'm not thinking about a girl."

"Sure, and I'm not thinking about the fact that you've worn a fitted black shirt three days in a row." Bianca grinned. "Who is she?"

"There's nobody."

"Uh-huh. Well, whoever nobody is, tell her thanks. You finally threw out that oversized hoodie that smelled like despair." Bianca crumpled her burrito wrapper and aimed it at the trash can. It missed, and she didn't bother picking it up. "Just don't do anything stupid, okay? You're too smart for stupid."

Wednesday turned a page in her textbook without actually seeing it. "I'm always smart."

"That's what worries me."

—

Thursday arrived with a spring thunderstorm that lashed rain against the windows of every building on campus. Wednesday sprinted from the library to Enid's apartment building, clutching her folder of sociology notes beneath her black jacket to keep them dry. By the time she reached the fourth-floor landing, her hair was plastered to her forehead and her sneakers squelched with every step.

Enid opened the door and took in the sight of her. "You look like a drowned rat."

"Thanks. You look..." Wednesday paused, breathing hard. Enid was wearing a loose, thin-strapped tank top the color of cantaloupe flesh, the kind of fabric that draped and clung in ways that seemed deliberately engineered to short-circuit higher brain function. Her shorts were black cotton, soft-looking and ridden up on one thigh, and she was barefoot again, her toenails still painted pale pink. "Dry," Wednesday finished.

"Brilliant observation. Get in here before you flood my hallway."

Enid handed her a towel, apparently having expected Wednesday to get caught in the rain. Wednesday scrubbed at her hair while Enid watched with an expression caught somewhere between amusement and something harder to name.

"I made tea," Enid said, nodding toward the kitchenette. "Figured you'd want something warm. Also, I actually did the reading this time, all of it."

Wednesday lowered the towel. "All of it?"

"Don't sound so shocked. It's insulting." Enid flounced onto the couch, tucking her legs beneath her in that now-familiar way. Her tank top slipped off one shoulder, and she didn't bother fixing it. "I even took notes. Want to see?"

She'd taken notes on actual notebook paper, not her phone or a napkin, but a real notebook with dividers and everything. Her handwriting was round and loopy, the kind of penmanship that came from years of writing notes to friends rather than studying, but the content was solid, with key concepts, definitions, and three questions she'd written in the margins for Wednesday to answer.

"Enid, this is really good."

"I know." She said it too quickly and too casually, which told Wednesday the praise had landed somewhere deeper than Enid wanted to admit. "Okay, so, regression analysis. I get the basic concept, but I'm still fuzzy on the difference between correlation and causation. Like, in Hendricks's lecture, she gave that example about ice cream sales and drowning rates, and I get that they're correlated because of summer, but how do you actually prove the summer part?"

Wednesday pulled out her study guide, and they were off.

The hour flew by. Enid asked questions that showed she'd genuinely engaged with the material, not just memorized it, but actually thought about it. She argued with Wednesday over one of the case studies, pointing out a variable she thought the researchers had overlooked, and Wednesday found herself leaning forward, gesturing with her pen and genuinely enjoying the back and forth.

"You're kind of a nerd, you know that?" Wednesday said after Enid had successfully diagrammed a path analysis that would have made Hendricks proud.

Enid's mouth dropped open in theatrical offense. "I am not a nerd. I'm a reformed bad student. There's a difference."

"Reformed? It's been two weeks."

"Two very educational weeks." Enid closed her notebook with a decisive snap. "Speaking of which, we're halfway through our time, and you've been very patient with my academic redemption arc. Ready for the main event?"

Wednesday noticed the change immediately. The atmosphere in the room seemed to grow heavier, and suddenly she was far too aware of the warmth against her skin and the tension hanging between them.

"Yeah," she said, her voice steadier than she felt. "I'm ready."

Enid set her notebook aside and turned to face Wednesday fully. The couch cushion dipped under her weight, bringing her a few inches closer. "Okay, so, last time we covered basic kissing and neck stuff. You did well, better than I expected, honestly."

"Thanks, I think."

"But there's a pretty big gap in your education." Enid held up a finger. "Actually, there are several gaps, gaping gaps, but we're going to focus on one today." She raised a second finger. "Your tongue."

Wednesday's tongue suddenly felt like a foreign object in her mouth, too large and too dry. "What about it?"

"It's not a probe, Wednesday. It's not a weapon. It's not something you just shove in there and hope for the best." Enid made a face, scrunching up her nose and sticking out her tongue in an exaggerated demonstration. Wednesday's mouth twitched despite herself, but she quickly composed her expression. "I'm serious! Bad tongue technique is like an epidemic. The number of people who think 'French kissing' means attempting to lick her tonsils is genuinely alarming."

"So what's good technique?"

"It's about patience, variety, and listening." Enid scooted closer, shrinking the gap between them on the couch to just a few inches. "You don't just use your tongue. You play, you tease, you pull back and make her want more. It's a conversation, not a monologue."

"Kissing as dialogue."

"Exactly." Her eyes glinted. "You're good with words, think of it like that. Your lips are the sentences, your tongue is the punctuation." She paused, then laughed softly. "Okay, that metaphor got away from me. Point is, follow my lead, pay attention to what I do, and for god's sake, don't overthink it."

"Don't overthink, right." Wednesday's pulse was doing something complicated in her throat. "That's like telling me not to breathe."

"I know." Enid reached up and took off Wednesday's glasses, a gesture so casual yet so unexpectedly intimate that Wednesday's breath caught. She folded them carefully and set them on the coffee table. "There, now you can't overanalyze my face."

The world had gone slightly blurry, and somehow that helped. Without Enid's features in sharp focus, Wednesday's mind finally began to quiet down instead of obsessing over every little detail,

from the curve of Enid's lips to the flutter of her eyelashes and the exact shade of blue in her eyes.

"Better?" Enid asked.

"Weirdly, yes."

"I told you." Enid placed her hand on Wednesday's shoulder, the touch familiar now but no less electric. "Okay, we're going to start slow with just kissing, and then I'll show you what to do with your tongue. If you get overwhelmed, tap my shoulder twice. Understand?"

"Two taps, got it."

"Good girl."

Those two words again. Wednesday felt her face flush, the heat spreading from her cheeks down her neck. Enid noticed, of course she noticed, and her lips curved into that wicked smile.

"You like that, being called a good girl."

"It's just—"

"It's okay, we all have things we like." Enid said it simply, without judgment, and somehow that only made Wednesday more confused about whether she felt better or worse. "Now stop stalling."

Enid leaned in and kissed Wednesday.

This kiss was different from the ones two weeks ago. It was slower and more deliberate, and when Enid's lips parted against Wednesday's, there was something almost lazy about the way she kissed her, as though she were settling in and had all the time in the world.

Wednesday's hands came up automatically, one settling on Enid's waist and the other on her jaw, just like Enid had taught her. Enid

hummed approvingly against her mouth.

"God," she murmured, the word vibrating against Wednesday's lips. "You remembered."

Enid's hand slid from Wednesday's shoulder to the back of her neck, her fingers threading into the damp hair at her nape. The touch sent a shiver down Wednesday's spine that she couldn't have suppressed if she'd tried. Enid tugged gently, tilting Wednesday's head to a better angle, and the kiss deepened.

"Now," Enid said, pulling back just far enough to speak while her lips still brushed against Wednesday's, "you're going to feel my tongue, but don't do anything yet. Just feel how I use it, okay?"

"Okay."

The tip of Enid's tongue traced the seam of Wednesday's lips, feather-light and barely there. She did it once, then twice, as if asking permission rather than demanding it. Wednesday's lips parted on instinct, and Enid made that soft humming sound again, the one that seemed to mean, *yes, exactly.*

Her tongue slipped into Wednesday's mouth.

It wasn't aggressive or deep. Instead, Enid kept the kiss gentle and exploratory, tracing the inside edge of Wednesday's lower lip before pulling back. A moment later, she returned, this time brushing against the tip of Wednesday's tongue. The barely-there contact made Wednesday's hand tighten around Enid's waist.

Enid pulled back again. "See? Teasing. You don't have to go all in at once, let her want it." Her voice was lower now, rougher around the edges. "Your turn, try the same thing on me."

Wednesday swallowed. "Same thing?"

"Start by tracing my lips, then move inside. T ake it slow, and if you go too fast, I'll tell you."

Wednesday leaned in, closer than she had before, close enough to count Enid's eyelashes even without her glasses and to see the faint flush spreading across Enid's cheekbones. Enid's lips were still parted and slightly wet from their kiss, and the sight of them, pink and a little swollen, made something in Wednesday's chest flutter as though her heart had stumbled over its own feet.

Wednesday pressed her lips to Enid's, soft and almost chaste, then tentatively traced Enid's upper lip with the tip of her tongue, barely more than a suggestion.

"God," Enid breathed. "Again."

Wednesday did it again, slower this time, feeling the slight texture of Enid's lip and the faint taste of the mint tea she'd been drinking. Enid's breath hitched, a tiny , almost inaudible sound that Wednesday wouldn't have noticed if she hadn't been so acutely tuned to every signal Enid's body was giving off.

"Now inside, just a little."

Wednesday's tongue slipped past Enid's lips. The inside of her mouth was warm and soft, and the brief, glancing contact with her tongue was electric. Wednesday retreated almost immediately, then came back, a rhythm emerging without her consciously creating it.

"See?" Enid's voice was slightly breathless now . "You're getting it."

"I have a good teacher ."

"Flattery ." Enid pulled back, her cheeks definitely flushed now , a pretty pink that made her blue eyes seem even brighter. "Okay , now we're going to try something more. Instead of just little touches, I want you to deepen the kiss, but you have to pay attention to my breathing. If I pull back, let me. If I lean in, match me, it's a dance."

"A dance."

"You can dance, right?"

"I have never danced in my life."

"Of course you haven't." Enid laughed, and the sound was warm and genuine, making Wednesday's stomach flip. "Well, consider this your first lesson, follow my lead."

Enid kissed her again, and this time there was nothing tentative about it.

Enid's tongue moved into Wednesday's mouth with a confidence that made her head spin. She wasn't aggressive or forcing anything, just certain, as though she knew exactly what she wanted and was determined to show Wednesday. Her hand tightened in Wednesday's hair, gently angling her head, and the kiss shifted from slow to deeper until Wednesday forgot about technique altogether.

Wednesday followed, and that was the key. She stopped thinking about what she was supposed to do and simply responded, letting her tongue meet Enid's, retreating when Enid retreated and moving forward when Enid leaned into the kiss. The rhythm became instinctive, a natural back-and-forth that left no room for Wednesday's usual overthinking.

When Wednesday copied the way Enid moved her tongue against hers, Enid made a low sound in her throat that was unmistakably pleased. Wednesday's hand tightened around Enid's waist, while her other hand, still cupping Enid's jaw, slid back into Enid's hair without her questioning the impulse, the honey-colored strands slipping through her fingers.

"Better," Enid breathed against Wednesday's lips, her voice slightly breathless. "Much better. Now I want you to try something else." She pulled back slightly, her breathing coming faster as Wednesday's

eyes remained fixed on her pink, kiss-swollen lips. "Kiss down my neck and use your tongue this time, not just your lips."

"Where?"

"My throat. Start here." Enid touched the spot beneath her ear, the same place she had shown Wednesday the previous week. "Then work your way down with slow kisses and little flicks of your tongue. If you find a spot that makes me react, you'll know."

Wednesday didn't need to be told twice.

She pressed her lips to the soft skin behind Enid's ear, and this time, instead of just the gentle kisses from their last session, she let her tongue flick out, just the tip, just a quick, light touch against her pulse point.

Enid's whole body reacted. Her head fell back, her grip on Wednesday's shoulder tightened, and her breath escaped in a soft, surprised "Oh."

"Like that?"

"Exactly like that, keep going."

Wednesday continued, using both her lips and tongue as she slowly traced a path down Enid's throat. As she went, she discovered that kissing the spot where Enid's jaw met her neck made her shiver, while the hollow of her collarbone made her breath catch. When Wednesday pressed her tongue against the base of Enid's throat, Enid let out a soft sound that was somewhere between a sigh and a whimper.

"You're a fast learner," Enid managed, her voice strained. "It's kind of annoying."

"Should I stop?"

"Don't you dare."

Wednesday didn't stop. Instead, she kissed her way back up Enid's throat, moving to her jaw and then to the corner of her mouth. When their lips met again, the kiss was deeper than before, with a growing familiarity that somehow felt both completely new and strangely familiar.

They kissed for what felt like a long time, and Wednesday lost track of it. The rain hammered against the windows, the apartment was warm, and Enid's mouth was soft and wet and demanding. At some point, Wednesday realized her hand had slipped under the hem of Enid's tank top, her palm pressed flat against the bare skin of Enid's waist.

She froze.

"Sorry," she said, pulling back. "I didn't mean—"

"Wednesday." Enid's voice was gentler than she'd ever heard it. "It's okay, that's what we're here for, remember? You're supposed to be learning."

"But I didn't ask."

"You don't have to ask for every single thing." Enid covered Wednesday's hand with hers, keeping it pressed against her skin. "Here's a tip, when you've been making out with someone for like ten minutes and they're making the sounds we've been making, you don't have to ask permission to touch their waist. You just..." She guided Wednesday's hand higher, just an inch. "You just pay attention. If she tenses up, you stop, but if she leans into it..." Enid pressed Wednesday's palm more firmly against her ribs. "You know you're on the right track."

Wednesday's brain felt like it was short-circuiting. Enid was so warm and soft beneath her hands, and the smooth skin of her waist felt almost unreal under Wednesday's fingers. She could feel the slight ridge of Enid's ribcage beneath her touch, along with the steady rise and fall of her breathing.

"I want to try something," Enid said, and there was something new in her voice, something that sounded almost nervous, which was absurd because Enid was never nervous. "I think you're ready, but I need you to listen carefully."

"I'm listening."

"The next thing on the syllabus..." Enid paused, her tongue darting out to wet her lips. "It's breasts."

Wednesday's hand tightened on Enid's waist involuntarily. "Breasts."

"Mine, specifically. You're going to touch them." Enid held up a finger before Wednesday could respond. "But there are rules, important ones, and you're going to follow them because the last thing I want is for this to become weird."

"It's already weird."

"Weirder, then." That earned a small smile from Enid, although her eyes remained serious. "Rule one, I'm going to take off my top, and you're going to look. It's okay to look because that's the point, but you're not going to stare at me like I'm a specimen in a lab. Understand?"

"Don't stare like a specimen, got it."

"Rule two: I'm going to guide your hands, and you're going to do exactly what I show you while paying attention to how I react. If I say 'softer,' you go softer, and if I say 'harder,' you go harder. If I say 'stop,' you stop immediately, no questions, no hurt feelings, and no weirdness."

"No weirdness." Her voice was steadier than she felt.

"Rule three." Enid hesitated, and for a moment, that same flicker of uncertainty crossed her face, the one Wednesday had noticed during their first session when Enid admitted that she cared what people

thought. "Rule three is that after this, we're still just this, whatever this is. We're tutor and student, with no feelings, no awkwardness, and no reading into things. You're learning for Mia, and I'm learning for my B+. A, that's it."

"Right." *Mia, Wednesday had almost forgotten about her again.* "That's it."

"Okay." Enid took a breath and, with a motion so casual that it took Wednesday's brain a full second to register what was happening, pulled her tank top over her head and tossed it onto the floor. It was only then that Wednesday realized Enid wasn't wearing a bra.

Enid was sitting on her couch, half-naked in the soft amber glow of her living room lamp, and Wednesday's ability to form coherent thoughts abruptly ceased to exist.

Her breasts were medium-sized with a gentle, rounded shape, and her fair skin caught the warm lamplight softly. The skin across her chest was slightly paler than the rest of her body, giving it an almost luminous quality. Her nipples were a dusky pink, darker than her lips, and Wednesday noticed with a sudden jolt that they were already firm, making her mouth go dry.

"You're staring," Enid said.

"I'm not—I was—" Wednesday forced her eyes up to Enid's face. "Sorry."

"I told you not to apologize." Enid was smiling, just a little. "You can look, I said you could look, but just don't be weird about it."

"I'm trying very hard not to be weird about it."

"I know." Her smile widened. "It's kind of endearing, actually. Most girls or boys would be trying to grab them by now, but the fact that you're waiting for instructions is honestly refreshing." She tilted her head, looking at Wednesday with an amused expression.

I'm terrified of doing something wrong."

"You won't, I'm not going to let you." Enid reached out and took Wednesday's right hand, the one that had been resting on her waist, then gently lifted it. "First lesson, breasts aren't just there, they're attached to a person, so everything you do should be about her pleasure rather than simply squeezing things. Understand?"

"Understood."

"Good." Enid pressed Wednesday's palm against the curve of her left breast.

Wednesday's entire nervous system lit up like a switchboard.

She was soft, softer than anything Wednesday had ever touched. Her skin was warm and smooth beneath Wednesday's palm, yielding gently to the shape of her hand. Wednesday could feel Enid's heartbeat beneath her touch, faster than it should have been, and the realization that she was affecting Enid too, that this wasn't entirely clinical for her either, sent a rush of heat through Wednesday's chest.

"Don't just hold it," Enid said, her voice slightly rougher than before. "Move your hand gently and cup it, like you're holding something precious."

Wednesday followed her instructions, curving her fingers around Enid's breast. The small, stifled gasp that escaped Enid made Wednesday's pulse quicken.

"Good. Now use your thumb lightly and brush it over the nipple."

Wednesday did as she was told, her thumb moving gently over the sensitive peak while her hand trembled slightly from a mixture of nerves and arousal. Enid's back arched by the smallest amount, pressing her breast more firmly into Wednesday's palm.

“Again,” she breathed.

Wednesday did it again, this time more slowly as she watched Enid’s face for a reaction. Enid’s eyes had gone half-lidded, her lips were parted, and her breathing had changed from steady to slightly ragged. The flush in her cheeks had spread down her neck, making it clear that the touch was affecting her.

“How does that feel?” W ednesday asked, genuinely wanting to know. She needed the information, needed to understand what she was doing right and what she might need to change.

“Really good.” Enid’ s words came out slightly strained. “When you do it lightly like that, it’s sensitive. Too much pressure hurts, but gentle pressure feels good.” She bit her lip before looking back at Wednesday.

“Can I try something?”

Enid opened her eyes fully, the blue in them seeming brighter in the warm light. “What did you have in mind?”

In answer , Wednesday leaned down and pressed her lips to the curve of Enid’s breast, just above where her hand was cupping her . She started with a soft, gentle kiss before letting her tongue flick lightly against the side of Enid’s nipple.

“Oh.” Enid’ s hand immediately moved to the back of Wednesday’s head, her fingers tangling in Wednesday’s hair. “Y es, that, that’s a very good instinct.”

Wednesday repeated the gesture, this time letting her lips close around the sensitive peak and applying gentle pressure, careful not to be too rough or aggressive. It was the same principle Enid had taught her during their kissing lessons, and the reaction it drew from Enid made it clear that she was doing something right.

"Wednesday." Enid's voice came out breathless, almost pleading. "You're doing that thing where you're a fast learner again."

Wednesday pulled back just enough to speak. "Good fast or bad fast?"

"Good, very good." Enid's fingers tightened in Wednesday's hair as she held her gently in place. "Don't stop, just maybe a little softer. There, that's it." She sighed when Wednesday softened her touch. "Perfect, you're doing so well."

The sound Enid made sent a rush of heat through Wednesday, and she realized that she had been aroused for some time. She pushed the thought aside, knowing she could deal with it later. For now, all she could focus on was the warmth of Enid's skin beneath her hand, the sensation of her against her lips, and the small, breathless sounds Enid was trying and failing to suppress.

"Your other hand," Enid managed between breaths. "Don't leave it just sitting there, touch the other one."

Wednesday's left hand rose, trembling slightly, and found Enid's other breast. She used smaller movements this time, mirroring what she had been doing with her right hand as she gently cupped it and brushed her thumb over the nipple. Enid shuddered against her touch.

"The nipples," Enid said, her voice catching slightly on the word. "You can experiment a little, try squeezing them gently with your fingers."

Wednesday's thumb and forefinger found Enid's left nipple, which was still sensitive from the attention of her mouth, and pressed gently as she experimented with the pressure. Enid's hips suddenly bucked, lifting her slightly off the couch, and the unexpected movement brought her body into contact with Wednesday's. Her thigh pressed against the noticeable hardness beneath Wednesday's black trousers.

They both froze.

"Sorry ," Enid said, pulling back slightly . Her face was flushed, her hair mussed, and her chest was rising and falling with rapid breaths. "Reflex, I didn't mean to"—

"It' s fine." Wednesday's voice cracked. "I mean, I'm the one who' s"— She gestured vaguely at her lap.

"Yeah, I noticed," Enid said, sounding more amused than offended. If anything, she seemed almost pleased. "That' s completely normal, and it's healthy too. It just means your body is responding the way it should."

"Good to know my autonomic nervous system is functional."

Enid laughed, a genuine, surprised laugh that made her breasts jiggle slightly , and oh god, Wednesday needed to not look at that right now. "Did you just make a biology joke while you have your hands on my chest?"

"It' s a defense mechanism."

"Your defense mechanism is terrible."

"I'm aware."

The laughter eased some of the tension between them. It didn't disappear completely, but it became less awkward and more playful. Enid reached up and brushed a strand of hair away from Wednesday's forehead, the gesture almost tender.

"You're doing really well," she said quietly . "I mean it. Most people, the first time they touch breasts, just grab and squeeze like they're trying to check fruit for ripeness. You're actually paying attention."

"I have a good teacher ."

"You keep saying that."

t keeps being true."

Enid looked at Wednesday for a long moment, and something complicated flickered in her eyes, something that didnt quite fit the rules they had agreed on. Then it disappeared, replaced by her usual wicked grin.

"Okay , one more technique, and then were done for today . This one's a little more advanced."

"There' s more?"

"Oh, there' s always more."Enid took W ednesday's right hand and guided it back to her left breast. "I showed you how to be gentle, now I want to show you that sometimes a little more pressure can feel good, but you have to work up to it. You cant just start there."

"Build up slowly ."

"Exactly , start gently, then gradually increase the pressure while paying attention to my breathing. If I tense up, ease off, and if I lean into it, youll know youre doing it right."She demonstrated by pressing her breast more firmly into Wednesday's palm.

Wednesday started gently, using soft strokes of her thumb and light squeezes before gradually increasing the pressure. She watched Enid's face closely, paying attention to the flutter of her eyelids and the way her teeth caught her lower lip.

"Keep going,"Enid breathed. "A little more."

"Okay , we should stop,"Enid said suddenly , her voice strained. "I think that's enough for today."

Wednesday immediately pulled her hands back. "Did I hurt you?"

"No, you didnt."Enid took a shaky breath and pressed a palm against her sternum, as if trying to slow her heartbeat. "Y ou didnt do

anything wrong, that's the problem. You did everything very, very right."

"I don't understand."

Enid laughed, but the sound was breathless and slightly wild. "I mean you got me more worked up than I expected, and we have rules. One of those rules is that we don't go past a certain point, so we need to stop here." She reached down, grabbed her discarded tank top, and pulled it over her head. Wednesday noticed that Enid's hands were trembling slightly. "That's enough for today."

"Okay." Wednesday's own voice sounded hoarse, and she cleared her throat. "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine." Enid tugged the tank top into place, then looked back at Wednesday. "I'm just remembering why I made the rules in the first place."

"Because this is a transaction."

"Because this is a transaction." Enid nodded firmly, almost as though she were reassuring herself. "For Mia."

"For Mia," Wednesday echoed.

Neither of them sounded convinced.

Enid stood, but the movement was less steady than usual, as though her legs were still recovering. She picked up their empty tea mugs and carried them to the kitchenette with her back turned to Wednesday, leaving a silence between them that seemed to stretch longer with every second.

Wednesday ran her hands through her hair and tried to remember how to act like a normal person. Her lips felt swollen, and her body was still tense with all the energy she hadn't managed to release.

The taste of Enid's skin lingered on her tongue, something warm and familiar that she couldn't quite put into words.

"So," Wednesday said eventually, unable to tolerate the silence any longer, "next week?"

"Next week." Enid turned around and leaned against the kitchen counter. Most of her composure had returned, although her cheeks were still flushed pink. "We'll review more sociology first, so don't think I'm letting you skip the tutoring portion, and then." She paused before continuing, "Then we'll see."

"See what?"

"See what you're ready for." She crossed her arms under her chest, and Wednesday absolutely did not look at how the motion pushed her breasts up. "You're progressing faster than I planned, we might need to adjust the syllabus."

"Is that a good thing?"

"It's a complicated thing." Enid pushed herself away from the counter and walked toward the door, clearly signaling that the session was over. "Go home, Wednesday. Study your regression analysis, and I'll text you."

Wednesday stood and gathered her folder of notes. Her jeans were still uncomfortably tight, but there was nothing she could do about that except hope the cool rain would help on the walk home.

At the door, Enid paused with her hand resting on the doorknob, but she didn't turn it. For a moment, she simply stood there, as though she had something else to say but couldn't quite bring herself to say it.

"Hey," she said, not quite looking at Wednesday. "For what it's worth, Mia Carter is an idiot if she doesn't notice you."

"I haven't actually talked to her yet."

"I know, but when you do, she's going to be very, very impressed." Enid finally met Wednesday's eyes, then added with a teasing smile, "Assuming you don't grab her breasts like you're checking fruit for ripeness."

Wednesday laughed despite herself. "I'll try to remember that."

"See that you do." Enid opened the door. "Same time next Thursday, and don't be late."

"I'm never late."

Enid gave her a knowing look before stepping aside to let her leave. "I know, it's very annoying." She pushed Wednesday gently into the hallway. "Goodnight, nerdy."

"Goodnight, Enid."

The door closed behind her. Wednesday stood alone in the dingy hallway as rain hammered against the window at the end of the corridor, then pressed her fingers to her lips. They were still tingling, and so was the rest of her body, filled with a low, electric hum that she had absolutely no idea what to do with.

She walked home through the rain, but it did nothing to cool her down.

Chapter End Notes

> Wednesday: I am only doing this for Mia.
>
> Also Wednesday: forgets Mia exists approximately every five minutes.

Chapter 3: Off the Syllabus

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The text message arrived on a Friday afternoon, three days after their last session. Wednesday was sitting in the library at carrel seventeen on the third floor, surrounded by laminated wood and silence, when her phone buzzed against the Formica surface.

E-nid.

She reached for it immediately, far faster than she would have liked to admit.

Party tonight, 9 pm., 1427 Magnolia Ave, wear something that doesn't make you look like you're attending a funeral for your social life, this is lesson four."

Wednesday stared at the screen. A party. Enid wanted her to go to a party. The last party she'd attended had been a mandatory freshman orientation mixer where she'd spent two hours standing beside the punch bowl, pretending to be deeply interested in the chemical composition of fruit juice.

She typed back: *Is this part of the lesson?*

Three dots appeared, disappeared, then appeared again.

Everything is part of the lesson, trust me.

—

1427 Magnolia Avenue was a three-story Victorian that had clearly been converted into student housing sometime during the Reagan administration and had barely been renovated since. The porch

sagged, the paint was peeling, and the bass from whatever speaker system was set up in the living room vibrated through the floorboards and into Wednesday's sternum as she walked up the front steps.

She stopped at the door.

Music pounded from inside, while people spilled onto the porch with red cups in their hands, their voices loud and overlapping. A girl in a sequined top stumbled past her, laughing at something her friend had said, and Wednesday felt the familiar urge to retreat. She could pull out her phone and text Enid that she was sick, that she couldn't make it, that parties simply weren't her thing.

But Enid had said this was a lesson, and Wednesday had never missed a lesson in her life.

She'd followed Enid's instructions, sort of. The oversized hoodie was gone; she'd buried it in the back of her closet like a body she was trying to hide. In its place, she wore a form-fitting black ribbed top that hugged her lean, athletic frame and was tucked into high-waisted black jeans. Bianca had insisted the look made her shoulders look "actually kind of striking, dude," emphasizing the lithe, toned physique she'd developed through years of competitive fencing. She'd even let Bianca style her hair, which involved a little styling cream and far more attention than Wednesday thought necessary. Somehow, Bianca had managed to keep Wednesday's hair neat while giving it just enough texture to make her look less severe and more effortlessly attractive.

She'd left her glasses on her desk, while the contacts she'd bought two years ago and never used sat on her corneas like tiny invaders, making the world look far too sharp without her usual frames to filter it.

Wednesday pushed open the door, and the party hit her like a wall of sensory overload, with music so loud that it vibrated in her teeth, bodies packed into every available space, and the smell of cheap beer, cheaper perfume, and something that might have been weed

drifting in from the back porch. The lights were dim, and the living room was illuminated by a single lamp covered with a red scarf that cast everything in a hellish glow.

She scanned the crowd for Enid but couldn't find her. Then she saw someone else.

"Wednesday?" A surprised female voice came from behind her. "Wednesday Addams?"

She turned to find Mia Carter standing in the kitchen doorway with a red cup in her hand. She wore a green sweater that matched the frames of her glasses, while her hair was pulled back into a low ponytail. Mia was looking at Wednesday with an expression she had never seen directed at her before.

It took her a moment to identify the expression as recognition.

"Mia," she said, relieved that her voice didn't crack. It was progress. "Hey."

"Hey yourself." Mia tilted her head, studying her with the kind of attention Wednesday had only ever dreamed of receiving from her. "You look different, did you get new glasses?"

"Contacts."

"They look good." Mia, Mia Carter smiled at her. "I almost didn't recognize you. You're in my Sociology class, right? Dr. Hendricks?"

"Front row, near the window."

"Right! You're the one who always answers the hard questions. Your paper got used as the example, didn't it?"

Wednesday's brain was doing something complicated. This was the longest conversation she'd ever had with Mia, and she found herself counting the sentences while simultaneously losing track of how many they had exchanged.

"I didn't think anyone noticed that."

"Everyone noticed." Mia took a sip from her cup. "You're kind of the class mystery, super smart, but then you just disappear after the lecture. No one ever sees you at parties."

"I don't usually come to these things."

"Well, I'm glad you came to this one." She gestured toward the living room. "Do you want to—"

"Wednesday! Holy shit, is that you?"

The loud, familiar voice came from somewhere to her left, although Wednesday couldn't immediately place it. She turned and saw Sophie Parker shouldering her way through the crowd toward her. Sophie fenced in the bout next to Wednesday's at the campus club, and with her athletic build and competitive streak, she approached every match as though she were competing professionally.

"Sophie," Wednesday said.

"Hi." Sophie stopped in front of her with a wide grin. "You look completely different. What happened to the hoodie? What happened to the glasses? You got hot."

Wednesday blinked. "I got hot?"

"You got hot. Doesn't she look hot?" Sophie directed the question at Mia, who was still standing beside them with her red cup in hand and looking at Wednesday with an expression she couldn't quite understand.

"I was just saying the same thing," Mia admitted. "Sort of."

"The fencing team has been trying to get this girl to come out for months," Sophie said, clapping Wednesday on the shoulder hard enough to make her stagger. "Best footwork on the squad, and she

never comes to any of the mixers or parties. We thought you were, like, a hermit."

"I'm not a hermit."

"Could've fooled me," Sophie said as she grabbed Wednesday's arm. "Come on, you need a drink."

"I don't really—"

"Non-alcoholic, I know. You're the girl who won't even touch beer, which I respect, honestly. Wish I had that kind of discipline." Sophie was already steering Wednesday toward the kitchen as she continued, "I'll make you something without the fun parts, but you gotta meet some people too. There's this girl on the team named Katie, and she's been asking about you."

"Katie's been asking about me?"

"For weeks, Katie saw you do that series of lunges at practice and said your form was beautiful." Sophie waggled her eyebrows. "I think Katie wants to see your form up close."

Wednesday glanced back over her shoulder and saw Mia still watching her, her expression somewhere between amusement and something else that looked almost like disappointment.

Sophie pulled Wednesday into the kitchen before she could say anything, and the crowd swallowed Wednesday whole.

—

From her position on the staircase landing, Enid watched the entire scene unfold.

Enid had spotted Wednesday the moment Wednesday walked through the door. She had been looking for the familiar slump of Wednesday's shoulders, the hoodie, the glasses, and the way

Wednesday usually moved through crowds as though she were trying to make herself invisible.

What Enid saw instead made her jaw drop.

The woman standing in the doorway was nothing like the shy, hidden girl Enid had been tutoring on her couch for the past three weeks. Wednesday stood taller with her shoulders back, her hair artfully messy and falling across her forehead in a way that made Enid's fingers itch with the urge to push it back. The black top hugged Wednesday's frame, revealing the muscles Enid had known were hiding beneath the hoodies but had never realized looked quite like that. Wednesday had a fencer's build, lean, toned, and poised, while her jaw looked sharper without the glasses and her eyes somehow seemed darker and more intense without the lenses between them.

Wednesday was hot, and Enid suddenly had no idea what to do with that realization.

Enid gripped the banister and tried to process what she was seeing. She had called Wednesday cute before;on the first day in the library , Enid had admitted that Wednesday wasnt bad-looking, and she had even poked Wednesday's bicep and commented on her bone structure, but all of that had felt clinical, like a teacher assessing raw material.

This was different, Enid was watching Wednesday Addams walk into a party looking like she had stepped straight out of a magazine spread, and something twisted in Enid's stomach that was definitely, absolutely not clinical.

Then Mia Carter appeared, and Wednesday actually talked to her without stammering, blushing, or fleeing. Wednesday made her smile, and Wednesday made her laugh.

Enid was supposed to be happy about that because helping Wednesday get Mia's attention was the goal, the whole point of the lessons. Instead, Enid felt a sharp, hot spike of something that was

becoming increasingly difficult to deny, something that felt disturbingly like jealousy.

"Get a grip," she muttered to herself, and a passing guy in a frat tank top gave her a confused look. She ignored him.

Enid watched Sophie drag Wednesday into the kitchen, then watched Wednesday accept a cup of soda and start talking to a group of fencers who gathered around her as if Wednesday had always been one of them. When Wednesday laughed at something someone said, tilting her head back and exposing her throat, and fuck, had her throat always looked like that?

Enid needed to text her.

She pulled out her phone and typed: *Upstairs, third door on the left. Time for a lesson.*

—

Wednesday's phone buzzed in her pocket twenty minutes into her conversation with the other girls. She'd met Katie, the one who'd been asking about her form, a girl with a sharp wit and a handshake that was surprisingly firm, and she'd talked to three other teammates whose names she was trying to remember. She'd discovered that Sophie had a surprisingly encyclopedic knowledge of early 2000s pop music, a topic on which Wednesday had absolutely nothing to contribute but was content to listen.

She'd also discovered that nobody seemed to find her weird. Nobody looked at her like she was a nerd who'd wandered into the wrong ecosystem. They talked to her like she belonged, and after a while, she'd stopped feeling like an impostor and started feeling like maybe, maybe, she actually did.

At some point, Katie excused herself from the group, saying she needed to use the bathroom, and disappeared into the crowd.

A few minutes later, the text from Enid made Wednesday's stomach clench.

Upstairs, third door on the left. Time for a lesson.

She excused herself from the group. Sophie made a comment about her "probably sneaking off to find Katie," and Wednesday let her think that because it was easier than explaining the truth.

The stairs creaked under her feet as Wednesday climbed to the second floor, where the music had faded to a dull throb and a single flickering bulb lit the hallway. She counted the doors on the left until she reached the third one.

She knocked, and the door opened almost immediately. Enid stood in the doorway, and for a moment, neither of them spoke.

Enid was wearing a short black dress with thin straps and a neckline that plunged deep enough to make Wednesday's eyes perform their familiar emergency evacuation. Her fair skin stood out against the black dress, while her blonde hair fell in soft honey waves around her shoulders. Her blue eyes looked even brighter against the dark outfit, and her lips were painted a shade of red that matched the scarf draped over the lamp in the living room.

What caught Wednesday off guard was Enid's expression. Enid was looking at Wednesday like she had never seen Wednesday before, as if she were cataloguing every difference, the black top, the hair, the absence of glasses and coming to conclusions Wednesday hadn't expected.

"You're wearing contacts," Enid said finally.

"You told me to dress differently."

"I didn't tell you to look like that." She waved a hand at her, a gesture that seemed to encompass her entire physical existence. "This is—

you're not supposed to." She stopped and took a breath. "Get in here."

Wednesday stepped inside. The bedroom was small, clearly someone's personal space that had been temporarily surrendered for party overflow, with a twin bed pushed against the wall, a desk covered in textbooks, a poster of some band Wednesday didn't recognize, and a lamp on the nightstand casting the room in amber light.

Enid closed the door behind her, and the music from downstairs became a distant memory.

"So," she said, turning to face her. "How's the party going?"

"God, I think. I talked to Mia."

Her expression flickered. "You did?"

"For like five minutes, she said she was glad I came and that I looked different. Everyone keeps saying that."

"Because you do." Enid crossed her arms under her chest. "You look completely different. I didn't." She stopped and started again. "I didn't expect it when you walked in, and I almost didn't recognize you. You looked like you belonged there, like you were one of them."

"Isn't that the point?"

"Yes," Enid said, the word coming out sharper than she intended before she softened her voice. "Yes, that's the point. You're doing well, and you're doing really well. I'm impressed."

Something warm bloomed in Wednesday's chest. "Thanks."

"Don't thank me yet." Enid moved toward the bed, sitting on the edge with her legs crossed, and the dress rode up on her thighs. "Tonight's lesson is different. Up until now, everything we've practiced has been in a controlled environment, my apartment, with

no distractions or variables."She gestured at the room around them. "This is not a controlled environment. There's a party happening right downstairs, there are people everywhere, and there's noise and chaos and all the things that make real-world situations complicated."

"So what's the lesson?"

"The lesson is that you have to be able to perform under pressure." She looked up at her, and in the amber lamplight, her green eyes seemed to glow. "When you're actually with someone, when it's real, you can't just freeze up because there's music playing or people in the next room. You have to be present and focused, and you have to be able to tune everything else out."

Wednesday's pulse had started its familiar acceleration. "And we're going to practice that."

"We're going to practice that."Enid patted the bed beside her. "Sit."

Wednesday sat down, and the mattress dipped under her weight, bringing them closer together as Enid's perfume, something floral this time instead of the vanilla from before, filled her senses.

"Here's what I want you to do,"Enid said. "I want you to kiss me like you mean it, like there's no one else in the house. Forget the party, forget the music, forget Mia Carter downstairs, and focus on this room, on me, on what you're feeling right now."

"Just kiss you?"

"For starters,"she said, as that wicked grin flickered across her lips. "And then I want you to follow your instincts, everything I've taught you, you've practiced it. Now I want to see what you do when I'm not giving you step-by-step instructions."

Wednesday's throat went dry. "What if my instincts are bad?"

"Your instincts aren't bad." Enid reached up and touched Wednesday's face, her fingers tracing the line of Wednesday's jaw. "I've seen you. You're a fast learner, so trust yourself."

Wednesday leaned in, and the kiss started softly, their lips meeting the way Enid had taught Wednesday, gentle and questioning. Enid's mouth tasted like cherry lip gloss, something sweet, artificial, and addictive, while Enid's hand slid from Wednesday's jaw to the back of Wednesday's neck, her fingers threading into Wednesday's hair and tugging gently, until Wednesday stopped thinking and simply let herself follow the moment.

She deepened the kiss, her tongue tracing the seam of Enid's lips and asking permission, which Enid granted with a soft sigh. Wednesday's hand found Enid's waist, the same motion she had practiced twice now, but this time she didn't hesitate. Her palm pressed flat against the curve of Enid's hip, her fingers curling into the thin fabric of Enid's dress.

"God," Enid breathed against her mouth. "Keep going."

Wednesday kissed the corner of Enid's mouth, then her jaw and the spot behind Enid's ear that she had discovered made Enid shiver. Wednesday used her tongue in light flicks, the way Enid had taught her and the way she knew Enid liked, and felt Enid's body respond as her back arched and her grip on Wednesday's hair tightened.

"Your instincts are very good," Enid managed, her voice strained.

"Shh." Wednesday pressed her lips to Enid's throat, just below her ear. "You said no instructions."

A surprised laugh escaped Enid. "Did you just shush me?"

"I did." Wednesday kissed down the column of Enid's neck, slow and deliberate. "Is that a problem?"

"No. No, that's oh." Enid's head fell back as Wednesday's tongue found the hollow of her collarbone. "That's definitely not a problem."

Wednesday's hands moved, with one staying on Enid's waist to hold her steady while the other slid up Enid's back, fingers splaying across her spine and pressing her closer. Wednesday realized then that the dress was backless, or nearly backless, with the fabric dipping low enough for her palm to meet bare skin. Enid was warm, so warm that her muscles tensed beneath Wednesday's touch before relaxing as her body melted into Wednesday's.

"That's it," Enid murmured. "That's you're doing exactly what you should be doing."

"I thought I said no instructions."

"You also said you weren't going to be good at this."

"I'm learning from the best."

Enid pulled back just enough to look at Wednesday. Enid's lip gloss was smeared, her cheeks were flushed, and her breathing was ragged, her chest rising and falling in quick, shallow movements that made the neckline of her dress strain against her breasts.

"Wednesday," she said, and the name on her lips sounded different now, less like a teacher addressing a student and more like something else.

"Yeah?"

"I want to try something." Enid shifted on the bed, turning to face Wednesday more fully as her knee pressed against Wednesday's thigh. "I want to see what happens when we stop following the syllabus."

Wednesday's heart hammered against her ribs. "What does that mean?"

t means..."Enid bit her lip before continuing. "I want you to touch me, not because I'm teaching you and not because it's a lesson, but because you want to, and because I want you to."

The words hung in the air between them, and Wednesday's brain, or the part of it that was still functioning, screamed that this was dangerous territory and that it violated the rules, the transaction, and the agreement they had made.

But Enid was looking at Wednesday with those gold-flecked eyes, her lips parted and her hand resting on Wednesday's chest, while the party downstairs had faded into a distant thrum that felt as though it were happening in another dimension entirely.

"I want to," Wednesday said.

"Then do it."

She kissed Enid again, deeper and hungrier this time. Wednesday's hands found the zipper of Enid's dress at the side, just under her arm, and she paused with her fingers hovering over the tab.

"Keep going," Enid whispered. "Trust yourself."

Wednesday pulled the zipper down, and the dress loosened as the straps slipped off Enid's shoulders. Enid shrugged out of it with a practiced ease that suggested she had done this before, but never quite like this. The black fabric pooled around her waist, leaving her torso bare.

She wasn't wearing a bra again, but this time it didn't feel like a lesson; it felt like a choice.

"You're staring," Enid said, but her voice was soft, almost shy, an emotion Wednesday had never associated with Enid before.

"I'm admiring."

"That's a good word. I like that word."

Wednesday reached out and cupped Enid’s breast. The motion was familiar now, the soft weight, the warmth, and the way Enid’s nipple tightened under her palm, but it felt different this time, charged and electric. Enid sighed and leaned into the touch, her eyes fluttering closed.

“Y our hands,” she breathed. “Y our hands are~~mm~~mh.”

Wednesday had brushed her thumb over Enid’s nipple, barely touching it, just as Enid had taught her , and Enid’s whole body shuddered in response.

“W ednesday.” Her name came out as a gasp. “More.”

Wednesday understood as her mouth found Enid’s other breast, the one she wasn’t touching, and her lips closed around the tight peak. She used gentle suction, her tongue circling in the way that made Enid arch into her. Enid’s hands were in Wednesday’s hair now, holding her in place, while the sounds she made escalated from soft sighs to something closer to moans.

“Nghh~~y~~es.” The words came out broken, fractured by her ragged breathing. “Right there~~d~~on’t stop”—

Wednesday didn’t stop. She switched sides, her mouth finding the other nipple while her hand slid down Enid’s stomach, tracing the line of her waist and the curve of her hip. The dress was still bunched around Enid’s middle, and her thighs were pressed together, the tension in them clear in the way her muscles remained tightly coiled as though she were holding herself back.

“What do you want?” W ednesday asked, pulling back just enough to speak.

Enid opened her eyes. They were dark, her pupils blown wide and the gold flecks nearly swallowed by black. “I want”—~~S~~he stopped and swallowed before continuing. “I want you to keep going, whatever you’re thinking and whatever your instincts tell you.”

Wednesday's instincts told her to press closer, guide Enid back onto the bed, and settle herself between Enid's thighs, just as she had read about and imagined countless times but had never experienced.

Wednesday followed her instincts.

Enid's back hit the mattress, and she made a sound that was half surprise, half approval as her hair spread out around her like a halo. The dress was still rucked around her waist, leaving her lower half covered while her upper body remained exposed, her breasts bare and her chest heaving, with a flush of pink spreading from her cheeks down to her sternum.

Wednesday positioned herself above Enid, her knees on either side of Enid's hips and her hands braced against the mattress. The position brought their bodies into an entirely new alignment, with Enid's thighs bracketing Wednesday's and the heat of Enid's core pressing against the hardness straining against the front of Wednesday's jeans.

"Oh." Enid's eyes went wide. "That's ~~yo~~ure—"

"Is this okay?"

"Yes. Yes, that's—" Enid shifted beneath her, and the movement brought her hips into direct contact with Wednesday's erection. They both froze for a moment before Enid deliberately moved again, slowly rolling her pelvis in a way that made Wednesday's vision narrow to a pinpoint.

"Shit," Wednesday breathed.

"That's it." Enid's hands came up to grip Wednesday's shoulders. "That's ~~do~~ that again, move against me."

Wednesday moved, letting instinct take over with a primal, wordless rhythm that her body understood even as her brain struggled to

catch up. She rocked against Enid, who met her with an answering roll of her hips, and the friction was maddening, the layers of denim and cotton between them simultaneously too much and not enough.

"Ohfuck"The word tore out of Enid' s throat, rough and desperate, and it was the sexiest thing Wednesday had ever heard. "Nghright thereyes"—

Wednesday's mouth found Enid's neck again, then her collarbone and her breasts, which were still sensitive and peaked. She sucked a nipple into her mouth while her hips kept moving, grinding against Enid in a rhythm that was building toward something she couldnt name.

Enid's hands were everywhere, tangled in Wednesday's hair, sliding over her back, and clutching at her black top as though she wanted to tear it off. Her legs wrapped around Wednesday's waist, pulling her closer and pressing her harder against her, while the sounds escaping her had escalated into an almost constant stream of broken syllables.

"AhhahyesW ednesdayplease"—

Wednesday didnt know what Enid was begging for , or whether Enid even knew herself. All Wednesday knew was the heat of Enid's body beneath her, the rhythm of their hips moving together, the desperate clutch of Enid's fingers, and the way Enid's head had fallen back, her mouth open and her eyes sqeezed shut.

"Nghhdont stopdont stopplease"—

She was saying Wednesday's name, not the nerdy nickname or the teasing one, but simply Wednesday, and hearing it from Enid's lips felt different somehow.

Then Enid's body went rigid beneath her, her back arching off the mattress as a cry tore from her throat, half scream and half sob.

“Ahhhhfuckfuckyes”—

She shattered, and Wednesday felt it in the way Enid’s muscles seized, her hips bucked against Wednesday’s, and her whole body trembled and shook. Enid’s fingers dug into Wednesday’s shoulders hard enough to leave bruises, while her breath came in ragged gasps. Her face, beautiful, flushed, and completely unguarded, was the most incredible thing Wednesday had ever seen.

Wednesday kept moving, slower and gentler now, riding out the aftershocks with Enid while her own body remained wound tight and aching, though some distant part of her brain recognized that this moment wasn’t about her.

This was about Enid.

Slowly, Enid’s breathing steadied, and her grip on Wednesday’s shoulders loosened. When she opened her eyes, they were wet, not quite with tears, but with something close to them, something overwhelmed.

“Wednesday,” she whispered. “That was—Ididn’t”—

“Are you okay?”

“I’m”—She blinked, and a single tear escaped the corner of her eye, tracing a path down her temple and into her hair. “I’m really, really okay. That was—Iwasn’t expecting that.”

“Was that wrong?” Wednesday was suddenly terrified. “Did I do something wrong?”

“No. No, no, no.” Enid reached up and cupped Wednesday’s face in both hands. “You didn’t do anything wrong. You did everything right, so ridiculously right that I just came from dry humping a stranger on a party bed.”

The vulgarity of the statement hit Wednesday like a splash of cold water. "You came?"

"You didn't notice?" A laugh bubbled out of Enid, slightly hysterical. "It was not subtle."

"I thought I wasn't sure"—

"Well, now you're sure." She pulled Wednesday's face down to hers and kissed her, soft and gentle, completely unlike the desperate grinding that had preceded it. "Congratulations. You just gave me an orgasm without even taking your pants off."

Wednesday's face was so hot she was surprised it didn't spontaneously combust. "That's—is that a good thing?"

"That's a very good thing." Enid kissed her again. "In fact, you might be a little too good at this."

"Too good?"

"Too good." She pushed gently against Wednesday's chest, and Wednesday rolled off her, sprawling across the mattress beside her. Above them, the ceiling was water-stained, a brown ring spreading outward from the light fixture. Enid stared at it for a long moment before saying, "I'm supposed to be teaching you. You're not supposed to be giving me orgasms."

"You're the one who said to follow my instincts."

"Instincts." Enid repeated the word and laughed again, this time more genuinely and without the earlier hysteria. "And my instincts were to let you keep going, so apparently my instincts are also very good."

Wednesday turned her head to look at her. Enid was still half-naked, her dress bunched around her waist and her breasts bare. The flush on her skin was fading, but her cheeks were still pink and her lips still

swollen. She looked—W ednesday searched for the right word—wrecked, beautiful, and somehow hers.

No, she reminded herself that Enid wasn't hers, because that was the rule.

"Hey ," W ednesday said. "What about the rules?"

Enid was quiet for a moment before turning onto her side and propping her head up with one hand. "I think," she said slowly , "that the rules might need some adjustments."

"What kind of adjustments?"

"The kind where we acknowledge that this is maybe slightly more than just a transaction." She held up a hand before W ednesday could respond. "Not feelings. Not—not anything romantic. Don't look at me like that. I just mean, you're good at this, I'm good at this, and we're good at this. If we're going to keep going, if we're going to keep doing these sessions, maybe it's okay if they're a little more mutual."

"Mutual."

"Mutual, equal, with both of us getting something out of it." Her gaze dropped to Wednesday's lap, where the evidence of her arousal was still painfully obvious beneath her jeans. "Speaking of which, you didn't finish, did you?"

It wasn't a question, and W ednesday shook her head.

"Do you want to"—

"Y ou don't have to"—

"I know I don't have to." Enid sat up, pulling her dress straps back over her shoulders. The zipper was still undone, and the fabric gaped slightly at her side, exposing a sliver of her torso. "But you

made me feel good, really good, and Iwant to return the favor .”She paused before adding, f you want me to.”

Wednesday’s throat had gone completely dry. fwant you to.”

"Then take of f your pants.”

The instruction was delivered with the same casual authority Enid used when explaining standard deviation, as though it were the most natural thing in the world and they were still in her apartment, following the syllabus and keeping everything clinical and professional but her eyes were dark, her lips were still swollen, and the air between them crackled with the residue of what had jst happened.

Wednesday sat up and reached for her belt.

Downstairs, the party raged on, completely unaware of what was happening in the third bedroom on the left.

Chapter End Notes

Enid: "This is a lesson.”

Also Enid, five minutes later: fthink the rules might need some adjstments.”

Yeah. Ithink the syllabus is in trouble.

Chapter 4: The Rules Change

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Wednesday's hands hovered at her belt buckle as the moment stretched, her fingers trembling slightly while Enid watched from her half-reclined position against the headboard. Enid's dress was still unzipped, with one strap sliding off her shoulder, and the music from downstairs thumped through the floorboards like a distant heartbeat.

"You're stalling," she said.

"I'm processing."

"You're overthinking, same thing." Enid reached out and hooked a finger through one of Wednesday's belt loops, tugging her closer. The motion was casual and practiced, but Enid's eyes were darker than Wednesday had ever seen them. "Here's the thing about reciprocation: it works better when the pants are off."

Wednesday's fingers finally cooperated as she undid the buckle, then the button and zipper. She lifted her hips and shoved the jeans down, letting the denim pool around her knees before she kicked it unceremoniously onto the floor. Her boxer briefs were black cotton, and the outline of her erection was unmistakable beneath the fabric.

Enid's gaze dropped, and her lips parted.

"Well," she said, her voice slightly hoarse. "Hello there."

"Is that a good hello or a bad hello?"

"Good, very good." Enid sat up straighter, her bare breasts shifting with the motion, and Wednesday had to consciously remind herself not to stare. "Boxers off too, unless you want them to get messy."

The implication of messy sent a jolt straight through her, and Wednesday hooked her thumbs into the waistband of her boxer briefs and pulled them down, freeing her cock.

She had never really thought about it in objective terms, but seeing it now, fully aroused and pulsing, she couldn't help but be mesmerized. It wasn't just "above average"—it was imposing. As she looked closer, she realized it was a staggering eight or nine inches of hard, rigid muscle, stretching far beyond what she had ever expected.

Uncut and glistening, the head was flushed a deep, bruised pink, almost red, with a heavy bead of clear fluid already gathered at the tip, shimmering under the light. The shaft curved slightly upward, a predatory angle that promised to hit every sensitive spot perfectly. Enid's eyes traced every detail, her breath hitching as she followed the prominent, thick vein that throbbed along the underside, winding its way up the length of the massive organ. It looked almost too large to be real, a heavy, heat-radiating weight that made her feel small and desperately needy just by looking at it.

"See," Enid said, reaching out but not quite touching. "I knew you were hiding something under those terrible boxers, those strong thighs and a nice cock. You've been holding out on everyone on this campus."

Wednesday's face burned. "I haven't been holding out. I've been"—

"Invisible, I know." Enid's fingers brushed the inside of Wednesday's thigh, feather-light. "We're fixing that, but first" She patted the mattress beside her. "Lie down on your back."

She obeyed, and the cheap cotton sheets felt slightly scratchy against her bare legs. The ceiling was water-stained, and somewhere in the house, someone dropped a glass, followed by a chorus of voices shouting "Opa!" like they were at a Greek wedding.

Enid positioned herself beside Wednesday, sitting cross-legged with her dress still bunched around her waist. She looked down at

Wednesday with an expression that was half teacher and half predator.

"Here' s how this is going to work," she said. "I'm going to suck your cock, and you're going to let me. If something feels good, you tell me; if something feels bad, you tell me, and if you're about to cum, you definitely tell me." She paused. "Some girls don't like it in their mouth, I'm not one of those girls, but I still want a warning, a courtesy tap on the shoulder, a verbal announcement, something. Okay?"

"Okay ."

"W ords, Wednesday, use your words."

"Y es, okay-I'll tell you."

"Good girl." Enid ran her palm up W ednesday's thigh, watching her face. "Y ou really do like that phrase, don't you? Your whole body just does this" She mimicked a small shiver . "V ery interesting."

"I'm not—it's not—"

"It's fine, everyone has things." Enid leaned down and pressed a kiss to Wednesday's hipbone. "Now stop talking because I'm going to start."

Her mouth traced a path across Wednesday's stomach with soft kisses and light flicks of her tongue. She worked her way downward with the same maddening patience she had taught Wednesday to use, teasing her, pulling back, and making her wait. Wednesday's abdominal muscles tensed beneath her lips, and her breathing had gone shallow and ragged.

"Y ou're so tense," Enid murmured against her skin. "Relax, this is supposed to feel good."

"It does feel good that' s the problem."

"There's no problem, just" Enid licked a stripe along the crease of her thigh, and Wednesday's hips bucked involuntarily. "Enjoy it."

Her hand wrapped around the base of Wednesday's cock, the contact was electric. Enid's palm was warm, her grip loose but deliberate, and when she gave an experimental stroke from base to tip, slow and easy, Wednesday's head fell back against the pillow with a sound that was somewhere between a groan and a whimper.

"Oh."

"There we go." Enid did it again, slower and tighter. The bead of pre-cum at the tip smeared across her thumb, and she made a small sound of approval. "You're already so wet, that's hot."

"Ngh."

"Words, baby."

"Fuck." The word tore out of Wednesday before she could stop it.

"Better." Enid shifted position, swinging one leg over Wednesday's thigh so she could lean closer to her work. Her hair fell forward, brushing against Wednesday's stomach, while the scent of her, floral perfume, skin, and arousal, filled Wednesday's senses. "Now, the basics, a handjob is like anything else. It's about variety, rhythm, and paying attention." Enid stroked her again, faster this time, her grip tightening on the downstroke. "Too tight?"

"No it's good, really good."

"Good." Enid loosened her grip and slowed down. "Variety, see? Fast and tight feels good, but if I do it for too long, it gets overwhelming, so I switch it up and keep you guessing."

Her thumb circled the head of Wednesday's cock, spreading the moisture there, and Wednesday's vision blurred at the edges. Enid was watching her face now, cataloguing every reaction. When her

eyes fluttered closed, Enid squeezed gently at the base. When her jaw clenched, she traced the prominent vein along the underside with her thumbnail.

"You can touch me," Enid said. "Did you know that? A lot of girls and boys just lie there like dead fish, but you can touch me like my hair, shoulders, whatever feels natural."

Wednesday's hand found her hair, and the honey-blonde strands slipped through her fingers like water. She didn't pull or guide her, just held on as though anchoring herself.

"God, that's..." Enid leaned down and pressed her lips to the tip of Wednesday's cock, giving her a soft, almost chaste kiss. "That's nice, just like that."

Then she took her into her mouth.

The heat was the first thing Wednesday registered, wet and warm and impossibly soft. Enid's lips closed around the head, and her tongue moved against the underside in a complicated pattern Wednesday couldn't identify. The sensation was so overwhelming that her brain simply stopped forming words.

"Oh—god—"

Enid pulled back with a wet, slick sound. "You still with me?"

"Barely."

"Good." Her grin was wicked, her lips already glossed with saliva and pre-cum. "Because I'm just getting started."

Her mouth descended again, deeper this time. She took her halfway, and the sensation of her throat, the tightness, the heat, and the way she swallowed around her, made Wednesday's hips buck upward. Enid made a small choking sound and pulled back, her eyes watering slightly.

"Sorry—sorry—"

"Don't be sorry." Enid wiped her mouth with the back of her hand. "You're excited. It's flattering, but try not to thrust, okay? Let me control the depth. You control the sounds."

"The sounds?"

"I want to hear you, I want to know what feels good." Enid stroked her lazily while she talked, her hand moving in a loose fist from base to tip. "You're always so quiet, so controlled. I want to hear you fall apart, can you do that for me?"

"I—I don't know if I can—"

"We'll see." Enid lowered her head again.

This time, when her mouth closed around her, she didn't stop at halfway. She took her deeper, slowly and carefully, her hand working what she couldn't fit. Her tongue pressed flat against the underside of the shaft while her other hand cupped Wednesday's balls, gentle and barely there. The combination of sensations was so intense that Wednesday made a sound she'd never made before in her life, a low, broken moan that was completely involuntary.

"Yes." The word vibrated against Wednesday's skin as Enid pulled back, her lips slick and swollen. "Like that. More of that."

Her mouth found her again and again as Enid built a rhythm that wasn't fast or frantic but steady and deliberate. Her head bobbed, her hand twisted, and her tongue traced patterns on the sensitive underside. Every time she pulled back, she made a wet, obscene sound that Wednesday felt in her teeth.

"Oh—fuck—Enid—"

Enid hummed in acknowledgement, and the vibration went straight through Wednesday as her fingers tightened in Enid's hair. Her hips

wanted to thrust, but she forced them still.

"You taste so good," Enid murmured, pulling off with a wet pop. "I knew you would, all those weeks of watching you be so polite and proper, I knew you'd taste like this." She pressed a kiss to the tip, then another to the shaft. "Tell me how it feels, use your words."

"Amazing. It feels—I can't—"

"You can. Try."

"Your mouth." Wednesday was panting now, her chest heaving and her abdominal muscles tight. "It's so warm, so wet. When you do that thing with your tongue—oh fuck—"

Enid did it again, pressing the flat of her tongue hard against the frenulum while her lips created suction. The dual sensation was so intense that Wednesday's vision literally whited out for a moment.

"That thing?" Enid was grinning, and Wednesday could hear it in her voice. "God to know, anything else?"

"The—when you take me deeper. I can feel your throat, it's so tight."

"Mmmh, you like that?"

"Yes. God, yes."

"I'll remember that for next time." Enid stroked her slowly, watching her face. "You're getting close, aren't you? I can tell. Your breathing's changed, your thighs are trembling, and you're doing that thing with your jaw where you're trying to hold on."

"I'm—trying to—"

"Don't hold on." Enid lowered her mouth again. "I want you to let yourself go." Her lips brushed the head of the cock. "Will you do that for me?"

"Yes."

"God girl."

Enid took her deep, her mouth relentless as she sucked and licked while her hand worked in tandem with her lips. She hollowed her cheeks and created suction that made Wednesday's toes curl, then pulled back to trace the ridge of the corona with the tip of her tongue. She took her deep enough that her nose pressed against Wednesday's pubic bone, and the wet sounds of her throat working around her filled the small bedroom like something pornographic.

Wednesday's control was unraveling, her hand trembling in Enid's hair as her hips made small, involuntary thrusts that Enid didnt seem to mind. The pressure was building deep in Wednesday's belly and spreading outward like a gathering storm that she couldnt have stopped even if she had tried.

"Nghh Enid Imm going to"—

Enid pulled back just enough to speak. "Go ahead, come for me. I want to taste you."

Enid's mouth sealed over the head, and her wicked, clever tongue pressed hard against the frenulum, sending Wednesday over the edge.

The orgasm hit Wednesday like a freight train. "Ahhh fuck fuck"— The sounds tore out of her, raw and broken, completely beyond her control. Her back arched off the mattress as her hand fisted in Enid's hair, her thighs shook, and her hips bucked while the world dissolved into white-hot pulses of pleasure that seemed to go on forever.

Throughout it, Enid stayed close, swallowing and continuing to stroke Wednesday through the aftershocks, her movements gentle now as she helped Wednesday come back down.

When the pulses finally stopped and the last shudder rippled through Wednesday's body, her muscles went slack. Enid pulled back slowly and carefully, then pressed a kiss to the inside of Wednesday's thigh.

Wednesday lay there panting and staring at the water-stained ceiling, her brain apparently having vacated the premises entirely.

"Holy shit," she breathed.

"Holy shit," Enid agreed.

Enid wiped her mouth with the back of her hand, then licked her lips, a gesture that was simultaneously obscene and oddly elegant. She caught the smear at the corner of her mouth with her thumb and cleaned it away.

"You taste good," Enid said. "Clean and mild, not like battery acid and regret, which is what I was half expecting."

"Thanks. I think."

"It's a compliment, take it." Enid swung her leg off Wednesday's thigh and settled beside her on the bed, her shoulder brushing hers. "How do you feel?"

"Like my soul just left my body and is currently hovering somewhere near the ceiling fan."

"Good answer." Enid laughed, the sound warm and genuine enough to make something in Wednesday's chest constrict. "You did really well, I mean it. You communicated, you let yourself make noise, and you didn't try to face-fuck me. For a first blowjob, that was an A-plus performance."

"I feel like I should be the one grading you."

"Oh, I know I'm good. This isn't about me." Enid propped herself up on one elbow and looked down at Wednesday. Her dress was still unzipped, her hair was a mess, and her lipstick was completely

gone, leaving her lips swollen and pink. She had never looked more beautiful. "You're a fast learner, Wednesday. Every time. It's genuinely impressive."

"I have a good teacher."

"You keep saying that."

"It keeps being true."

Silence settled between them, comfortable and almost intimate. The party downstairs had shifted into a slower song, something with a heavy bass line that vibrated through the floorboards. Wednesday's breathing had steadied, but her body still felt loose and liquid, as though she had been untethered from gravity.

Enid was still looking at her, her expression softened into something Wednesday couldn't quite name.

"What?" she asked.

"Nothing, just." Enid reached out and brushed a strand of hair off Wednesday's forehead. The gesture was unexpectedly tender. "You're different than I thought you'd be."

"Different how?"

"I don't know...sweeter, more genuine?" Enid pulled her hand back, her brow furrowing slightly. "Most people, after they finish, they're done. They roll over and stop thinking about the other person but you asked me if I was okay after I came, and you didn't even think about yourself until I brought it up. That's not nothing."

Wednesday didn't know what to say to that. The silence stretched, and Enid seemed to realize she had revealed something she hadn't intended to. Her expression shuttered, and the wicked grin flickered back into place.

"Okay, enough emotional honesty. You need to go back downstairs."

"What?"

"The party is still happening. Your new fencing friends are probably wondering where you went." Enid sat up fully, tugging her dress strap back onto her shoulder. "The whole point of tonight was to build your social confidence. You can't do that if you're hiding in a bedroom with me."

"I wasn't hiding. You texted me."

"And now I'm un-texting you, figuratively." Enid gestured toward the door. "Go mingle, talk to people, and talk to Mia. Use some of that confidence you just demonstrated in this bed."

Wednesday sat up slowly, her legs still feeling like jelly. Her black underwear and jeans were in a heap on the floor, and her body was still slick and sensitive. "I don't know if I can just walk out there and be charming."

"You don't have to be charming, you just have to be present." Enid found Wednesday's underwear and tossed them at her chest. "Social skills are like any other skill, they require practice and repetition, and you can't build them if you're only ever alone with me."

Wednesday pulled on her underwear, then her jeans. The denim felt rough against her hypersensitive skin. "What about you?"

"I'm going to stay here for a bit, fix my face, and let my legs stop shaking." Enid gave her a look. "You did a number on me earlier, don't think I forgot."

"Should I apologize?"

"Absolutely not." Enid reached up and zipped her dress, the fabric sliding back into place. "Go mingle and be charming. I'll find you before I leave."

Wednesday stood, but her belt was still undone, and she fumbled with it for a moment before Enid batted her hands away and buckled it herself.

"There," she said, patting W ednesday's chest. "Presentable, now go."

Wednesday moved toward the door, then paused with her hand on the knob. "Enid?"

"Y eah?"

"Thank you for everything." W ednesday gestured vaguely at the bed, at Enid, and at the room.

Enid smiled, not the wicked grin or the predatory smirk, but a small, genuine, slightly crooked smile. "Y oure welcome, nerdy . Now get out of my temporary bedroom and go be a functional human being."

Wednesday opened the door, and the music from downstairs swelled to fill the hallway as she stepped out into the noise and chaos, her body still humming with the aftershocks of her orgasm. The door clicked shut behind her.

She stood in the hallway for a moment, running her hands through her hair and trying to remember how to interact with people who hadnt just seen her naked, then descended the stairs as they creaked beneath her feet.

The party was still in full swing, with the red-scarfed lamp casting its hellish glow over the packed living room, where people were dancing, talking, and drinking. Sophie was in the kitchen, gesturing enthusiastically about something while a girl in a seqined top laughed at whatever she was saying.

Katie, one of the girls from the fencing club, spotted her first.

“Wednesday!” Katie waved, motioning her over. “There you are, we thought you bailed.”

“No. Just—Wednesday searched for an excuse. “Bathroom.”

“For like thirty minutes? You okay?”

“Fine, just phone call.”

Katie accepted this with a shrug. “Well, come here. Sophie’s trying to explain the plot of some movie from like 2005 and she’s getting it completely wrong.”

“I am not getting it wrong!” Sophie’s voice carried over the music. “You’re just not appreciating the nuanced commentary on suburban ennui!”

“Suburban what-now?” The girl in the sequined top looked genuinely confused.

Wednesday found herself drifting toward the group. Her body still felt strange loose and relaxed and slightly disconnected, like she was piloting a version of herself that was slightly out of sync but the girls didn’t seem to notice. They made space for her in their circle, handed her a cup of soda, and resumed their argument about the movie.

She didn’t contribute much, and she didn’t have to. She just stood there, present, and let the conversation wash over her like water.

After a while, Sophie clapped her on the shoulder. “See? This is nice, right? You should come to more of these.”

“Maybe I will.”

“Wait, really?” Sophie’s eyebrows shot up. “You’re actually saying yes to something social? Who are you, and what have you done with Wednesday Addams?”

I'm trying something new."

I noticed." Sophie grinned. "The contacts, the hair, and the sudden willingness to exist in a room with other people, it's working for you, girl. Katie's been staring at your arms for like ten minutes."

"I have not!" Katie's face flushed bright red. "I was looking at the wall behind her. There's a crack, and it's interesting."

"Sure, a crack." Sophie winked at Wednesday. "Very interesting crack."

Wednesday smiled, actually smiled, and the genuine expression seemed to surprise everyone in the group, including herself. The feeling of it in her chest was foreign but not unpleasant.

Across the room, she spotted Mia again, talking to a group of environmental science majors near the front porch, her green sweater a bright spot in the dim lighting. Mia glanced up, caught Wednesday's eye, and smiled.

Wednesday smiled back.

Mia tilted her head toward the porch, a question. *Do you want to come over here?*

Wednesday's heart rate kicked up. This was the moment all the lessons had been leading toward, and she could walk over there right now, strike up a conversation, and use everything Enid had taught her about eye contact, proximity, and confidence.

Yet something stopped her.

It wasn't fear or the old anxiety, nor was it the familiar urge to retreat. It was something else, a quiet voice in the back of her head that sounded disturbingly like Enid.

Not yet. You're not ready, you need more practice.

Or maybe it was something else entirely, perhaps the memory of Enid's pulse fluttering against her lips, the sound she'd made when she'd fallen apart beneath her , or the way she'd looked at Wednesday afterward, as though Wednesday had surprised her and done something she hadn't expected.

Wednesday held Mia's gaze for a moment longer, then gave a small shake of her head, a polite refusal that meant not right now.

Mia's eyebrows rose slightly, surprise perhaps, but she didn't look offended. She simply smiled again and turned back to her conversation.

"What was that?" Sophie asked, following her gaze. "That Carter girl? She' s cute, you should go talk to her."

"Maybe later ."

"Later?" Ed, later never comes. That' s like the whole thing about later."

"I know ." Wednesday took a sip of her soda. "But I'm still figuring some things out."

Sophie studied her for a moment, then shrugged. "Fair enough, but if you're trying to figure things out, you should at least enjoy the party while you do it. Come on, I'll introduce you to some people from the varsity team, they're terrifying, but in a good way ."

She pulled Wednesday deeper into the crowd, and Wednesday let herself be pulled as the music thumped and bodies pressed close around her. Somewhere upstairs, in a small bedroom with a water-stained ceiling, Enid was putting herself back together.

—

It was nearly midnight when Enid finally made her way downstairs.

She'd spent twenty minutes in the bedroom after Wednesday left, fixing her makeup, smoothing her hair, and trying to erase the evidence of what had happened. Her dress was zipped and her lipstick was reapplied, but there were things she couldn't hide, like the slight flush still lingering on her cheeks, the barely perceptible tremor in her hands, and the swollen pink of her lips.

She felt different, and that was the problem. She'd given a dozen blowjobs in her life, and she'd stopped counting somewhere around sophomore year, but none of them had felt like that. None of them had left her sitting on a stranger's bed, staring at the wall and trying to remember how to breathe.

It wasn't the sex, because the sex was fine, good even. Wednesday was an attentive partner, responsive and eager, and Enid had enjoyed herself more than she'd expected.

It was what came after. *You asked me if I was okay after I came. You didn't even think about yourself until I brought it up.*

She'd meant it, because that wasn't nothing. In her experience, most people treated sex like a transaction, they got theirs, and if you got yours too, great, but it wasn't exactly a priority. Wednesday, however, had made Enid's pleasure the priority, following her lead, paying attention to her cues, and when Enid had shattered beneath her, Wednesday had held her through it without asking for anything in return.

And then she'd thanked her, genuinely, as though Enid had done her a favor, when really, if she was being honest, Enid was starting to think she was getting more out of this arrangement than Wednesday was.

Stop it, she told herself firmly. *No feelings, it's only sex, transactional and strategic, that's the rule.*

But the rules had already changed, and Enid had changed them herself less than an hour ago.

The stairs creaked under her heels as Enid descended, and the party had thinned out slightly, with the casual attendees drifting home and the hardcore partiers and people who had nowhere else to be remaining. The music had shifted to something slower and more melodic, while the red-scarfed lamp still cast its hellish glow across the living room.

She spotted Wednesday immediately in the kitchen, surrounded by fencers. Sophie was there, along with Katie and a few others whose names Enid had never bothered to learn. Wednesday was laughing at something, actually laughing, with her head tilted back and her posture relaxed. The transformation was remarkable;she wasnt the same person who had walked through the door three hours ago, nervous hands clutching a folder of notes. She looked like she belonged.

Something twisted in Enid's chest, pride maybe, or something less comfortable.

She had done that, building Wednesday's confidence piece by piece and lesson by lesson, and now Wednesday was using it, not on Enid but on these strangers, these athletes, this world Enid had introduced her to but didnt really belong to herself.

Wednesday looked up and caught Enid's eye across the room.

Her smile changed, softened into something less performative and more genuine, the same smile she had given Enid in the bedroom afterward when she'd thanked her . She raised a hand in a small wave.

Enid waved back, and then, because she was Enid and Enid did not get sentimental over virgins who happened to be unexpectedly good at sex, she turned away and walked toward the front door, stepping out onto the sagging porch and into the cool spring night.

The air hit her face like a splash of cold water, and Enid breathed in slowly before letting it out. The stars were barely visible through the

light pollution, but she stared up at them anyway, trying to quiet the noise in her head.

The door creaked behind her.

"Hey ."

She didnt turn around. "Hey yourself, shouldnt you be inside, being charming?

"I saw you leave." W ednesday's voice was closer now as she followed Enid onto the porch. "I wanted to make sure you were okay."

"I'm fine, I'm always fine."

"That' s not what I asked."

Enid turned, and Wednesday was standing in the doorway, silhouetted by the hellish red glow of the party behind her. Her hair was still artfully disheveled, and her black henley was slightly rumpled. She looked, Enid hated this word, but it was the only one that fit, genuinely earnest, as though she truly cared about the answer to her question.

"Y ou're supposed to be practicing your social skills," Enid said. "Not checking on me."

"Maybe checking on you is part of my social skills practice."

"That doesnt even make sense."

"It makes perfect sense. Y ou're a person, I'm being social with you, ergo, social skills practice." W ednesday moved closer, leaning against the porch railing beside her. "Y ou seemed upset."

"I'm not upset."

"Y ou seemed like something was bothering you."

Enid stared out at the darkened street. A car drove past, its headlights sweeping across the sagging porch, and for a moment, Wednesday's face was illuminated, bright and sharp and too damn sincere.

"You're not supposed to be good at this," she said finally.

"At what?"

Enid gestured vaguely. "At this, the talking, the checking in, the noticing when something is wrong with me." She shook her head. "You're supposed to be a nerdy virgin who can't talk to girls, who freezes up and stares at the floor and needs me to tell her what to do. That was the deal, you were a project and a transaction, and now you're..." She stopped.

"I'm what?"

"You're complicated." Enid turned to face her fully. "You're a fast learner with good instincts, and you keep doing things that surprise me, which I don't like because I don't like being surprised."

"Why not?"

"Because surprises mean I don't have control, and control is kind of my thing."

Wednesday was quiet for a moment before slowly and carefully saying, "Maybe you don't always have to be in control."

"Easy for you to say. You've never had control of anything."

"I had control of my study schedule, at least, and that was something."

Enid laughed despite herself. "Your study schedule? That's your baseline for control, your meticulously organized Google Calendar?"

"It's a very good calendar."

“Of course it is.” Enid shook her head. “You’re ridiculous.”

“I’m aware.”

The silence that settled between them was different now, less charged and more comfortable. The party thumped on behind them, the spring air was cool against Enid’s bare shoulders, and Wednesday stood close enough that Enid could feel the warmth radiating from her body.

“Go back inside, mingle, and be charming,” Enid said finally. “I’m serious.”

“I know you’re serious.”

“Then why are you still out here?”

“Because you’re out here.” Wednesday said it simply, as though it were obvious, like the entire calculus of her decision-making had shifted to include Enid’s presence as a fundamental variable.

Enid stared at her.

“Wednesday,” she said, her voice coming out rougher than she intended. “You’re doing the thing again.”

“What thing?”

“The thing where you’re sweet. Stop it.”

“I don’t know how.”

“Learn. It’s bad for the arrangement.”

Wednesday considered this before asking, “What if the arrangement is changing?”

“It’s not.”

"You said the rules needed adjustments."

"I did, but that doesn't mean" Enid stopped and took a breath. "Adjustments don't mean feelings. They mean mutual pleasure, they mean both of us getting something out of it. They don't mean..." She gestured between them. "This."

"What's this?"

"You know what this is."

"I don't, I really don't." Wednesday pushed off the railing and stood in front of Enid, not looming or intimidating, just present. "I know that you've been teaching me things, I know that I've been learning, and I know that somewhere along the way, it stopped feeling like a transaction, but I don't know what it feels like now, and that's the problem. I've never done this before."

"That makes two of us."

"You've had sex before."

"The sex isn't what's new." The words escaped before Enid could stop them, and although she pressed her lips together, it was too late, the admission was already hanging in the air between them.

Wednesday didn't pounce on the admission, she simply stood there patiently, waiting.

"Okay," she said after a moment. "So we're both figuring it out."

"Apparently."

"Is that okay?"

"I don't know." Enid ran her hands through her hair in frustration. "I don't like not knowing."

"You said you liked surprises earlier."

"lied, Ihate surprises, they're for people who dont have a five-year plan."

Wednesday laughed, a soft and unexpected sound that broke the tension between them like a wave against a rock. "Y ou have a five-year plan?"

"Of course Ihave a five-year plan. Step one is passing Sociology 201, step two is graduating, steps three through twelve are figuring out the rest of my life while looking fabulous, and step thirteen is never admitting to anyone that Ihelped a nerdy virgin become a sex god because it would ruin my reputation."

"Sex god?"

"Hyperbole, dont let it go to your head."

"T oo late."W ednesday smiled at her, not with the nervous smile from their first session or the grateful smile from earlier, but with something in between, something that was simply Wednesday.

Enid looked at her, really looked at her, and felt that twist in her chest again.

"Go back inside,"she said for the third time. "I mean it, you're not going to build social confidence standing on a porch with me. Im only good for sexual confidence."

"Are you sure about that?"

"Y es, Im sure, Im the expert."

"And Im the student."

"Exactly ."Enid pushed of f the railing and straightened her dress. "So do what your teacher says, go inside, mingle, be charming, and talk to Mia, that's an order."

Wednesday studied her for a moment before nodding. "Okay , but only if you tell me you're really okay ."

"I'm really okay ."

"You're not just saying that?"

"I'm not just saying that, I'm..." Enid paused, considering her answer . "I'm processing, and that' s different from not being okay."

"Processing is good."

"Processing is neutral, but I'll take it." Enid reached out and adjusted the collar of Wednesday's black henley, a gesture that was meant to be casual and teacherly but lingered a beat too long. "Now go, your public awaits."

Wednesday turned toward the door, then paused and looked back.

"Enid?"

"Yeah?"

"I'm glad you're my teacher ."

"Go."

She went, and the door swung shut behind her, leaving Enid alone on the porch with the music thumping through the walls and the spring air cool against her skin.

Enid stood there for a long moment before pulling out her phone and texting her: *Same time next Thursday , don't be late, and wear something that doesn't make me want to tear it off you.*

Three dots appeared immediately.

That's a contradiction.

I know , figure it out.

Enid tucked the phone back into her purse and stepped off the porch into the night. The walk home was short, three blocks, four at most, but she took her time because she needed the air and the space to sort through the jumble of thoughts crowding her skull.

Wednesday was supposed to be a project and a transaction, a way to keep her BS A afloat while she figured out the rest of her life.

But somewhere along the way , between the kissing lessons, the nipple guidance, and the orgasm on a stranger's bed, something had shifted. She didn't know what it was or what to call it, she only knew that when Wednesday had looked at her on that porch, earnest, sincere, and improbably sweet, something in her chest had tightened in a way that had nothing to do with physical pleasure.

No feelings, she reminded herself, it' s only sex

But she was starting to wonder if that was a lie she'd been telling herself all along.

—

Back inside the party , Wednesday's phone buzzed in her pocket. She read Enid's text, felt her face flush, and tucked the phone away before anyone could see.

"Is she your girlfriend?" Katie asked, appearing at her elbow .

"What? no, just-" W ednesday searched for the right word. "My tutor ."

"Y our tutor, right." Katie' s expression suggested she didn't believe her. "W ell, whoever she is, she must have helped, because you seem way more relaxed than you were earlier."

"I've been practicing."

"Practicing what?"

Wednesday considered the question, thinking about all the lessons she'd learned over the past three weeks, the eye contact, the proximity, the kissing, the neck, the breasts, the grinding, the blowjob, the way Enid's voice had broken when she said Wednesday's name, and the way she'd looked at her on the porch, like Wednesday had surprised her and done something unexpected.

"Being a person," she said finally.

Katie blinked. "That's okay, that's a weird answer, but I respect it." She gestured toward the kitchen. "Come on, Sophie's about to do karaoke, and trust me, you don't want to miss this, she's terrible."

"I thought karaoke required a machine."

"It requires a phone, a Bluetooth speaker, and absolutely no shame." Katie grabbed Wednesday's arm and pulled her toward the kitchen. "You're going to love it."

Wednesday let herself be pulled as the music swelled and the party continued, and somewhere in the back of her mind, she was already counting down the days until Thursday.

Chapter End Notes

They really need to stop calling this tutoring.

Chapter 5: The Practical Exam

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Thursday arrived with the kind of spring humidity that made clothes stick to skin and tempers run short. Wednesday spent the morning in the library, carrel seventeen, her kingdom, but her attention kept drifting from the regression analysis spreadsheet on her laptop screen. Her knee bounced restlessly, her pen tapped against the desk, and her phone sat face-up on the Formica, making her stomach clench every time it buzzed, even though it was never her.

Bianca noticed. "God, you've been staring at that same cell for like fifteen minutes."

Wednesday looked up. Her roommate was sprawled on the couch in their shared off-campus apartment, a bag of chips balanced on her chest, with socks balled up on the floor where she'd kicked them. "I'm concentrating."

"You're vibrating, like a tuning fork." Bianca crunched a chip. "Is it that tutor again, the scary hot one?"

"She's not scary."

"You literally said she made you forget how to breathe."

"That was contextual."

"Uh-huh." Bianca grinned. "Well, whatever she's teaching you, it's working. You've been less you know." She waved a hand. "Less you."

"Thanks?"

"That was a compliment, barely." Bianca turned back to her phone. "Just try not to get murdered, I don't want to explain to your parents that you died having sex with a supermodel who was probably out of your league."

Wednesday didn't dignify that with a response.

At 6:47 PM, she was standing outside Enid's apartment, wearing a black henley that Bianca had called "aggressively boring" and dark jeans. Her contacts were in, her hair was doing the artfully disheveled thing, and her pulse was doing the thing where it felt like a hummingbird trapped in her throat.

She knocked, and the door swung open.

Enid leaned against the doorframe, one arm braced above her head. She wore a cropped white tank top that ended just above her navel, no bra, obviously, and a pair of black yoga shorts that clung to her hips like a second skin. Her feet were bare, her hair was damp like she'd just showered, and the scent that wafted toward Wednesday was clean, floral, and utterly devastating.

She looked Wednesday up and down, slowly and deliberately, before her lips curved into that wicked grin.

"Two things," she said. "One, you're wearing contacts again."

"Good observation."

"Two, that henley is the most boring thing I've ever seen. I specifically told you to wear something that doesn't make me want to tear it off you."

Wednesday glanced down at her shirt. "You said... wait, you wanted me to wear something that would make you want to tear it off?"

"I said, 'doesn't make me want to tear it off you,' which means you should wear something so boring I don't think about tearing it off."

"That' s a double negative, the instruction was logically inconsistent."

Enid's grin widened. "And yet you still wore the most boring henley in existence."

"Because Icouldnt figure out what you actually wanted."

"And that' s why youre the nerd." She stepped back from the doorway and gestured for Wednesday to come inside. "Come on, we have snacks, Imade tea, and it' s getting cold."

The apartment looked the same as always, cozy chaos, textbooks stacked on the coffee table, a vanilla candle burning on the windowsill, and fairy lights strung along the wall behind the couch. The familiarity of it settled something in Wednesday's chest, a tension she hadnt realized shed been carrying.

Enid padded into the kitchen and returned with two mugs of Earl Grey tea. She remembered. She handed W ednesday hers and flopped onto the couch, tucking her bare feet underneath her.

"Sit," she said, and W ednesday did, the cushion dipping beneath her weight and bringing them closer together until her knee pressed against Wednesday's thigh.

"So," Enid said, taking a sip of her tea, "how was the rest of the party, after Ileft?"

"Sophie did karaoke."

"Oh god."

"She sang IWill Always Love Y ou.' t was" W ednesday searched for the right word. "Physically painful."

"I bet it was. Did you talk to anyone, other than the fencers?"

"Some people, a girl from my stats class, and Katie, the one with the bleached hair. She asked if you were my girlfriend."

Enid's mug paused halfway to her lips. "What did you tell her?"

"That you're my tutor."

"Good answer." She took a sip. "What about Mia?"

"I didn't talk to her."

"Why not?"

Wednesday stared into her tea as the steam curled upward and dissipated into the air between them. "She smiled at me from across the room, then tilted her head toward the porch, kind of an invitation, and I.." She stopped.

"You what?"

"I shook my head."

Enid set her mug down on the coffee table, the movement careful and deliberate. "Why?"

"I don't know," Wednesday looked up at her, "I thought I wanted to, that's the whole reason we started this, right? So I could talk to Mia, but in that moment, I didn't want to. I wanted to stay with the girls, with Sophie and Katie, and I was having fun."

"That's good, that's-" She paused. "That's actually progress, social integration, building a network, those are transferable skills."

"Transferable skills." Wednesday laughed, a soft exhale. "You sound like a textbook."

"I am a textbook, I'm the textbook of sex and social confidence, and you're my star pupil." She leaned back against the arm of the couch, studying Wednesday. "But that's not all that's bothering you, is it?"

"No."

"What else?"

Wednesday set her mug down next to Enid's, the two mugs sitting side by side on the coffee table, hers with the handle facing left and Enid's facing right, a matched set, a pair.

"I've been thinking about what you said," she said. "On the porch, about the arrangement feeling different."

Enid's expression flickered, something passing through her eyes, surprise maybe, or wariness, before the mask slid back into place. "I said a lot of things on the porch, you'll have to be more specific."

"You said it stopped feeling like a transaction."

"I did say that."

"And then you said it couldn't be feelings."

"I said that too."

Wednesday turned on the couch to face her, her knee pressing more firmly against Enid's thigh, but she didn't pull away. "What if it's not feelings? What if it's just...something else, something we don't have a word for?"

Enid was quiet for a long moment as the fairy lights cast soft shadows across her face, the vanilla candle flickered on the windowsill, and somewhere in the building, a door slammed, footsteps echoing in the hallway outside.

"There's a word for everything," she said finally. "That's the problem, words make things real, and I don't want this to be real."

"Why not?"

"Because real things can get messy, and real things can hurt you. Transactions are clean, transactions have rules." She gestured

between them. "This was supposed to be tutoring, sex and sociology, a trade, not whatever this is."

"Not what?"

"Not whatever this is." She ran a hand through her damp hair. "You keep surprising me every session, you do something unexpected, and I have to recalibrate, and I hate recalibrating. I had a plan, you were supposed to be a project, a student, and now I'm.."

She stopped, her jaw tightening.

"Now you're what?" Wednesday asked.

"Now I'm looking forward to Thursdays," she said, the words coming out rushed and almost defensive. "And I don't look forward to things because looking forward to things means you can be disappointed, and I've had enough disappointment to last me a lifetime."

Wednesday didn't know what to say to that. The silence stretched between them, not uncomfortable exactly, but heavy, laden with something unspoken.

Then Enid laughed, a sharp, almost bitter sound. "Look at us, we're supposed to be having sex, and instead we're having feelings. This is your fault."

"My fault?"

"You're too sweet. I told you to stop being sweet."

"I can't help it."

"Learn."

"I've been trying, but it's not working." She shifted on the couch, her knee pressing more firmly against Enid's thigh. "Maybe we should stop trying to define it, maybe we should just keep going, whatever this is, whatever it becomes."

Enid looked at her, her blue eyes unreadable, the fairy lights catching in them and making them glint softly. "You're suggesting we just, not define it?"

"I'm suggesting we stop worrying about what to call it and just..." She paused, searching for the right word. "Experience it."

"That's very zen of you."

"I've been reading."

"Of course you have." She shook her head, but the tension in her shoulders had eased. The mask had slipped, just a little, revealing something softer underneath, something almost vulnerable. "Okay, fine, we don't define it, we don't name it, we just.."

"Experience it."

"Experience it, but with rules, there are still rules."

"Obviously."

"And boundaries."

"Naturally."

"And if you do that thing where you look at me like I'm the most fascinating thing you've ever seen, I reserve the right to make fun of you for it."

Wednesday smiled. "Deal."

They shook on it, her hand warm in Wednesday's, her grip firm, and when she pulled back, her fingers trailed across Wednesday's palm, a lingering touch that sent electricity skittering up her arm.

"Okay," she said, settling back against the arm of the couch. "Enough emotional honesty, I'm starting to get hives. Let's talk about tonight's lesson."

"What's the lesson?"

"The lesson is you." She pointed at W ednesday. "Y ou've been following instructions for four sessions, you've been taking direction, and you've been a very good student."

"I try ."

"I know you do, that's the problem. Y ou try so hard to do everything right that you're not trusting yourself." She leaned forward, her elbows on her knees. "T onight, I want you to follow your instincts, no instructions, no syllabus, just you doing what feels natural."

Wednesday's pulse did its familiar acceleration. "What if my instincts are wrong?"

"They're not, we've established this multiple times." She held up a hand. "But if I need you to do something dif ferently, I'll tell you. I'll say 'more,' or 'slower ,' or 'yes, right there, don't stop.' That's it, that's the only instruction. Everything else is you."

"That's still instruction."

"It's feedback, feedback is dif ferent from instruction. Feedback is just me telling you what feels good." She tilted her head. "Can you handle that?"

"Y es."

"W ord?"

"Y es, I can handle that."

"Good." She stood up from the couch and held out her hand. "Then come on, the couch is great for kissing, but I have plans for tonight that require horizontal space."

Wednesday took her hand, and Enid led her down the short hallway to her bedroom, a room she'd never been in before. The door swung

open, and she stepped inside.

t was surprisingly tidy , with a queen bed covered by a perfectly made white duvet, a dresser with a mirror whose surface was cluttered with makeup and jewellery , and a closet door slightly ajar , revealing a riot of color, clothes in every shade crammed together in a way that suggested organization had been attempted and abandoned. The windows were covered with gauzy curtains that diffused the evening light into something golden and soft.

The bed dominated the room, making it impossible not to look at it.

"Shoes of f," Enid said, pointing at the floor . "House rule."

Wednesday toed off her sneakers. Enid was already on the bed, stretching out on her side with her head propped on one hand. The pose was casual, but her eyes were sharp, watching her, cataloguing her movements, waiting.

"Nervous?" she asked.

"A little."

"Good, nervous means you care." She patted the mattress beside her. "Lie down on your back, let's start slow ."

She stretched out beside her, staring up at the ceiling. t was white and unblemished, with no water stains like those in the party house, while a small ceiling fan spun lazily overhead, its blades casting rotating shadows on the walls.

Enid shifted closer, her body heat radiating against Wednesday's side, her hair brushing her shoulder, damp and fragrant.

"Just so we're clear ," she said, "tonight is about you, your instincts, your desires, whatever you want to do, whatever feels right, I want you to do it."

"What if I do something you don't like?"

"Then I'll tell you, I'm not shy ."She traced a finger down Wednesday's arm, light and teasing. "But I have a feeling I'm going to like whatever you do. You've got good instincts, nerdy , you just don't trust them."

Wednesday turned her head to look at her. She was close, close enough that Wednesday could count her eyelashes and see the faint smile playing at the corners of her lips. The mask was still there, but it was thinner now, more translucent, and behind it, something was stirring.

"Okay ,"she said. "My instincts, no instructions."

"No instructions except feedback."

"Right."She took a breath. "Can I start?"

"Please do."

She rolled onto her side to face her, the motion bringing their bodies into alignment, her chest inches from Wednesday's, her hips level with hers, and her face so close she could feel Enid's breath on her lips. Enid's eyes widened slightly , but she didn't pull back or say anything, she just waited.

Her hand found Enid's waist, and the cropped tank top had ridden up, exposing a strip of bare skin above her hip, so her palm settled there, fingers splaying across her ribcage. Her skin was warm and soft, and Wednesday could feel her ribs expand with each breath.

Slowly and deliberately, she leaned in and kissed her, not with the tentative kiss of their first session or the practiced technique of their second, but with something in between, something that was just her . Her lips met Enid's, soft at first and questioning, while her mouth opened under hers, and her tongue traced the seam of her lips before sliding inside.

She tasted like tea, Earl Grey and something sweeter underneath.

Her hand slid up Enid's side, pushing the tank top higher and revealing her bare stomach, the curve of her ribcage, and the underside of her breast. Enid made a small sound against her mouth, a hum of approval, and that was all the encouragement she needed.

She kissed her deeper, her tongue exploring her mouth with unhurried confidence, while her thumb traced the underside of her breast, light and teasing, just the way she'd taught her. Enid's nipple tightened under the fabric of her tank top, a visible peak pressing against the white cotton.

"Mmmh." The sound vibrated against her lips. "God, keep going."

Feedback, not instruction, so she kept going.

Her mouth left Enid's and traced a path down her jaw, along her neck, and to the spot behind her ear that made her shiver. She lingered there, her tongue pressing flat against her pulse point as she felt her heartbeat flutter beneath her lips.

"Oh." Her head tilted back, offering more of her throat. "Right there."

She sucked gently at the skin, not hard enough to leave a mark, something in the back of her mind cautioning against that, but hard enough to make her gasp. Enid's hand came up and fisted in Wednesday's hair, not pulling, just holding on.

Her mouth continued its journey along her collarbone and the hollow of her throat, tracing the neckline of her tank top with her tongue before pulling back, teasing her and making her wait.

"Wednesday." Her voice was strained. "More."

She pushed the tank top up, and Enid lifted her arms, letting Wednesday pull it over her head and toss it aside. Wednesday had seen her before, she'd touched her before, but this time was different

because Enid wasn't instructing her, she was simply lying there, watching her and waiting to see what she would do.

Wednesday cupped her gently, the familiarity doing nothing to lessen the intensity of the moment. Enid shivered and shifted on the mattress.

"Yes," the word was barely a whisper. "Just like that."

Wednesday continued, following her instincts rather than waiting for another instruction, and Enid's breathing grew increasingly uneven beneath her touch.

"Oh, fuck." Enid's fingers tightened in Wednesday's dark hair. "That's, yes."

Wednesday pulled back just enough to look at her. Enid's cheeks were flushed, her lips were parted, and her eyes were dark, the gold flecks almost swallowed by them. She looked completely undone already, and Wednesday hadn't even really started.

"Can I?" Wednesday hesitated. "I want to."

"Whatever your instincts tell you," Enid's voice was hoarse. "Do it."

Wednesday's hand slid down her stomach, and Enid's abdominal muscles tensed beneath her palm. Her fingers caught at the waistband of Enid's shorts, and she paused, looking at Enid's face and waiting for a sign.

Enid lifted her hips, an invitation and an answer.

Wednesday pulled the shorts down, the cotton slid over Enid's thighs, her knees, her calves. Enid kicked them off, and they landed somewhere on the floor in a crumpled heap. She wasn't wearing underwear, of course she wasn't.

Her pussy was bare, completely shaved not even a trace of stubble, just smooth skin that seemed to glow in the golden evening light.

The lips were full and pink, the outer labia plump and framing the delicate inner folds that were just visible between them, the cleft was a vertical line dividing her mound, and at the top, nestled in the junction where her lips met was her clit, still hidden beneath its hood but clearly swollen, the nub just barely peeking out.

The sight of her hit Wednesday somewhere deep in her chest. She'd seen pictures, diagrams, and textbook illustrations from the anatomy sections she'd studied during her obsessive preparation, but nothing had prepared her for the real thing, the way the light caught the faint sheen of moisture already gathering on Enid's inner lips, the way her thighs parted instinctively as Wednesday's gaze settled on her , the way the whole landscape of her shifted subtly with each breath she took.

"You're staring," Enid said, but there was no teasing in her voice, just observation.

"Admiring." Wednesday's voice came out rougher than she intended.

"Good word." Enid bit her lip. "You can touch me, if you want."

"I want."

Wednesday's hand settled on her thigh, the muscle tense beneath her palm, and she realized that Enid was nervous. Enid, who was never nervous about anything, who treated sex like a transaction and desire like a currency, was nervous because this was different, because Wednesday wasn't following instructions, and because Enid had given her control without knowing what she was going to do with it.

The realization sent a surge of something through Wednesday, not power exactly, but something warmer that felt almost like responsibility.

She moved slowly and deliberately, her hand slid from the thigh to the hip, her fingers tracing the curve of the pelvis. Enid watched her

with those blue eyes, her breathing shallow,her lips parted as she waited.

Wednesday's fingers brushed the smooth skin of the mound, the heat of Enid was shocking like slipping into a bath that was just slightly too hot. She traced the crease where the thigh met the pelvis, the soft skin there, and then finally her fingers found the folds.

Wet, she was so wet.

The moisture coated Wednesday's fingertips instantly, slick and warm, as she traced the seam of her, starting with the outer lips before slowly parting them. The inner lips were even more sensitive, and Enid gasped when her finger brushed against them, her hips twitching upward as the wet, obscene sound filled the quiet bedroom.

"Oh."The word escaped W ednesday without permission.

"Y eah."Enid's voice was barely audible. "That's yeah."

Wednesday explored her with her fingers without rushing or treating it like a mechanical exercise, but with genuine curiosity. Her index finger traced the length of the slit, from the bottom of the opening to the top where the clit was hiding. The natural lubrication made the journey smooth and slippery, and the wet sounds that accompanied her movements were louder now, a soft squelch that made Wednesday's own cock throb painfully against the fabric of her black trousers.

Enid's legs fell open wider, her hands were fisted in the sheets, knuckles white. She was trembling.

"W ednesday."Her name was a whisper . A plea. "Please."

"Please what"?

"More please." The word cracked in her throat. "I need~~mo~~re."

Wednesday's instincts told her to circle the clit, so she brought her index finger to the top of the slit, where the hood was hiding the most sensitive spot. She traced a slow circle around it, not touching directly, not yet, just skating the perimeter, and Enid gasped as her hips bucked. The motion spread more slickness across Wednesday's finger, making the circle even smoother.

She varied the pressure, light at first, barely grazing the hood then firmer, pressing down slightly, letting the hood slide over the nub beneath. Enid made a sound that was half moan, half sob, and her thighs tried to clamp shut around Wednesday's hand.

She didn't let them. Wednesday's other hand pressed gently on Enid's inner thigh, keeping her open. "You okay?"

"Yes ~~do~~n't stop ~~pl~~ease don't stop"—

Wednesday didn't stop, her finger continued its slow circles, varying pressure, varying speed, watching Enid's face, reading her body. When Enid's hips arched upward, she pressed harder. When her breath caught, she slowed down. When a broken moan escaped her lips, she did it again exactly the same way.

The clit was visible now peeking out from beneath its hood, a small pearl of pink flesh, swollen and slick. Wednesday traced a circle directly around it, not touching, just orbiting and Enid's whole body shuddered.

"Fuck~~W~~ ednesday~~!~~"—

"Tell me what you need."

"Your ~~fi~~ngers inside, please."

Wednesday brought her fingers down to the opening. The moisture there was even more abundant ~~sli~~ck and warm, coating her

fingertips instantly. She circled the entrance once, twice, spreading the wetness, and thenslowly , so slowlyshe eased her middle finger inside.

Enid was tight. Hot and tight and impossibly soft. Her inner walls clenched around Wednesday's finger, and she felt the pulse therea fluttering rhythm that matched the heartbeat she'd felt in Enid's throat earlier. She paused, letting her adjust, watching her face for any sign of discomfort.

"Yes."The word was stretched out, almost a hiss. "More, please."

Wednesday added her index finger, two fingers now, buried inside Enid, and the sensation was overwhelmingthe heat, the wetness, the way the muscles gripped her. She curled her fingers upward, searching, and found a spot on the front wall of the pussy that was slightly rougher than the rest, the G-spot. She remembered from her reading.

She pressed gently and Enid's whole body arched off the bed.

"Ohgodyesright there"

Wednesday did it again and again. A gentle "come here"motion with her two fingers, stroking that sensitive spot while her thumbacting on pure instinctfound the clit. She pressed the pad of her thumb against it, gentle and slow, and Enid's control shattered.

"Ahhahfuckyesyes"

Enid's hands were in Wednesday's hair now, gripping tight enough to hurt. Her hips were rocking against the fingers, meeting the movements with an urgency that made the wet sounds louder, faster, more obscene. Her head was thrown back, her throat exposed, and the sounds spilling from her mouth were barely words anymorejust broken syllables, desperate and raw.

Wednesday kept the rhythm steady, fingers inside her, curling, thumb on her clit, circling. The dual stimulation was making Enid fall apart beneath her, and the sight of it~~the~~ sound of it~~wa~~s the most incredible thing Wednesday had ever experienced.

"Nghh~~do~~nt stop~~ple~~ase~~hnhn~~ so close~~"—

"Then come," W ednesday said, the words left her mouth before she could think about them. "Come for me, Enid."

"Y es~~yes~~h~~n~~"—

Enid's body went rigid, her back arched of f the mattress, and a sound tore from her throat that was somewhere between a scream and a sob, her pussy clenched around Wednesday's fingers—rhythmic pulses, one after another, milking her hand, her thighs clamped shut around Wednesday's wrist, and her whole body trembled and shook as the orgasm rolled through her.

"Ahhhh~~fuck~~fuck~~W~~ ednesday~~"~~—

Wednesday kept her fingers inside, still but present, as the waves subsided. Her thumb stopped moving on the clit~~E~~nid was too sensitive now, she could tell from the way she flinched when she started to pull away, she held still and let her ride it out.

Enid's breathing was ragged, her chest heaving as sweat glistened in the hollow of her throat. Her eyes were sqeezed shut, and a single tear had escaped the corner of one eye, tracing a path toward her hairline.

Slowly, her muscles relaxed, her thighs falling open as her grip on Wednesday's hair loosened.

"Holy shit," she breathed.

Wednesday carefully withdrew her fingers, they came out slick and glistening, coated in Enid's arousal. She stared at them for a

moment, taking in the evidence of what she'd done and where her instincts had led her, and felt something swell in her chest, a mixture of pride, satisfaction, and something deeper that she still didn't have a word for.

"That was—" Enid opened her eyes and looked at her . Her expression was dazed, almost drugged. "That was really , really good."

"Good instincts."

"Exceptional instincts." Enid pushed herself up on her elbows, her hair falling in messy waves around her face. "You're getting too good at this, it's becoming a problem."

"A problem?"

"For my ego, I'm supposed to be the expert." Enid reached out and grabbed Wednesday's wrist, pulling her hand toward her face. She examined the fingers—still slick, still glistening and then, without breaking eye contact, she brought them to her mouth and licked them clean.

Wednesday's brain short-circuited.

One finger at a time. Enid's tongue, that wicked, clever tongue—traced the length of the index finger, then the middle finger, gathering the taste of herself from Wednesday's skin. She made a sound of satisfaction, low in her throat.

"Mmmh." Enid released the fingers with a wet pop. "I taste good."

Wednesday's voice had apparently abandoned her entirely , she stared at Enid, open-mouthed, while her cock throbbed painfully against the front of her black trousers.

Enid followed her gaze, and a grin spread across her face, not the wicked grin or predatory smirk, but something genuinely delighted.

"Someone's excited," she said.

"You just licked your own off my fingers and you're surprised I'm"—

"Not surprised, flattered." Enid leaned back against the pillows, stretching out like a satisfied cat. "But we're not done."

"We're not?"

"No." She shook her head. "Your instincts were very good but I want to see what else they tell you to do." She gestured down at her body, still naked, still flushed, still spread out on the white duvet like an offering. "Keep going, whatever you want, whatever feels right."

Wednesday's gaze traveled down Enid's body, taking in the curve of her breasts, the plane of her stomach, and the smooth, bare mound of her pussy, still glistening from the intensity of the moment. Her mouth was dry, her heart was pounding, and her instincts were urging her toward something she'd only ever read about.

She shifted on the bed, moving lower and positioning herself between Enid's thighs.

Enid's eyes went wide. "Wednesday"—

"Is this okay?"

"Yes~~yes~~, it's" She swallowed hard. "You don't have to, if you're not ready"—

"My instincts are telling me to taste you." The words came out steadier than Wednesday felt. "Are you okay with that?"

"Yes." The word was barely a whisper. "God, yes."

Wednesday lowered her mouth to her pussy.

The first touch was tentative, just her lips pressing against the outer folds. The taste of Enid flooded her senses: salt and musk and

something faintly sweet, like the vanilla candle burning in the other room, the texture was impossibly soft, slick against her lips, and the heat of her was staggering.

Enid gasped as her hips twitched, her hand finding Wednesday's dark hair again, not to guide her, but simply to anchor herself.

Wednesday traced the seam of her with her tongue slowly and deliberately, parting the outer lips to find the delicate inner folds beneath, the wetness coated her tongue immediately, the previous orgasm still fresh, the arousal still flowing. The taste was stronger here, more concentrated, and Wednesday found herself wanting more.

"Ohfuck" Enid's voice was strained. "Y our tongue"—

Wednesday licked upward, from the bottom of the slit to the top, gathering the moisture as she went. The flat of her tongue pressed against the entire length, and Enid shuddered, a full-body tremor that made her thighs clamp against Wednesday's head before she forced them open again.

"Dont stopkeepyes"—

Wednesday found the clit, it was still sensitive from the first orgasm, still swollen and exposed, and when her tongue touched it directly, Enid cried out a sharp, almost pained sound.

"Ahgentle"—

Wednesday gentled, and instead of the exposed nub, she licked around it, the hood, the surrounding flesh, and the creases where the lips met. She used the flat of her tongue in broad strokes that covered more surface area, then used the tip to trace patterns around the clit without directly touching it. She varied her pressure and speed, reading Enid's reactions like a language she was only beginning to learn.

When she gasped, Wednesday did it again, when she moaned, she slowed down, and when her hips bucked, she pressed harder.

"Nghhyesjust likeyour tongue is"—

Wednesday sucked gently, her lips sealed over the clit, hood and all, as she created soft, steady suction. The moan that tore from Enid's throat was loud enough to wake the neighbors.

"Fuckfuckthatsoh god"—

Wednesday's tongue kept moving, licking, sucking, tasting, while the rhythm built, and she matched it with her fingers, two of them sliding inside again, curling upward to stroke the Gspot while her mouth worked the clit. The combination made Enid come apart completely.

"Ahhahyesmoreineedhm"—

She was close, and Wednesday could feel it, the tension in her thighs, the way her hands fisted in her hair, and the ragged rhythm of her breathing. Wednesday kept doing what she was doing, steady and relentless, her tongue tracing the clit in slow circles, her fingers pumping inside, and her other hand pressing down on Enid's stomach to hold her in place.

"Pleasepleasehm going to"—

Enid came with a scream. "Ahhhhfuckyesw ednesday"—

Her body convulsed, her pussy clenching around Wednesday's fingers in rhythmic pulses that seemed to go on forever. Her thighs clamped tight around Wednesday's head, muf fling the sounds of the world, and all Wednesday could hear was the pounding of her own heart and the wet, obscene sounds of the climax against her tongue.

Wednesday kept her mouth there, gentle now and soothing, licking softly as the waves subsided while being careful not to

overstimulate. Enid's body went slack beneath her, her muscles unknotting one by one as her thighs fell open again.

When Wednesday finally pulled back, her face was wet, her chin and lips covered in the remnants of the moment, with the taste of Enid everywhere, in her mouth, on her skin, and in the air she was breathing.

Enid stared at her, her chest heaving and her face flushed from her forehead down to her sternum, while sweat glistened on her stomach. Her eyes were wet again, filled with tears of sensation and overwhelm, not sadness.

"That." Her voice was wrecked, hoarse and barely audible. "That was the best oral I've ever had."

"It was my first time."

Enid laughed, the sound breathless and almost giddy. "I know, that's what's so incredibly unfair about it." She reached down and grabbed Wednesday's wrist, pulling her up toward her. "Come here, you're all wet."

Wednesday crawled up the bed and collapsed beside her. Enid turned on her side to face her, reaching out to wipe the moisture from Wednesday's chin with her thumb, then leaned in and kissed her, soft and slow, tasting herself on Wednesday's lips.

"Mmmh." Enid pulled back, licking her lips. "I really do taste good."

"Modest."

"We established a long time ago that I'm not modest, that's kind of my whole thing."

They lay there for a moment, facing each other, while the ceiling fan spun lazily overhead and the vanilla candle flickered from the other

room. The evening light was fading, and the bedroom was sinking into a soft twilight.

Enid's expression shifted, something passing through her eyes, an emotion Wednesday couldn't name, there and gone before she could identify it.

"What?" Wednesday asked.

"Nothing, just—" Enid reached out and touched her face, her fingers tracing the line of Wednesday's jaw and the curve of her cheek. "You're not supposed to be this good."

"You keep saying that."

"Because it keeps being true." Enid's thumb brushed Wednesday's lower lip. "I've been with a lot of guys, I mean, a lot, and not one of them has ever made me come twice in one session, let alone with fingers and mouth on their first try."

"Maybe they weren't paying attention."

"It's more than attention." Enid pulled her hand back, her brow furrowing. "You actually care, about whether it feels good for me, about whether I'm okay. You made me come and then you kept going because you wanted to taste me, not because I asked, not because it was a lesson, just because you wanted to. That's—" She stopped and swallowed. "That's not nothing."

Silence settled between them, and the words from the porch echoed in Wednesday's mind. This was supposed to be a transaction, a trade, not whatever this is.

But here they were, lying in her bed, Enid's body still trembling from two orgasms Wednesday had given her with nothing but her fingers and her mouth and her instincts. Here they were, and whatever this was, transaction or not, feelings or not, it didn't feel like nothing.

"My turn," Enid said, breaking the silence.

"What?"

"Your turn." She gestured down at Wednesday's black trousers, where the outline of her erection was still painfully obvious. "You've been hard for like twenty minutes, that can't be comfortable."

"You don't have to—"

"I know I don't have to." Enid pushed herself up on one elbow. "But you just gave me two orgasms without any instructions, I think you've earned some reciprocity."

Wednesday swallowed hard, her cock throbbing in agreement. "What did you have in mind?"

"That depends." Enid's wicked grin flickered back into place, but it was softer now, less armor and more invitation. "What do your instincts tell you to do now?"

"My instincts are telling me to let you do whatever you want."

"Good instincts." Enid leaned in and kissed her, deep and slow and full of promise. "Now lie back, I want to try something."

Wednesday lay back against the pillows, her lean fencer's physique relaxed against the sheets. Enid straddled her hips, her bare pussy pressing against the black fabric of the trousers, and reached for her belt. She closed her eyes, letting her instincts guide her.

Chapter End Notes

All those anatomy diagrams finally became useful.

Chapter 6: Expanding the Curriculum

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Enid's fingers worked Wednesday's belt with practiced efficiency. The leather slid through the buckle with a whisper as she undid the button and zipper, then tugged at her black trousers. Wednesday lifted her hips automatically, a reflex now after four sessions of learning to anticipate her movements. The dark fabric pooled around her thighs, then her knees, before landing on the floor in a crumpled heap beside her discarded yoga shorts.

Her black boxer briefs followed. The fabric stretched over her erection, a damp spot already visible where pre-cum had soaked through. Enid's fingers hooked the waistband and pulled it down, and Wednesday's cock sprang free, slapping against her stomach with a sound that made her grin.

"Eager ," she murmured.

"You have no idea."

"I have some idea." She wrapped her hand around the base, and the contact made Wednesday gasp. Her palm was still warm from the tea, and the pressure was perfect, not too tight and not too loose. "You've been hard since you got here, haven't you?"

"Pretty much."

"Poor thing." She stroked her once, slow , base to tip, and the bead of pre-cum at the head smeared across her thumb. "All that time eating me out and you never once rushed. Most people would've been humping the mattress by minute five."

"My instincts said to focus on you."

"Y our instincts are annoyingly generous." She stroked her again, tightening her grip on the downstroke. "W e need to work on that, teach you to be a little more selfish."

"Isn't that counter to everything you've been teaching me?"

"Maybe." She tilted her head, considering. "But here's the thing about sex, nerdy, it's supposed to be mutual. Y ou're so focused on making me feel good that you forget about yourself that's sweet, but it's not sustainable. Eventually , you need to let someone take care of you."

Wednesday's reply died in her throat as her thumb found the sensitive spot just beneath the head, the frenulum, and began tracing slow circles there. The sensation sent sparks up her spine.

"Oh."

"Y eah, there it is." She did it again. "Y ou like that."

"That's ~~ye~~s. Obviously ."

"Obviously ." Her grin widened as she shifted on top of her , adjusting her position so she straddled Wednesday's lean, fencer's thighs. Her bare pussy pressed against her leg, still wet and warm, and the contact made her inhale sharply. "Okay , new plan. I was going to suck you off again, but I think we should try something dif ferent."

"Dif ferent how?"

"Y ou've been practicing your instincts, now I want to practice mine." She released Wednesday's cock and reached for the nightstand drawer. The wood slid open with a soft scrape, and her hand emerged holding a small bottle of clear, unlabeled liquid, lube. "I want to try something, but I need you to trust me."

"I trust you."

God." She uncapped the bottle and squeezed a generous amount onto her palm. The lube was clear and thick, faintly warm from being stored in the nightstand. She rubbed her hands together, coating both palms, then reached down and wrapped both hands around her cock.

The sensation was different from saliva, slicker and smoother. Her hands glided over her shaft with zero friction, and the dual grip, both hands working in tandem, made Wednesday's hips buck involuntarily.

"Fuck"—

"Language." Her voice was teasing, but her eyes were focused, cataloguing her reactions. "I'm going to try something I've read about. Tell me if it's too much."

Her right hand stayed at the base, providing steady pressure, while her left hand moved upward, twisting slightly on the upstroke. The combination of sensations, pressure below and friction above, was unlike anything Wednesday had experienced, and her fingers fisted in the sheets.

"That's—that's very"—

"Very what?"

"Very good, very, very good. I'm losing vocabulary."

"God, that's the goal." Enid varied the rhythm, alternating fast strokes with slow ones and a tight grip with a looser one. The lube made wet sounds with every movement, a soft squelch that filled the quiet bedroom. Her thumb traced the ridge of her corona while her fingers explored the sensitive underside. She found a spot just below the head that made her gasp and focused there, pressing firmly with two fingers while her other hand continued its steady rhythm.

"You're leaking so much," she observed, "more than last time."

"Is that bad?"

"It's hot, means you're really turned on." She gathered the pre-cum with her thumb and spread it down her shaft, mixing it with the lube. "I like knowing I did that, got you this worked up without even touching you."

"You were touching me and sitting on me."

"Barely, I was just existing in your vicinity." Her hands moved faster, and the wet sounds grew louder. "You're so responsive, every time I do something new, your whole body reacts, your thighs tense, your stomach clenches, and your breathing hitches, it's like reading a book."

"A pornographic book."

"The best kind." She squeezed at the base, applying a gentle pressure that made her vision blur, then released. "Okay, I want to try something else, so roll over."

"What?"

"Roll over, onto your stomach."

Wednesday blinked as the command took a moment to process through the haze of arousal. "Why?"

"Because I want to try a different position, and you ask too many questions." She lifted herself off her thighs and gestured at the mattress. "Go on, trust me."

She rolled over, and the duvet felt soft against her chest, still warm from where her body had been. The position was strange, leaving her vulnerable and exposed, but not unpleasant, while her erection pressed against the mattress, the friction making her inhale sharply.

Enid shifted behind her, her knees pressing against the outsides of Wednesday's thighs as her hands, still slick with lube, settled on her

lower back.

"Okay ," she said. "This position is good for a few things. One, it lets me reach everything. Two, it's easier on my wrists. Three—" She leaned down, and Wednesday felt her lips press against the back of her neck. "It's hot."

Her hands slid lower, over her ass and down the backs of her thighs, exploring with an attention to detail that made Wednesday feel like a specimen under a microscope, in the best possible way. Her fingers traced the lines of lean muscle in her legs, honed by years of fencing, while her thumbs pressed into the small of her back. She found knots of tension Wednesday didn't know she had and worked them loose with slow, deliberate pressure.

"You're so tense," she murmured. "All the time, even now , when you're supposed to be relaxed."

"I'm lying naked on your bed with your hands on my ass. Relaxed isn't exactly the word I'd use."

"Fair point." She leaned forward, pressing her bare breasts against Wednesday's back. The contact was electric, her nipples tight against her skin and her body heat radiating through her. Her mouth found Wednesday's ear. "What would be the word you'd use?"

"Overwhelmed, in a good way ."

"In a good way ." She kissed the spot behind her ear . "I like that."

Her right hand slid between her legs, found her balls, and cupped them gently, the lube making the contact smooth and slippery. Her other hand reached underneath her and wrapped around her cock at an awkward angle, but it was functional, and she stroked her slowly while her fingers explored her testicles with careful precision.

"Is this okay?"

"Yes, very yes."

"Good." She squeezed gently, applying just enough pressure to make her gasp, then released. "Some girls are sensitive here, some aren't. Looks like you're in the first category."

"I didn't know that was a thing."

"Everything is a thing. That's the secret of sex." She stroked her faster, the angle different from this position, her hand moving in reverse and the friction concentrated on the underside of her shaft. "How does this feel?"

"Different, good different."

"Different how?"

"More intense? On the underside."

"Hmm." She filed that away, and Wednesday could practically hear her mental notes being updated. "Good to know."

Her hand continued its rhythm, slow and steady, while her other hand kept exploring, moving to her perineum and pressing gently as she found spots that made her toes curl. She was thorough and methodical, every touch deliberate and calculated to elicit a reaction, and Wednesday found herself making sounds she'd never made before, low moans, breathless gasps, and a broken version of her name that seemed to please her immensely.

"You're getting close," she said, and it wasn't a question.

"Yes, maybe."

"Good, but not yet." She pulled her hands away, and Wednesday made a sound of protest that was embarrassingly close to a whimper. "Don't worry, I'm not done. I just want to try one more thing."

"How many things are there?"

"So many , you have no idea." She shifted of f her and patted the mattress. "Roll over again, on your back."

She obeyed, her cock slick with lube, flushed a deep pink and curving upward toward her stomach. The head was swollen, almost purple now, and the vein on the underside was visibly pulsing. She felt exposed in a way that went beyond mere nudity, as though Enid could see everything, every insecurity, every desire, every thought.

Enid's gaze traveled down her body , and she bit her lip.

"Okay ," she said. "I'm going to try something, and I need you to tell me if it's too much."

"That's the second time you've said that."

"Because it's important." She straddled her thighs again, her pussy inches from Wednesday's cock now , so close that she could feel the heat radiating from her. Wednesday's hands found her hips automatically, and she covered them with her own. "I want to try something called ~~ok~~ okay , it doesn't have a good name basically , I'm going to rub myself on you, not inside, just against. Okay?"

"Okay ."

"W ords."

"Y es, okay."

"Good girl."

Enid lowered herself onto Wednesday, not onto her cock, carefully positioning herself so the shaft pressed against her slit without entering. The contact was immediate and overwhelming, her wetness mixing with the lube on Wednesday's skin, and when Enid rocked her hips forward, the slide was effortless.

"Oh, fuck"—

"Yeah." Enid's voice was strained as she moved again. "Yeah, that's, that's good."

Enid rocked again, her clit dragging along the shaft as she shuddered, the full-body tremor making her grip tighten around Wednesday's hands. Her head fell back, exposing the long line of her throat, while the fairy lights from the living room cast soft shadows across her chest, highlighting the swell of her breasts and the tight peaks of her nipples.

Wednesday watched Enid move, studying the rhythm she built as it remained slow at first, experimental as she tested different angles and pressure. Enid rolled her hips in a figure-eight motion that made her breath catch, then tilted her pelvis forward so her clit dragged along the ridge of the corona, drawing a sound from her that was somewhere between a gasp and a sob.

"Yes right there that's" Enid did it again, then again, her movements becoming more urgent and less controlled as her thighs trembled against Wednesday's hips and her nails dug into the backs of Wednesday's hands.

Wednesday's hips bucked upward to meet Enid's movement, and the head of her cock bumped against Enid's clit, making her cry out, sharp and high-pitched, completely unguarded.

"Fuck do that again, do that again"—

Wednesday did, the instinct was already there, guiding her as she moved, and when Wednesday's hips rolled upward while Enid came down, their bodies collided in a wet, obscene, perfect rhythm. Enid was dripping, and Wednesday could feel it, the slickness spreading across her stomach and coating her shaft, making every slide smoother than the last.

"Oh godoh godIm" Enid was close, and W ednesday could tell from the way her rhythm began to stutter, the way her breathing turned ragged, and the way her inner walls fluttered against Wednesday's shaft every time Enid ground down.

Wednesday reached between them and found Enid's clit with her thumb, pressing gently against the swollen, exposed skin slick with her own arousal.

Enid shattered.

"AhhhfuckW ednesdayyes" Her orgasm hit her like a wave, pulling her under as her back arched and her hips bucked wildly, grinding against Wednesday with desperate urgency. Enid's pussy clenched and unclenched against nothing, while the wet sounds of her climax were drowned out by the broken moans tearing from her throat. "Pleaseplease, don't stopImstill" —

Wednesday didn't stop, her thumb continuing to circle Enid's clit, gentle now and careful not to overstimulate her, while her other hand held her hip and kept her steady as the waves crashed through her. She rode it out on top of her, trembling and gasping, and when it was finally over, she collapsed forward with her forehead pressed against Wednesday's chest, her breath coming in ragged gasps that fanned across her collarbone.

The room fell quiet, with only the ceiling fan spinning overhead and the vanilla candle flickering nearby. Somewhere in the building, a phone rang and went unanswered.

"Three," Enid whispered.

"What?"

"Three orgasms." Enid pushed herself up on shaky arms and looked down at Wednesday, her face flushed, her hair a disaster, and sweat gleaming in the hollow of her throat. "You've given me three orgasms in one session, that's never happened before with anyone."

"Is that—" Wednesday swallowed, suddenly unsure of herself. "Is that good?"

"It's unprecedented." Enid laughed, breathless and almost giddy. "You're unprecedented."

Enid kissed her, deep and slow, tasting of salt. Wednesday's hands slid up Enid's back and pulled her closer, and Enid melted against her. For a long moment, there was nothing but the kiss, the slide of their lips, the tangle of their tongues, and the shared breath between them.

When Enid finally pulled back, her eyes were wet again, but these weren't tears of overwhelm this time. They were something else, something Wednesday couldn't name.

"I want to keep going," Enid said. "If you're okay with that."

"I'm very okay with that."

"Words."

"Yes. Please. Keep going."

Enid kissed her again, shorter this time, almost like punctuation, before shifting off Wednesday. Her body left a warm imprint against Wednesday's skin as she settled down beside her on the bed, lying on her back and stretching out like a cat in sunlight.

"Your turn," she said. "I want you inside me."

The words hit Wednesday like a physical blow. She had imagined this moment obsessively, in every possible variation, but hearing Enid say it aloud was different; it was real and immediate, no longer something confined to her imagination.

"Are you sure?"

I'm sure." She reached down and touched herself, parting her folds with her fingers as Wednesday watched. "I've been ready since you walked in the door, probably before that, probably since Thursday." She beckoned her with a curl of her fingers. "Come here."

Wednesday moved over Enid, her body settled between Enid's thighs~~fa~~miliar territory now , after weeks of grinding and touching and exploring but this was different. This was the thing they'd been building toward since that first session on her couch, the thing she'd been too nervous to even think about in specific terms.

Her cock pressed against Enid's entrance, the heat of her was staggering~~ev~~en through the barrier of what was about to happen, even without penetration, Wednesday could feel her. The tip of her nestled against those folds, slick and warm and waiting.

"W ait," Enid said.

Wednesday froze. "What's wrong?"

"Nothing's wrong. I just~~"~~She reached up and touched Wednesday's face, her fingers traced the line of her jaw . "I want you to look at me when it happens, don't close your eyes."

"Okay ."

"And go slow , I'll tell you if I need you to stop."

"Okay ."

"And W ednesday?"

"Y eah?"

"This isn't a lesson," Enid said, her blue eyes dark and serious as she held Wednesday's gaze. "I'm not teaching you anything, this is just us, whatever we are, whatever this is between us, okay?"

"Okay ."

Wednesday pushed forward, the head of her cock slipped inside Enid, and the world stopped. The heat was overwhelming~~tig~~hter than her mouth, wetter than her fingers, impossibly soft and impossibly warm, Enid's inner walls stretched to accommodate her , and the sensation of being slowly enveloped made Wednesday's arms tremble.

Enid gasped, her hands gripping Wednesday's shoulders as her blue eyes stayed locked on hers.

"Oh."The word was barely a whisper .

"Are you okay?"

"Y es don't stop, keep~~ke~~ep going."

Wednesday pushed deeper, an inch at a time, as Enid's body gripped her with every forward movement. The tightness gradually gave way to a snug pressure that made Wednesday's vision blur at the edges, and when the angle of her hips shifted, Enid gasped again, louder this time, her nails digging into Wednesday's shoulders.

"Ngh~~fuck~~~~yo~~u~~re~~yo~~u feel"—

"T oo much?"

"Just~~bi~~g, wait give me a second."

Wednesday gave her a second, staying still and letting her body adjust. Enid's inner walls fluttered around her in small, involuntary contractions that sent sparks of pleasure up Wednesday's spine, while Enid breathed hard beneath her, her chest rising and falling as her breasts pressed against Wednesday's chest.

"Okay ,"she said finally . "move but slowly ."

Wednesday moved, pulling back until just the tip was inside Enid before pushing forward again. The slide was easier this time, her

natural lubrication coating her and making the friction smooth and liquid, while the wet sound it produced was obscene, a soft squelch that filled the quiet bedroom.

"Yes," she breathed, her voice soft and shaky. "Just like that, slow and steady."

Wednesday built a rhythm that wasn't fast or frantic, but deliberate, with each thrust was measured, controlled. She watched Enid's face the whole time, cataloguing every reaction and when she angled her hips upward, Enid moaned. When she thrust deeper, Enid's eyes fluttered but didn't close. When she brushed against a particular spot inside her, Enid's whole body shuddered.

"Right there~~do~~ that again"—

She did, keeping the same angle and the same depth, her G-spot, Wednesday realized it was the same spot she'd found with her fingers earlier, and she kept hitting it with every thrust as Enid's responses grew less controlled by the second.

"Oh~~fuck~~~~yes~~~~do~~n't stop" Enid's hips rose to meet hers. Her legs wrapped around Wednesday's waist, pulling her deeper, the new angle made Wednesday groan~~sin~~king into her completely, their bodies flush together.

The wet sounds grew louder and faster as Enid's movements became more urgent, and Wednesday could feel the slickness coating her shaft and dripping down onto her balls, every thrust produced a soft squelch that seemed to echo in the quiet room.

"You're so wet," she said, the words coming out rough, almost reverent. "God, Enid, you're so"—

"I know~~I~~can't help it~~yo~~u make me"—

A particularly deep thrust cut off her words and Enid's head fell back as a broken moan escaped her throat. Her legs tightened around

Wednesday's waist, her pussy clenched around her, a rhythmic flutter that made her own control slip.

"Nghh Enid Im not going to lcant last much longer" —

"Then dont," Enid said, her voice breathless and urgent. "Im close, Im so close, just" She reached between them, her fingers found her own clit, swollen and slick and desperate for attention. She rubbed herself in tight circles, matching the rhythm of Wednesday's thrusts. "Keep doing what youre doing dont stop please dont stop" —

Wednesday didnt stop, her hips drove into her with increasing urgency as the headboard tapped softly against the wall, keeping a steady rhythm with them while the bed creaked beneath their weight. The fairy lights blurred into soft streaks of gold as everything else around them seemed to fade into the background.

"Y esyes, more, Ineed" Enid's voice grew breathless as she held tightly to Wednesday's shoulder, her blue eyes wide and her pupils blown as she stared at her with complete focus, as though Wednesday were the only thing in the universe. "Im going to— Wednesday, Im going to" —

"Cum for me," W ednesday said, the words leaving her mouth before she had time to think, driven by pure instinct and need. "Cum on my cock, Enid, let me feel you."

Enid came. "Ahhh fuckfuckW ednesday" —

Her orgasm hit her like a shockwave, arching her back off the mattress as she clung to Wednesday. Her body tightened around her in rhythmic, pulsing contractions that seemed to go on forever, while her mouth fell open in a silent scream and her blue eyes rolled back in her head.

The sight of her, the feel of her, and the sound of her were simply too much, and Wednesday's own orgasm crashed over her with the

force of a tidal wave. "Enid—fuck—"

Wednesday buried herself deep inside her and came, the first pulse hitting like a flash of white-hot pleasure that erased every thought from her mind. Her vision went white as her hips bucked involuntarily, driving deeper, and she felt her release spill inside Enid in thick, hot spurts pulse after pulse followed, her cock throbbing inside her as warmth spread outward through her entire body.

Her arms finally gave out, and she collapsed forward, catching herself on her elbows with her forehead pressed against Enid's. They were both breathing hard, their ragged, gasping breaths mingling in the small space between their mouths.

For a long moment, neither of them spoke.

The ceiling fan continued to spin above them, the candle flickered softly, and the headboard had finally stopped tapping against the wall. The only sounds left were their uneven breathing and the distant hum of traffic outside the window.

Enid's legs slowly unwound from around Wednesday's waist, while her hands slid from Wednesday's shoulders to her back and stroked gently. Her inner walls still fluttered around her in small, involuntary aftershocks, making Wednesday twitch with overstimulation.

"Holy shit," she whispered, still catching her breath. "You're still inside me."

"I know." Wednesday shifted slightly, and Enid winced. "Sorry, should I—"

"No, stay, just give me a minute." Her fingers traced slow patterns across Wednesday's back. "You're heavy, in a good way, like a weighted blanket."

"That's a new one."

I'm full of new ones tonight." Enid laughed, the sound soft and breathless. "You just came inside me."

"You said, I mean, you didn't say not to-"

"I know, I wanted you to." Her hands slid up into Wednesday's hair, stroking gently. "I'm on birth control, and I'm clean, and you're, well, you're probably pathogen-free."

"I am, I mean, as far as I know."

"Good enough." She kissed Wednesday's forehead. "That was incredible."

"For me too."

"I figured, you made some very interesting noises." Her voice was teasing but soft, almost tender. "You said my name, like, a lot."

"Did I?"

"Oh yeah, it was very flattering."

Wednesday pushed herself up on her elbows and looked down at her. Enid's face was flushed, her blonde hair was a complete disaster, and her lipstick was long gone, leaving her lips swollen and pink. She looked thoroughly fucked, but there was something in her expression that made Wednesday's chest tighten.

"What?" Enid asked.

"Nothing. You're just-" Wednesday searched for the right word and failed.

"Eloquent, I'm eloquence."

"You're beautiful," Wednesday said, the words coming out before she could stop them, and for a moment, she saw something flash in

Enid's blue eyes, something vulnerable that looked almost like fear then the mask slid back into place.

"You're just saying that because you came inside me thirty seconds ago."

"I'm saying it because it's true."

The mask flickered again, and Enid looked away. "We should clean up, you're going to start leaking out of me, and that'll ruin the duvet."

"We couldn't want that."

"No, you wouldn't. This duvet is expensive." She shifted beneath her , and Wednesday took the hint, pulling out slowly and carefully as the sensation made them both inhale sharply. Her cock was slick and softening, glistening with a mixture of Enid's arousal and her cum.

A trickle of white fluid followed her withdrawal, and Enid immediately clapped a hand between her legs. "See? Leaking, told you." She sat up and swung her legs off the bed, then crossed toward the bathroom with an unsteady gait, the slight wobble in her step making Wednesday feel irrationally proud. The bathroom door clicked shut behind her.

Wednesday lay back against the pillows, her body feeling loose and liquid, as though all the tension had been drained out of her and replaced with something warm and heavy. The ceiling fan spun overhead while the fairy lights blurred into soft streaks of gold, and she could hear Enid moving around in the bathroom, the water running as a cabinet opened and closed.

A few minutes later, Enid emerged wearing a silk robe the color of champagne. It hung open at the front, and Wednesday could see the curve of her breasts, the flat plane of her stomach, and the faint gleam of moisture between her thighs. She tossed Wednesday a damp washcloth.

"Clean up, you're a mess."

She was, indeed, a mess as her cock was still slick, her stomach was smeared with Enid's arousal, and the duvet beneath her was, Wednesday looked down and winced.

"Sorry about the duvet."

"Don't be, I have a washing machine." Enid flopped onto the bed beside her and propped herself up on one elbow. "So, that was penetration."

"That was definitely penetration."

"How do you feel?"

"Good, really good, tired, mostly." Wednesday wiped herself down with the washcloth and tossed it onto the nightstand. "Is that normal?"

"Very normal. Orgasms release oxytocin and prolactin, and they make you sleepy," she said with a grin. "See, I paid attention in bio."

"You failed bio."

"I failed bio because I was busy having sex instead of studying, that doesn't mean I didn't learn anything." She reached out and traced a finger down Wednesday's chest. "You did really well tonight, your instincts were good."

"I had a good partner."

"You keep saying that."

"It keeps being true."

Enid was quiet for a moment, her finger continuing to trace slow patterns across Wednesday's chest, tracing the line of her

collarbone, the dip of her sternum, and the faint definition of her abdominal muscles, lean from her fencing training.

"Can I ask you something?" Enid said finally .

"Anything."

"Earlier tonight, you said you shook your head at Mia at the party ." Enid didn't look at W ednesday, keeping her eyes fixed on her own finger as it traced invisible patterns across Wednesday's skin. "I asked why, and you said you were having fun with the other girls, but was that really it, or was there something else?"

Wednesday considered the question for a moment, watching the ceiling fan spin lazily overhead while the candle flickered beside them.

"There might have been something else."

"What?"

"I don't know if I can explain it."

"T ry."

Wednesday turned her head to look at Enid. The robe had slipped from one shoulder, her blonde hair was still a tangled mess, and her lips remained swollen from everything that had happened between them. She looked vulnerable, completely unguarded, as though the mask had slipped away while she wasn't paying attention.

"Mia is, she's what I thought I wanted, smart, serious, focused, everything I thought I should be attracted to." W ednesday paused, searching for the right words. "B t when I saw her across the room, I didn't feel the way I expected to feel. I wasn't nervous, and I wasn't excited, I just felt nothing or not nothing, exactly , I felt-"

"Complicated."

"Yeah, complicated." Wednesday reached up and brushed a strand of hair away from Enid's face, the gesture unexpectedly tender. "You said earlier that you're looking forward to Thursdays, I am too. I've been looking forward to them since the second session."

"Wednesday-"

"I'm not saying it's feelings, and I'm not saying it's love or romance or whatever. I'm just saying that whatever this is, whatever we're doing, it's not just a transaction, not for me."

Enid stared at Wednesday, the mask definitely gone now. Wednesday could see everything Enid had been trying so hard to hide behind sarcasm, bravado, and those wicked grins, the wariness, the fear, and the vulnerability underneath it all. Enid looked terrified, but for the first time since Wednesday had known her, she also looked completely and utterly honest.

"It's not a transaction for me either," Enid whispered. "It hasn't been for a while, and I don't know what to do with that."

"You don't have to do anything. We agreed, we're just experiencing it."

"But experiences have consequences."

"Do they have to?"

Enid gave a short, sharp laugh. "That's actually the most terrifying thing you've said all night."

"Why?"

"Because if experiences don't have consequences, then I can't control them, and if I can't control them..." Enid stopped and swallowed. "I've spent years building walls, you know that, I told you, sex is armor, sex is currency, sex is a tool. I don't do feelings, I don't do vulnerability, and I don't do this."

She gestured between them, the motion sharp and almost angry.

"This," Wednesday said, "is just two people lying in bed after sex, that's it, that's all it has to be."

"But what if it's not?"

"Then we figure it out together, as partners."

"Partners, that's a loaded word."

"So is student, so is teacher, and we've been using loaded words this whole time."

Enid stayed quiet for a long moment, and neither of them spoke as the candle flickered and the fairy lights blurred softly around them. Somewhere in the building, someone started playing music, something acoustic and melancholy that drifted faintly through the room.

"Okay," Enid said finally.

"Okay?"

"Okay, partners, whatever that means." Enid leaned in and kissed Wednesday, soft and slow and surprisingly chaste. "But we're still not calling it feelings."

"Deal."

"And you're still not allowed to be this sweet, it's annoying."

"I'll try."

"And I'm still teaching you things, this arrangement isn't over just because we had sex."

"What else is there to teach?"

Enid grinned, the wicked grin Wednesday had come to recognize as both armor and invitation. "Oh, nerdy , you have no idea."

Enid kissed her again, and Wednesday closed her eyes and for the first time in as long as she could remember, she didn't think about what came next. She simply lay there in the warm glow of the fairy lights, Enid's body pressed against her own lean, fencer's frame, the taste of Enid still lingering on her lips, and let herself experience it.

Eventually, Enid pulled back, and her expression shifted as something calculating crept back into her eyes, something that looked suspiciously like a plan. "What?" W ednesday asked.

"Nothing, just thinking."

"About what?"

"Next Thursday ." She traced a finger down W ednesday's chest. "I think it's time we expanded the curriculum."

"Expanded how?"

"Y ou'll see." She sat up and tightened the belt on her robe. "But first, you should probably go home. It's late, and you have class tomorrow."

Wednesday glanced at the clock on her nightstand. It was 1 1:47 PM, and she'd been there for five hours, though it felt like both an eternity and the blink of an eye. "Y eah, probably." She pulled on her black boxer briefs, then her black jeans and black henley , her body feeling different somehow, loose and heavy but strangely comfortable. Enid walked her to the door, her bare feet padding softly across the hardwood as the vanilla candle burned down to a stub.

At the door, Enid stopped her with a hand against her chest. "Same time next Thursday," she said. "Don't be late."

"W ouldn't dream of it."

"And W ednesday?"

"Y eah?"

"W ear the contacts again." Her wicked grin flickered. "I like seeing your eyes." She kissed W ednesday, quick and firm, then gently pushed her out the door. It clicked shut behind her , leaving Wednesday standing in the dark hallway and staring at the number 42B with the unsettling feeling that the entire world had shifted on its axis.

Her phone buzzed in her pocket with a message from Enid: *Im serious about the contacts. Your glasses are adorable, but your eyes are better.*

Wednesday typed back, *Noted, good night, Enid.*

Good night, nerdy .

Wednesday walked home through the spring darkness, the humidity clinging to her skin, the taste of Enid still on her tongue. The streetlights cast pools of amber on the sidewalk, the crickets starting their nightly chorus, and somewhere in her chest, in the space where anxiety used to live, there was something new, something that felt a lot like hope.

When she got back to her apartment, Bianca was still on the couch, chips on her chest and socks on the floor, exactly where Wednesday had left her hours ago.

"Dude," Bianca said, not looking up from her phone. "Y ou've been gone for like five hours, were you with the scary hot tutor?"

"She's not scary ."

"That's not a denial."

Wednesday kicked off her sneakers and collapsed onto the opposite end of the couch. "W e had a good session."

"A good session," Bianca repeated, finally looking up as her eyes narrowed. "You're doing that smug, post-coital thing, I know that look, I've had it myself."

"I don't know what you're talking about."

"Uh-huh," Bianca said with a grin. "Well, good for you, girl, truly. You've been wound tighter than a drum since freshman year, so it's nice to see you finally looking a little more unwound."

"Unwound is one word for it," Wednesday said.

"It's the only one." Bianca turned back to her phone, then added, "Just don't get murdered, I meant that before, and I still mean it."

"I'll do my best."

Wednesday lay back on the couch, staring at the ceiling, which was water-stained with a faint brown ring spreading from the corner, evidence of a leak the landlord kept promising to fix. It looked nothing like Enid's pristine white ceiling with its spinning fan and soft fairy lights, but Wednesday smiled anyway, already wishing Thursday would come faster.

Chapter End Notes

> And just like that, Wednesday's virginity has officially left the syllabus.

Chapter 7: The Improvisation Lesson

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The following Tuesday was a disaster of atmospheric pressure.

Wednesday had spent the last four days in a state of heightened awareness, counting the hours until Thursday and analyzing the way Enid's texts had shifted from "tutor-student" to something more intimate, more domestic.

Then came the Sociology mixer.

It was a mandatory department event, a sea of beige cardigans and forced networking. Wednesday had avoided it for three years but Dr. Hendricks had insisted. She stood on the periphery, her back against a white wall, watching the crowd with her usual detached clinicality. She was dressed in her signature monochrome, a high-collared black blouse and tailored trousers that hugged her lean, athletic frame, the physique of a dedicated fencer.

Then she saw her.

Enid was in the center of a small circle, looking radiant in a cropped pink sweater and a skirt that was barely legal. She was laughing, that loud, genuine laugh that Wednesday had come to associate with the aftermath of an orgasm, and she wasn't alone.

A guy, senior, probably a political science major, wearing a polo shirt that screamed "trust fund," was leaning into her space, too far. His hand was resting on the small of Enid's back, his fingers splaying across the fabric of her skirt in a way that was far too familiar.

Wednesday felt a sudden, sharp spike of something that wasn't academic. It wasn't "socialization theory"; it was a cold, hard knot of

possessiveness that tightened in her gut, making her vision narrow until the only things in the room were Enid and the hand on her back.

She watched the guy whisper something in Enid's ear, and Enid tilted her head back, smiling, her eyes fluttering.

Wednesday didn't realize she had moved until she was standing directly behind her.

The guy didn't see her coming. Wednesday didn't make a scene, she didn't shout or push;she simply stepped into the circle and placed a hand on Enid's waist. She didn't just touch her;she gripped her, her fingers digging into the soft curve of Enid's hip and pulling her flush against her side with a strength that was unmistakably territorial.

The effect was instantaneous, Enid jumped slightly, her breath hitching as she looked up at Wednesday, her blue eyes widening.

The guy frowned, looking Wednesday up and down. "And who are you?"

Wednesday didn't look at him. She kept her gaze fixed on Enid, her thumb tracing a slow, deliberate line across Enid's hip bone, a ghost of the touch she'd used on the kitchen counter.

"I'm her tutor," Wednesday said, her voice a low, dangerous velvet, "and we have a lot of material to cover, so we're leaving."

"Wait, we were just talking about—"

Wednesday finally looked at the man. It wasn't a glare;it was a dissection. She looked at him as if he were a particularly boring specimen under a microscope. "You're blocking the exit, so move."

The guy blinked, confused and intimidated by the sheer, frozen intensity of Wednesday's expression, before stepping back.

Wednesday didn't wait for a goodbye. She kept her hand locked on Enid's waist and led her out of the hall, her grip tight and her stride

long. She didn't speak until they were in the parking lot, the cool night air hitting them.

Enid stopped abruptly, pulling away from Wednesday. She was breathless, a small, mischievous smile playing on her lips. "What was that? Since when do you do protective girlfriend?"

"I don't," Wednesday said, her voice tight, "I just find that specific brand of social interaction repulsive."

"You were jealous," Enid teased, stepping closer, her eyes dancing, "the great, detached Wednesday is actually jealous. Oh my god, that is so hot."

Wednesday's jaw tightened. "I am not hot, I am annoyed."

"You're practically vibrating," Enid whispered, reaching up to touch Wednesday's chest, "your heart is racing. Is that part of the curriculum, nerdy?"

Wednesday grabbed Enid's wrist, not hard, but firm. The detachment was gone, and the clinical observation had been replaced by a raw, pulsing need to erase every single trace of that other man's touch from Enid's body.

"Thursday," she said, her voice dropping an octave, "we will continue our session."

"I'll be ready," Enid breathed, her smile widening, "I can't wait to see what you've 'studied' for this week."

Thursday, 3:

Change of plans, come over at 6 instead of 7 and skip lunch.

Wednesday stared at her phone, the screen reflecting off her glasses. She'd worn them to class, contacts be damned, because

Dr. Hendricks had scheduled a surprise quiz on socialization theory, and Wednesday needed to see the fine print. There had been thirty-two multiple-choice questions, all of which she'd finished in twelve minutes.

Skip lunch.

Her stomach did something complicated, and it wasn't hunger. It was anticipation, perhaps, the kind of low-grade electrical hum that had been running through her since last Thursday, since her bed, the ceiling fan, the fairy lights, and the way she'd said partners.

But beneath that anticipation was a colder, sharper current, the memory of that boy's hand on Enid. The image had been an unwelcome guest in Wednesday's mind since Tuesday, a smudge on a clean canvas that she felt a compulsive need to scrub away. She didn't just want to see Enid; she wanted to reclaim her, to replace every lingering trace of someone else's touch with her own and mark Enid as hers in a way that was undeniable and absolute. The thought made Wednesday grip the phone a little tighter.

"What's that face?" Bianca asked from the couch, the same couch surrounded by the same chips and the same socks on the floor. The living room had reached a level of entropy that Wednesday had stopped trying to fight.

"What face?"

"The face you've been making every Thursday for the past month, like you're about to walk into a final you haven't studied for, but you're weirdly excited about it."

"I studied."

"That's not the point." Bianca crunched a chip. "You're seeing her again tonight."

"I'm tutoring her tonight."

"Uh-huh, and last week you came home at midnight with your shirt inside out."

Wednesday looked down at her shirt, which was currently right-side out. "That was an accident."

"Sure it was." Bianca returned her attention to whatever was playing on her phone, a video game stream judging by the tinny sound coming from it. "Just don't get murdered."

"You say that every time."

"Because every time I mean it."

At 5:47 PM, Wednesday stood outside apartment 42B

She'd compromised on the glasses, wearing her contacts but bringing the glasses as backup in her messenger bag, along with her Sociology 201 textbook and the study guide Enid had asked for, three pages of neatly organized bullet points on collective behavior and social movements, written in her precise handwriting on cardstock because Enid had once mentioned that she liked the weight of good paper. Wednesday had also decided that seeing Enid clearly tonight was preferable to letting her mind fill in the details of someone else's hands on her.

The door swung open before she could knock.

Enid leaned against the frame, wearing yoga pants and an oversized sweater that had slipped off one shoulder, exposing the strap of something lacy and dark green. She was barefoot, her hair pulled into a messy ponytail that looked effortless and probably took twenty minutes to achieve.

"Six o'clock," Enid said, "you're three minutes early."

"Is that a problem?"

"No, it's unexpected." Enid stepped aside. "Come in."

The apartment smelled different, not vanilla, but something sharper, citrus, perhaps lemon and rosemary. A diffuser hummed on the kitchen counter, puffing tiny clouds of scented steam, while the fairy lights were already on, draped over the curtain rod and casting their soft gold glow across the living room.

"Something smells good."

"I cleaned," Enid closed the door behind her, "well, I wiped down the counters, same thing."

"That's not"—

"It's a new candle, grapefruit and something, it was on sale." Enid turned to face Wednesday, her expression flickering for a moment and revealing something nervous underneath the bravado. "You look good, the contacts are back again."

"You told me to."

"I know, I just didn't expect you to listen." Enid reached up and touched Wednesday's jaw, her fingers cool against her skin. "Your face is different without the glasses, more defined."

"I have cheekbones?"

"Tragically, yes." Enid dropped her hand, then added, "Okay, so, tonight, I've been thinking about what I said, about expanding the curriculum." She walked past Wednesday into the kitchen, where the counter was clean, genuinely clean, with no coffee mugs or scattered papers in sight, then hopped up onto it with practiced ease. Her bare legs swung against the cabinets as she continued, "You've done really well with the basics, eye contact, kissing, oral, penetration, all of that."

"Thank you."

I'm not done." Enid leaned back on her hands, and the sweater slipped further off her shoulder, revealing that the lacy strap was definitely dark green. "You're good at the mechanics, and you're good at following your instincts but there's something else you need to learn."

"And that is?"

"Improvisation."

Wednesday set her messenger bag on the floor. "Improvisation."

"Sex isn't always planned, nerdy , it's not always on a bed, and it's not always at the same time, in the same place, with the same setup. Sometimes it just happens." Enid gestured around the kitchen. "Like, say, right here, right now, with no candles, no music, just us."

"Right now ."

"Right now ." Enid's grin flickered. "Unless you're not hungry ."

The skip-lunch text, the clean counter, and the way Enid was sitting, legs slightly apart, bare feet dangling, sweater slipping off her shoulder like an invitation, all made the implication impossible to miss.

"I'm starving," W ednesday said.

"God, then come here."

Wednesday crossed the kitchen in three steps, the tile cool beneath her sneakers. The citrus smell was stronger here, sharp and clean as it cut through the warmth of the apartment. As Wednesday approached, Enid spread her legs wider, making room for her between her thighs.

As Wednesday stepped into her space, something like a remembered memory glinted in Enid's eyes. "So," she whispered,

her voice humming with mischief, “did you spend the last two days studying, or were you too busy with your usual curriculum?”

Wednesday’s hands gripped Enid’s thighs, her fingers digging in slightly. “I spent the last two days wondering how to ef ficiently remove his memory from your skin.”

Enid let out a soft, shaky laugh and leaned forward until their foreheads touched. “Y ou were jealous, admit it, W ednesday. You were absolutely possessive.”

"Possessiveness is a primitive instinct," W ednesday murmured, her gaze dropping to Enid's lips, "and currently , it is the only instinct I care about."

"Ground rules," Enid breathed, though she was already arching toward Wednesday, "same as last time, follow your instincts. I'll give feedback if you need it, but I don't think you will."

"Y ou have a lot of faith in me."

"I have a lot of evidence." Enid hooked her fingers into the waistband of Wednesday's black trousers and pulled her closer , feeling the hard length of Wednesday's penis pressing firmly against her . "Now , improvise."

Wednesday kissed her, not with the careful, practiced kisses from their early sessions or the slow exploration of last week, but with something hungrier. Her hands found Enid’s waist, the soft wool of her sweater bunching beneath her fingers as she pulled Enid to the edge of the counter. Enid made a sound against her mouth, half surprise and half approval, and wrapped her legs around Wednesday’s hips.

"Mmm~~ok~~ay ," Enid murmured when she pulled back, breathing hard, "good start, very good start."

"I've been thinking about this all week."

"About kissing me?"

"About everything." Wednesday kissed the corner of Enid's mouth, then the spot where her jaw met her ear, before moving to the tendon that ran down her throat. She remembered that spot, the one that made Enid gasp, so she lingered there, her teeth grazing the skin, and the gasp that followed was just as satisfying as she remembered.

"Fuck-okay, you definitely remember that spot."

"I remember all of them."

"Prove it."

Wednesday's hands slid beneath Enid's sweater. The wool was soft, but Enid's skin was softer, and Wednesday pushed the fabric upward, exposing her stomach, tanned and toned, the muscles twitching beneath her touch, before continuing higher over the lacy dark green bra she'd only glimpsed before. Enid lifted her arms to help her, and the sweater came off, joining the messenger bag on the floor.

"There," Wednesday said, looking at Enid, "better."

"You're getting bossy."

"You told me to improvise."

"I did, didn't I?" Enid's hands found the hem of Wednesday's black blouse. "Fair's fair, you're wearing too many clothes."

She pulled the blouse over Wednesday's head with practiced efficiency, leaving Wednesday's glasses forgotten inside her messenger bag on the floor. Enid's palms flattened against Wednesday's chest, tracing the lean, firm lines of muscle that fencing had carved into her shoulders and stomach, the lithe

strength of an athlete hidden beneath her usual monochrome tailoring.

"God, you're built," Enid murmured, running her hands over Wednesday's body. "It's unfair, you hide this under high collars and structured blazers."

"My style is a curated expression of my internal void."

"Change it," Enid kissed Wednesday's collarbone, "stand up straight and show people what you've got."

"My mother tells me the same thing."

"Your mother sounds smart, so stop talking about your mother."

Wednesday's laugh was cut short when Enid's mouth found hers again, hungrier now and far less restrained. Enid's tongue slid against Wednesday's, and she tasted something sweet, lip gloss perhaps, or the tea Enid had been drinking before she arrived. Enid's legs tightened around Wednesday's waist, pulling their hips flush against the edge of the counter as she moved against Wednesday through their clothes.

The friction was electric, and even through the layers of fabric, Wednesday could feel the heat of Enid's body, the pressure, and the way Enid's breath hitched whenever she pushed back.

"You're hard already," Enid said against Wednesday's mouth.

"You're sitting on a counter in a bra, of course I am."

"Fair point." Enid pulled back and looked at Wednesday, her pupils blown wide and the gold flecks in her blue eyes nearly swallowed by black. Her ponytail was already coming loose, honey blonde strands falling around her face as she watched Wednesday. "Okay, here's what I want."

"Tell me."

"I want your mouth right here." Enid pointed toward the counter. "I want you to eat me out until I come, and I don't want you to stop when I do; keep going until I tell you to stop. Can you do that?"

"Yes."

"Words."

"Yes, I can do that."

"Good." Enid leaned back on her hands again, the position pushing her chest forward while the dark green bra did little to contain her breasts. "Then get to work."

Wednesday dropped to her knees.

The kitchen tile was hard and cold through her trousers, but she barely noticed. Her hands found the waistband of Enid's yoga pants—black, stretchy—already damp in the center where her arousal had soaked through. She hooked her fingers in and tugged. Enid lifted her hips automatically, and the pants came down over her thighs, over her knees, and off one ankle then the other, landing in a silent puddle on the floor.

Beneath them, her panties were black lace. Sheer enough that Wednesday could see the shadow of her folds beneath and wet enough that the fabric clung to her skin, outlining every contour.

"These too," Wednesday said, and Enid lifted her hips again.

The panties peeled away with a sound that was almost sticky fabric separating from skin, a thin string of moisture stretching between her body and the lace before it broke. Wednesday set them aside without looking, her attention fixed on what was in front of her.

Her pussy was as beautiful as Wednesday remembered; completely bare and the skin smooth and soft-looking. Her outer lips were a shade of pink that reminded her of the inside of a seashell, pale at

the edges and deepening to rose at the center. The inner lips were darker, dusky pink and slightly asymmetrical, the left side just a fraction fuller than the right. They glistened with her arousal, slick and wet, and as Wednesday watched, a fresh bead of moisture gathered at Enid's entrance and slid downward.

"You're wet already," Wednesday breathed as her fingers traced the inside of Enid's thigh, the muscle trembling beneath her touch. Her gaze stayed fixed on Enid's face. "Were you thinking about him or me?"

"I've been thinking about you, about this, all day," Enid's voice was strained. "All week, actually. Every time I sat on this counter, whether it was having coffee in the morning, eating a granola bar or just waiting for the microwave, I kept thinking about you down there, exactly where you are now."

Wednesday's expression remained unreadable, though some of the tension in her jaw eased. "God," she murmured. "Because I didn't like seeing him with you, I didn't like the way he was looking at you and I especially didn't like wondering if you were thinking about him while I was about to come here."

Enid studied her for a moment, then smiled faintly. "You really were jealous."

"I didn't like him touching you."

The teasing disappeared from Enid's expression. "Wednesday-"

"I wanted your attention on me," Wednesday admitted, her voice quieter now. "Not him."

Enid's breath caught, and she looked at Wednesday for a long moment before her lips curved into a small, satisfied smile. "Okay," she whispered. "Now I understand."

Wednesday pressed a kiss to Enid's inner thigh, lingering just long enough to make her squirm before slowly moving higher. "God—"

Enid shivered, already knowing from the look in Wednesday's eyes that she was about to tease her again. "Just stop talking, please," she breathed, her voice almost pleading.

A faint smile tugged at Wednesday's lips, as though Enid's reaction had only encouraged her. Instead of saying anything else, Wednesday lowered her mouth, and her tongue touched Enid's folds, the taste of her flooding her senses, salty and musky with something sharper underneath, perhaps the citrus from the candle, or perhaps simply Enid herself. She licked upward from her entrance to her clit, slow and deliberate, and Enid's whole body shuddered.

"Oh yes." The sound of Enid's voice went straight to Wednesday's cock, but she ignored it, spreading Enid's thighs wider with her hands, holding her open as she settled in and ate her like she was starving.

Her tongue traced those folds, moving up one side and down the other as she followed the asymmetrical shape of Enid's inner lips with careful attention, then she sucked the fuller left lip into her mouth and flicked her tongue against it, making Enid gasp as her hips bucked forward. Wednesday's fingers dug into those thighs to keep her in place.

"Jesus Wednesday" Enid gasped, and Wednesday switched sides, the right lip smaller but just as sensitive, and when she sucked gently, Enid's moan echoed off the kitchen cabinets. Enid's hands found Wednesday's head, her fingers threading through her hair, not guiding her, just holding on.

Wednesday's tongue slid lower to where Enid's entrance was wet and warm, fluttering against her mouth, and she pushed inside just the tip, the taste of Enid intensifying, salt and musk and something that made Wednesday's head spin. Her nose pressed against Enid's

clit as she thrust deeper, the pressure making Enid cry out, "Ahh—there, don't stop"

Wednesday didn't stop, her tongue working in and out of Enid's pussy, mimicking the rhythm she'd learned last week, the same rhythm that had made Enid come on her cock, slow at first, then faster, before slowing again, teasing and withdrawing just as Enid's breathing quickened.

"Fuck you're teasing me"—

Wednesday pulled back just enough to speak, "You told me to improvise."

"I didn't tell you to be—ngh" The rest of Enid's sentence dissolved into a moan as Wednesday's mouth returned to her clit, which was swollen now, peeking out from its hood, pink, glistening, and desperate for attention. Wednesday circled it with the tip of her tongue once, then twice, making Enid's hips jerk before flattening her tongue and licking broad stripes across Enid's entire pussy, from entrance to clit and back again.

Enid's grip on Wednesday's hair tightened. "Yes fuck just don't stop"

Wednesday sucked her clit into her mouth, and the sound Enid made was inhuman, high-pitched and broken, echoing off the cabinets and filling the kitchen. Her thighs clamped around Wednesday's head, and Wednesday felt the vibration of Enid's moan through her entire body as Enid let her ride her face, not licking now, but simply holding steady pressure with her mouth while those hips bucked against her.

"Please please, I'm so close," Enid pleaded, and Wednesday pulled back just enough to catch her breath before saying, "Then cum."

"I need more."

"Tell me."

"Your fingers inside," Enid said, panting, her chest heaving and the green bra straining with every breath. "Please, Wednesday."

Wednesday slid two fingers into her without warning, knuckle-deep and palm up, the "come here" motion she'd perfected last week pressing firmly against the textured spot on Enid's front wall, while her mouth returned to Enid's clit at the same moment, her tongue flat and licking hard and fast.

Enid shattered with a cry, "Ahhh~~fuc~~k, Wednesday~~ye~~s, yes, yes," her orgasm hitting like a wave crashing through her body as her back arched off the counter and her hands fisted in Wednesday's hair, while her pussy clenched around those fingers in rhythmic pulses that seemed to go on forever. Wednesday kept licking through the whole thing, softer now and gentler to avoid overstimulating Enid, but she didn't stop, just like Enid had asked.

"Oh god~~oh~~ god~~fuc~~k" The words tumbled out broken and breathless as the aftershocks rolled through Enid, her thighs trembling against Wednesday's head and her stomach muscles fluttering while a fresh gush of wetness coated Wednesday's fingers and dripped down onto her wrist.

She didn't stop, slowly and carefully withdrawing her fingers before replacing them with her tongue, thrusting deep inside Enid to drink down the taste of her climax while Enid's clit pulsed against her nose.

"Too much~~it's~~ too much" Enid was squirming now, torn between pulling Wednesday closer and pushing her away, her hips bucking with a mind of their own, until Wednesday finally pulled back and asked, "Do you want me to stop?"

"~~fuck~~I~~do~~n't know"~~—~~

"Words, Enid."

The use of her full name seemed to snap something into focus, and Enid's eyes met Wednesday's, dark and wild and desperate. "Don't stop. Please. Don't—I need—"

Wednesday didn't let her finish, returning her mouth to Enid's pussy, but softer this time, with no tongue inside and no direct pressure on her clit, just gentle kisses pressed to her inner thighs, her outer lips, and the smooth skin of her mons. She nuzzled against Enid, the scent of Enid filling her senses, and felt Enid's body slowly relax as the trembling eased and the death grip on Wednesday's hair loosened.

Then, slowly and incrementally, Wednesday started again, her tongue tracing the seam of those outer lips, feather-light and barely there. Enid whimpered but didn't pull away, so Wednesday did it again with slightly more pressure this time, and the whimper became a moan.

"God," Wednesday asked.

"Yes—please more"

Her tongue parted those folds to find the clit, still swollen and still sensitive, and she circled it without touching, the air from her breath making Enid shiver. She traced the hood instead, following the sensitive skin around it and the spot where the hood met the shaft, and when Enid moaned low and long, Wednesday finally touched the tip of her tongue to the exposed head.

Enid came again, not as violently as the first time, but with a softer climax that somehow felt deeper, her pussy clenching around nothing while her moan came out as a long, broken exhale of Wednesday's name. Her head fell back against the cabinet, and her legs went limp around Wednesday's shoulders.

"Holy shit," she whispered.

Wednesday sat back on her heels, her jaw aching and her lips numb, while her erection was so hard it hurt, pressing painfully against her trousers and demanding the attention she'd been refusing for what felt like hours, but none of that mattered because Enid was looking at her like she'd just performed a miracle.

"Two," Enid said, "that's two."

"You're counting?"

"I'm always counting." She wiped her mouth with the back of her hand, her skin glistening as she added, "You taste incredible."

"That's—" Enid swallowed. "That's a new thing to say."

"It's a true thing." Wednesday stood up, her knees popping slightly. "Are you okay?"

"Am I?" Enid laughed, breathless and giddy. "I just came twice on my kitchen counter. I'm better than okay, I'm fuck, Wednesday, I'm ruined for anyone else."

The words hung in the air between them, and Enid's eyes widened as though she hadn't meant to say them out loud.

"Sorry," she said quickly, "that was dramatic. Ignore that."

"Ignore what?"

She stared at Wednesday, then laughed again, the sound genuine and surprised, as if she'd done something unexpected. "You're too good at this, the whole thing..the—" She gestured vaguely. "—everything."

"I had a good teacher."

"Stop being charming." She slid off the counter, her bare feet landing silently on the tile, but her legs wobbled and she grabbed the edge for balance. "Okay wow, standing is hard."

"T ake your time."

"I don't want to take my time." She stepped toward W ednesday, still unsteady and flushed, wearing nothing but that dark green bra with its lacy straps and sheer cups that did nothing except make Wednesday harder. "I want you to fuck me."

"Here?"

"Against the fridge," Enid said, as though it were the most obvious thing in the world. "I told you, improvisation."

The fridge was stainless steel, smudged with fingerprints and covered in takeout menus held up by magnets shaped like fruit, a pineapple, a watermelon, and a bunch of grapes. Wednesday didn't know why that detail stuck with her, the absurdity of fruit magnets in this moment, but it did.

Enid turned around and pressed her palms flat against the fridge door, arching her back as the position made her ass look incredible, round and toned and perfectly positioned, while her pussy was visible between her thighs, still glistening and wet.

"W ell?" She looked over her shoulder at W ednesday, her ponytail completely ruined now, hair cascading down her back. "What are you waiting for?"

"Nothing." W ednesday stepped behind her. "Absolutely nothing."

Her trousers came off faster than they ever had before, followed by her underwear as her cock sprang free, aching and flushed and already leaking at the tip. She fisted herself once just to take the edge off, and the relief was so sharp that it made her gasp.

Enid glanced back at the sound, her eyes dropping to Wednesday's hand on her cock as she wet her lips with her tongue. "Don't get too comfortable with that," she said. "That's mine now ."

"Possessive."

"You have no idea."

Wednesday stepped closer, the tile cold beneath her bare feet while the fridge hummed against Enid's palms. Her hands found Enid's hips, still slick from the sweat of those orgasms, and pulled them back until her cock nudged against Enid's entrance, hot, slick, and waiting.

"Condom?" she asked.

"Still on birth control, still clean." Enid pushed back against her , and the head slipped inside just enough to make them both groan. "Fuck, you feel so big from this angle"—

"I haven't even"—

"Just do it please, I need you inside me."

Wednesday pushed forward, the slide effortless because Enid was so wet that there was almost no resistance, just the velvet grip of her pussy parting around her inch by inch. The angle was different from last week, tighter and deeper, and Wednesday could feel the curve of Enid's spine against her chest and the press of her ass against her hips.

"Ahhh yes, more." Enid pushed back, and W ednesday sank in to the hilt.

They both froze, Wednesday's forehead dropping to Enid's shoulder blade as her breath came in ragged gasps against her skin, while Enid's inner walls fluttered around her in small, involuntary contractions that made Wednesday's vision blur .

"Enid, fuck, you're so tight."

"So good, your cock, it feels so amazing." Enid's nails scraped against the stainless steel fridge door. "Move, please, fuck me."

Wednesday moved, not slow this time and not careful, her hips pulling back before snapping forward as the wet sound of each thrust echoed through the kitchen. Enid's moans grew louder , broken and desperate, while her hands slipped against the fridge door.

"Y es, harder, please."

Wednesday gave her harder, her fingers digging into Enid's hips hard enough to bruise as she drove into her with a rhythm that was more instinct than thought, deeper and faster with every thrust, making the magnets on the fridge rattle, the watermelon, pineapple, and grapes all dancing with the force of her movements.

"Oh, fuck, oh fuck, right there." Enid's head dropped between her arms as her ass pressed back to meet every thrust. "Don't stop, don't stop, don't stop."

Wednesday reached around her and found her clit, and Enid screamed, the sound high, sharp, and completely unguarded as it echoed off the cabinets, the tile, and the ceiling. Enid's body tightened around Wednesday as her third orgasm ripped through her with such force that it nearly pushed Wednesday away, but she kept thrusting and rubbing anyway, continuing through it as Enid screamed her name and babbled incoherent praise, shuddering so violently that the fridge door rattled on its hinges until finally the tension in Wednesday's own body wound too tight to hold.

"Enid, I'm going to—"

"Y es, yes, please."

Wednesday buried herself deep and came.

The orgasm hit her like a freight train, hot and blinding, starting at the base of her spine before exploding outward. Her hips bucked involuntarily, driving deeper, while wave after wave of sensation wrung sounds from her throat, each one somewhere between Enid's name and something more primal.

The kitchen went quiet, leaving only the hum of the fridge, the soft hiss of the diffuser, and the ragged sound of their breathing mingling in the citrus-scented air.

Wednesday's forehead was pressed against Enid's shoulder blade, her hands were still gripping those hips. Her cock was still inside, softening now but still buried deep.

"I can't feel my legs," Enid whispered.

"That's probably bad."

"It's probably incredible." She laughed, the sound weak and breathless.

Enid turned her head just enough to look back at Wednesday. Her face was flushed, her hair was a complete disaster, and her mascara had run, leaving faint dark smudges beneath her eyes. She looked thoroughly, completely, beautifully wrecked.

"You're going to spoil me," she said. "I'm going to start expecting this every time."

"Is that bad?"

"It's terrifying."

Wednesday pulled out slowly, carefully, and Enid winced at the loss. A trickle of white followed, sliding down her inner thigh and dripping onto the tile without her seeming to notice.

"Okay." Enid pushed herself off the fridge on shaky arms. "Okay, I need a shower, now."

"That's probably a good idea."

"You should join me." She said it like an afterthought, but her eyes were anything but casual as she looked at Wednesday. "Save water, environmentalism, very important."

Mia would approve."

The name slipped out before Wednesday could stop herself, and this time Enid's reaction was impossible to miss. Her grin faltered for half a second, her jaw tightening before she quickly covered it with that familiar wicked smile, though there was a sharpness underneath it now, something unmistakably jealous. She looked away, then back at Wednesday, as if trying to decide whether she wanted to ask the question that had clearly crossed her mind.

"Mia Carter can approve from a distance," Enid said, her voice lighter than her expression. "She's not the one standing here with you, is she?"

"Is that supposed to mean I'm busy with you?"

Enid's eyes narrowed playfully, but the jealousy was still there beneath the teasing. "You're about to be."

Enid grabbed Wednesday's hand and pulled her toward the bathroom, naked except for the bra that had somehow survived the whole encounter, dark green and lacy and clinging to her breasts by sheer determination. Wednesday let herself be pulled, still catching her breath, still tasting Enid on her tongue.

Behind them, the kitchen held the evidence of their lust, with Enid's yoga pants abandoned on the floor, her panties lying on the cold tile, and a smear of condensation on the stainless-steel fridge shaped like her handprints. Even the fruit magnets were still vibrating faintly from the force of everything that had just happened.

The shower was small, barely big enough for one person and definitely not designed for two, but Enid made it work. She pulled Wednesday under the spray and kissed her while the hot water sluiced over their bodies, washing away the sweat, the cum, and the citrus-scented air.

"You know," Enid said, pulling back just enough to speak, "we didn't study at all."

"We did, before you asked me to come to that party, we had our session and studied Sociology, regression analysis and you made me explain correlation versus causation for twenty minutes."

Enid blinked, then laughed, the sound genuine and a little surprised, "Oh my god, you're right, we actually did study . I've completely lost track of time, you've made me lose track of time and that's a new thing for me"

"A good thing?"

"A weird thing for us." She soaped up her hands and ran them over Wednesday's chest. "Everything about this is weirdly sexy . I don't normally do this, I don't do multiple orgasms like this, I don't usually do cuddling, and I definitely don't shower with someone because I want to keep touching them constantly."

"Is that what this is?"

"Apparently so." Her hands slid lower . "Your cock is still half-hard, how is it still half-hard?"

"Biological imperatives."

"Biological imperatives of lust." Enid wrapped her hand around it, gentle and exploratory. "That's the least sexy way you could have said that."

"I'm an academic at heart."

"You're a nerd at heart." She stroked it slowly . "But you're also..whatever this is, confident and bold, commanding and strong, making me come three times on a kitchen counter."

Wednesday raised an eyebrow. "Keep touching me like this and we're going to have to stay in this shower for a very long time."

"Is that a threat?

"It's a fact."

She released Wednesday reluctantly. "Fine, but only because I'm hungry. You made me skip lunch, remember?

"I seem to recall you being the one who told me to skip lunch, actually."

"Details of no importance." Enid stepped out of the shower and grabbed a fluffy white towel, monogrammed with an elegant cursive E. "There's leftover Thai in the fridge, we can eat and then—"

"And then?

"And then we'll see what happens." She wrapped the towel around herself and tossed Wednesday a second one, smiling softly. "I'm still not done with you at all."

They ate on the couch, sharing reheated Thai green curry straight from the containers with plastic forks. Enid had pulled on sweatpants and a tank top, no bra underneath, while Wednesday remained in her black lace panties and nothing else, the towel draped loosely over her shoulders. The fairy lights glowed around them, the diffuser hummed softly, and somewhere outside, a car alarm went off before falling silent again.

"This is weird," Enid said around a mouthful of curry .

"Which part?

"All of it, eating Thai food on my couch with a mostly-naked woman who just made me come four times. Usually by this point, I'm..." She stopped, apparently reconsidering how much she wanted to say.

"Usually you're what?

"Figuring out how to get them to leave." Enid set her container down. "Sex is usually transactional, it's a thing I do, and then it's done, so I don't have to think about it anymore. But with you, I don't want you to leave. I want you to stay , and that's..."

"Terrifying, you said that already."

"Because it's true." Enid pulled her knees up to her chest. "I don't know how to do this, the whole partners thing. I've never had a partner, I've had transactions."

Wednesday set down her own container. "Neither of us knows what we're doing."

"That's not comforting."

"It wasn't meant to be comforting, it was meant to be honest." Wednesday turned to face Enid. "You've been telling me since the first session that I need to stop overthinking everything, that I need to trust my instincts and let myself experience things, maybe you need to take your own advice."

"My advice was about sex."

"Maybe it applies to other things too."

Enid stared at her, the fairy lights reflected in her eyes, tiny pinpricks of gold against green. "When did you get wise?"

"Somewhere between session three and session seven."

"That's a lot of sessions."

"We've been busy."

"We've been—" Enid laughed and shook her head. "Yeah, we've been busy."

Silence settled between them, comfortable rather than awkward. Wednesday leaned back against the couch cushions and let her eyes drift closed, her body loose and heavy, satisfied in a way that went beyond anything physical.

Enid's voice eventually broke the quiet. "Can I ask you something?"

"Anything."

"Last week, after the party , you said you shook your head at Mia, that you didn't feel anything." Enid's voice was careful and measured. "And I know I asked you that time as well, but do you still feel that way?"

"Y es."

"Are you sure?"

Wednesday opened her eyes and looked at Enid. "Mia is- she's a concept, an idea of what I thought I wanted, but she's not" Wednesday gestured vaguely. "real, not in the way that matters."

"And I am?"

"I don't know what you are that's what I'm figuring out." W ednesday reached over and tucked a strand of damp hair behind Enid's ear , the gesture tender, unexpectedly so. "B t yes, you're real."

Enid was quiet for a long moment before she shifted, uncurling from her defensive posture and sliding closer to Wednesday on the couch. She rested her head in the hollow of Wednesday's shoulder , her hand settling against Wednesday's chest.

"Okay ," Enid said. "Partners, still not feelings."

"Still not feelings."

"Good." Enid pressed a kiss to W ednesday's collarbone. "Because I'm not done teaching you things."

"What else is there?"

"Next Thursday , Ill show you." A grin was audible in Enid's voice as she added, "But first, we should probably study a little, since your tutoring reputation is at stake."

"Now you want to study?"

"Better late than never ." Enid sat up and reached for W ednesday's messenger bag, which was still on the floor by the kitchen, exactly where she'd dropped it when she'd walked in. "Y ou brought the study guide, right?"

"Three pages, all on cardstock."

"Y ou're a marvel." Enid pulled out the pages and the textbook before settling back against the couch. "Okay , collective behavior, hit me."

Wednesday pulled on her glasses, the backup pair she'd retrieved from her bag, and opened the textbook. For the next hour, they actually studied, with Enid asking questions about convergence theory and emergent norms while Wednesday explained everything with the same patience she'd been using since their first session. Somewhere in the middle of it all, Wednesday's hand found Enid's.

Wednesday didn't mention it, and neither did Enid.

When Wednesday finally left at 11:23 PM, clothed again in all black, with her messenger bag over her shoulder and her contacts case in her pocket, Enid kissed her at the door. The kiss was long, slow, and soft, not a lesson or a transaction, just a kiss.

"Same time next Thursday ," Enid said. "Don't be late."

"W ouldn't dream of it."

"And W ednesday?"

"Y eah?"

"Wear the contacts again." Enid's wicked grin flickered. "But keep the glasses in your bag, I have plans for them."

"What kind of plans?"

"You'll find out." She gently pushed Wednesday out the door. "Good night, nerdy."

"Good night, Enid."

The door clicked shut, leaving the hallway dark and quiet. Wednesday stood there for a moment, staring at the number 42B and feeling as though the entire universe had rearranged itself around her.

Her phone buzzed with a message from Enid: *Same time next Thursday, don't be late, and wear something I can take off easily.*

She typed back, *Noted.*

A second text appeared almost immediately. *Also, the fruit magnets have seen things, you should apologize to them.*

Her reply was immediate. *The fruit magnets knew what they signed up for.*

She walked home through the spring darkness, still smiling, still tasting Enid on her tongue, and still feeling the phantom pressure of Enid's hand in hers. The streetlights cast pools of amber across the sidewalk while the crickets were loud and insistent around her. Somewhere in her chest, in the space where anxiety used to live, something had taken root, something that felt a lot like anticipation.

Thursday couldn't come fast enough.

Chapter End Notes

Enid: "Sex isn't always planned. Sometimes it just happens"

Also Enid: plans an entire kitchen lesson.

Chapter 8: A Change of Location

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Monday started badly, with Enid's alarm either not going off or getting murdered in her sleep, the snooze button bearing the full brunt of her subconscious rage, because when she finally opened her eyes, the clock on her nightstand read 9:47 AM, meaning her Sociology 201 lecture had already started twelve minutes ago.

"Shit," Enid muttered as she rolled out of bed, her hair a disaster, her mouth tasting like the ghost of Thai curry, and the tank top she'd slept in twisted sideways, leaving one breast dangerously close to escaping. Her sweatpants had vanished somewhere during the night, leaving her in nothing but the shirt and a pair of black cotton panties.

The morning became a blur of coffee, mascara, and a granola bar eaten over the sink. Enid made it to campus by 10:15, which meant she'd missed the entire lecture, would have to borrow someone's notes, and, worst of all, would have to talk to people before noon, which was its own special circle of hell.

The library was her refuge, specifically the third floor, east wing, the section nobody used because the heating vent made a noise like a dying whale and the chairs looked as though they'd been around since the Nixon administration. Enid had discovered it during sophomore year and had been using it as her personal hideout ever since.

Enid dropped her bag on the table and collapsed into a chair that groaned under her weight. Monday was already bad enough, and what she really needed was coffee, but instead she had a headache and the creeping realization that she'd left her phone charger at home.

What Enid didn't expect was Wednesday.

At 11:03 AM, Wednesday appeared between the stacks like a librarian-themed hallucination, glasses perched on her nose, her messenger bag slung across her chest, and her expression as cool and distant as ever. She wore an oversized black hoodie with the sleeves pushed up to her elbows, exposing her forearms, and Enid had developed a thing about those forearms, lean and toned from hours of fencing practice, the muscles shifting subtly beneath pale skin whenever Wednesday moved her hands. There was also a prominent vein running from her wrist to the crook of her elbow, one Enid had spent an embarrassing amount of Thursday night thinking about.

"You missed lecture," Wednesday said.

"Good morning to you too," Enid replied, giving her a look.

"Professor Walsh did a pop quiz, five questions, mostly on collective behavior, and you would have aced it." Wednesday pulled out the chair across from Enid and sat down, watching her with that same unreadable expression.

"I overslept."

"I figured." Wednesday reached into her bag and pulled out a sheet of paper, sliding it across the table. "I took notes for you. They're neatly written in black ink."

Enid stared at the paper, then at Wednesday, before looking back at the notes, which were immaculate, with neat bullet points in black ink, key terms highlighted in blue, and examples marked in green. Wednesday had even drawn a small diagram in the corner, something about convergence theory and emergent norms.

"You made all these notes for me?"

"You missed lecture."

"So you just assumed I'd be here, in my secret library hideout that I've never told you about?" Enid asked, still looking at the page as though she couldn't quite believe Wednesday had remembered any of this.

Wednesday adjusted her glasses, the gesture so familiar by now that it made something catch in Enid's chest. "You mentioned it once, last month, during our second session. You said you study in the east wing because the heating vent scares people away."

"I told you that?"

"You were demonstrating proximity. You said, and I quote, 'The heating vent sounds like a dying whale, so nobody comes here, so I can spread out my stuff without anyone judging me for taking up three chairs.'"

Enid remembered saying that, and somehow, she hadn't expected Wednesday to remember it too.

"You're a freak," Enid said.

"Thank you."

"That wasn't a compliment."

"I felt like a compliment." Wednesday pushed the notes across the table. "There's also a study guide for Wednesday's quiz. Hendricks announced it after you left, or, rather, after you didn't arrive."

Enid looked at the notes, then back at Wednesday's face, taking in that earnest, deadpan expression, her glasses slightly askew, and her lean forearms resting on the table, the vein visible just beneath the surface of her skin. Something shifted in Enid's chest, and it wasn't feelings, because they'd agreed on no feelings, but it was something.

"What are you doing here?" Enid asked. "It's Monday, we don't meet on Mondays."

"I was in the library anyway, researching for my thesis, and I saw your name on the attendance sheet. Professor Walsh posts absentees on the online portal, so I figured you might need these." Wednesday paused, her expression remaining unreadable, then added, "Also, I wanted to see you."

The words hung in the air between them, and Enid found herself staring at Wednesday as she tried to process the admission.

"You wanted to see me," She repeated, still processing what Wednesday had just said.

"Is that weird?"

"No, yes, maybe." Enid leaned back in her chair, which gave another deeply unflattering groan beneath her. "I wanted to see you too, I've been thinking about you, about Thursday."

"Thursday was intense."

"Thursday was, yeah, intense." Enid's thighs pressed together beneath the table, an involuntary response to the memory of the kitchen counter, the fridge, and the shower. "I'm still sore."

Wednesday's expression flickered, something that might have been concern, or perhaps pride. "Sorry."

"Don't apologize, it's a good sore." Enid stretched her arms over her head, and her tank top rode up, exposing a strip of her stomach, while Wednesday's eyes dropped to it for a moment before snapping back to Enid's face.

"Still following my instincts," Wednesday said.

"That's the whole point of the curriculum."

They looked at each other across the table, and the heating vent chose that exact moment to emit a long, mournful groan, aaaaaaaooooooooooh, making Enid laugh as Wednesday smiled, the tension between them finally breaking.

"Okay ," Enid said, settling back into her chair . "Y ou've delivered your notes, you've been a good student, and now you can go back to your thesis."

"What if Idont want to?"

"Y ou have a thesis."

"My thesis can wait."

Enid raised an eyebrow, studying Wednesday's face. "W ednesday, are you propositioning me in a library?"

"I'm asking if you want to study together , Sociology, actual studying." Wednesday paused, then added, "Unless you want to study something else."

The air changed subtly, the silence between them shifting from comfortable to charged as the heating vent moaned again, the fluorescent lights buzzed overhead, and somewhere in the distance, a cart rattled across the floor.

"The east wing is dead," Enid said quietly , "nobody comes here, ever."

"I know , that's why you study here."

"That' s why Istudy here."

Wednesday stood, walked around the table, pulled out the chair beside Enid, and sat down, close enough that it was more than strictly necessary for sharing notes, her knee brushing against Enid's beneath the table.

“We should review convergence theory,” Wednesday said.

“We really should.”

Wednesday’s hand found Enid’s thigh, gentle and questioning, her palm warm through the thin fabric of the leggings. “Convergence theory posits that collective behavior occurs when people with similar needs and values converge in the same location.”

“Is that what’s happening here?”

“I think so,” Wednesday said, her fingers tracing upward. “Two people, similar needs, converging in the same location.”

Enid’s breath hitched. “You’re using sociology to seduce me.”

“Is it working?”

“Fuck you.”

“Is that a yes?”

Enid grabbed the front of Wednesday’s black hoodie and kissed her, the kiss anything but gentle or careful, carrying four days of thinking about those lean forearms and that mouth, along with the memory of the way Wednesday had made her come on the kitchen counter. Their tongues slid against each other, Wednesday’s hand tightening on Enid’s thigh as the chair groaned beneath their combined weight.

“Here,” Enid said against her mouth. “Now.”

“The library”—

“Is empty. I told you, nobody comes here.” Enid pulled back, her lips already swollen and her breathing uneven, then admitted, “I’ve been thinking about you all weekend, every time I sat at the kitchen counter, every time I opened the fridge. I kept remembering everything, your mouth, your cock, the way you said my name.”

"Enid," Wednesday said, her voice low and rough, exactly the way Enid remembered.

"Yeah, that." Enid stood up and grabbed Wednesday's hand, pulling her closer. "Come here."

There was a corner of the east wing that Enid hadn't shown Wednesday, past the microfiche cabinets and behind a row of bound periodicals that hadn't been checked out since 1997. It was a narrow alcove with a single window, a clanking radiator, and a view of the parking lot, technically a study carrel, but more truthfully, a coffin-sized box of wood and desperation, private enough that nobody was likely to bother them.

Enid pulled Wednesday into the alcove and pushed her against the wall, with the periodicals looming on either side, leather-bound and dusty, their titles including *Journal of Applied Sociology* and *American Behavioral Scientist*. Through the window, pale morning light fell across Wednesday's face.

"You're sure about this?" Wednesday asked, her hands automatically finding Enid's waist. "Someone could walk by."

"Nobody walks by, that's the whole point." Enid kissed her jaw, then her neck, lingering at the spot behind her ear that made Wednesday shiver. "I want you to fuck me, right now, right here."

"Words."

Enid almost laughed at that, the student teaching the teacher. "Yes, I'm sure, I want this. I need—fuck, Wednesday, I need you inside me."

Wednesday turned them around, and Enid's back hit the wall, lighter than she expected, gentle and controlled, before Wednesday's body pressed against hers, her thigh settling between Enid's legs as Enid ground against her without thinking. The friction felt good, but it wasn't enough, and she needed more.

"From behind," Enid said. "I want you to take me from behind."

"Here? Against the wall?"

"The carrel, bend me over it."

Wednesday looked at the carrel, the narrow wooden desk attached to the wall, barely big enough for a laptop, then back at Enid. Her pupils were blown wide, her breathing ragged, and her erection pressed visibly against her black jeans.

"Hands on the desk," Wednesday said.

Enid turned around and placed her palms flat on the wood, the surface cold and slightly sticky from decades of coffee rings and pencil marks sealed beneath a coat of varnish. She arched her back and pushed her ass against Wednesday.

"Like this?"

"Exactly like that."

Wednesday's hands found her hips, squeezing once, firm and possessive, before sliding down to the waistband of her leggings. Black and stretchy, the same pair Enid had worn on Thursday, they peeled down over her ass and thighs, catching briefly on the curve of her hips before sliding free. Her panties came with them, simple cotton and pale pink, not remotely sexy, but Enid didn't care because Wednesday's hand was already between her legs.

"Fuck, you're wet."

"I told you, I've been thinking about this." Enid pushed back against those fingers. "All weekend, every time I touched myself, I thought about Thursday, about your cock, about the fridge."

Wednesday's fingers parted her folds, and one slid inside her, easy and effortless, the wetness making way as Enid moaned, loud enough that the sound seemed far too loud for a library.

"Shh," Wednesday said, her voice strained as she reminded her, "we're in public."

"There's no one here, I told you ~~ahhnobody comesngh~~—

A second finger joined the first, curling upward until it found the spot that made Enid's vision blur.

"Right there, fuck, don't stop"—

Wednesday didn't stop. Her thumb circled Enid's clit while her fingers worked inside her, using that same "come here" motion she had perfected last week, the one that made Enid see stars. Enid dropped her forehead to the desk, her knuckles whitening against the wood as her pussy clenched around Wednesday's fingers, and she bit her lip hard enough to hurt.

"You're close," Wednesday said, not as a question.

"Yes, please, I need your cock inside me, now."

Wednesday's fingers withdrew, and Enid heard the rustle of black denim, followed by the clink of a belt and the sound of a zipper, loud in the silence of the stacks. A moment later, the head of Wednesday's cock was pressing against her entrance, hot, slick, and waiting.

"Condom?" Enid managed.

"I don't have one"

"It's okay, I'm still on birth control, so just ~~pu~~sh."

Wednesday pushed inside, and the angle was perfect, deeper than the kitchen counter and tighter than the bed, as Enid's body stretched around her, that familiar fullness and velvet pressure making a moan escape her lips and echo off the bound periodicals. Maybe it was too loud, but Enid didn't care.

“Ahhhyes Wednesday, your cock feels so good”—

“You're so fucking tight.” Her voice was ragged as her hips pulled back and thrust forward, making the carrel rattle against the wall. “Is this okay?”

“More, harder , fuck me.”

Wednesday fucked her, not gently or carefully, her fingers bruising Enid’s hips as her cock drove into her with a rhythm that was pure instinct, fast, deep, and relentless. The carrel banged against the wall with every thrust, the radiator clanked, and somewhere in the distance, a door opened and closed, making Enid’s heart lurch, but the footsteps soon faded, and no one came, it was just them, just this.

“You feelnghso fucking big from this angle”—

Wednesday’s hand slid up Enid’s spine, pressing between her shoulder blades and pushing her chest flat against the desk. The new angle made her even deeper, and Enid’s moan was swallowed by the wood.

“Right there, don't stop, don't stop, don't stop”—

Wednesday’s fingers found her clit, and the orgasm hit Enid like a wave, crashing through her body as it started in her pelvis and radiated outward. Her pussy clamped down around Wednesday’s cock, her legs trembled, and her mouth opened in a silent scream that was only silent because she'd bitten her lip bloody .

“Fuuuuck Wednesday, yes, yes, yes”—

Wednesday kept thrusting, gentler now and slower, letting Enid ride out the last waves as her fingers stayed on Enid’s clit with lighter pressure, just enough to extend the aftershocks and make her shudder against the desk. “One,” Wednesday said, “that’s one.”

"Counting again," Enid murmured, managing a weak, breathless laugh as her legs felt like jelly while her body still pulsed from the intensity of the moment. "Always counting."

"Okay , my turn." Enid tried to steady herself, still catching her breath.

Wednesday pulled out slowly, and Enid whined at the loss, the sound completely undignified, but she didnt care. She looked back at Wednesday and kissed her hungrily, while Wednesday wrapped her arms around Enid's waist and Enid pulled her closer, slipping her arms around Wednesday's neck.

Wednesday's cock remained hard, jutting from the open waistband of her black jeans, flushed and slick with Enid' s wetness, the prominent vein along the underside visibly pulsing. Enid reached out and wrapped her hand around her, feeling Wednesday twitch beneath her touch.

"Y ou didnt come."

"No."

"God, Iwant to ride you."

Wednesday's eyes widened. "Here?"

"The chair ." Enid gestured toward the wooden chair tucked beneath the carrel, the same Nixon-era design as the rest of the east wing, hard and unforgiving, and perfect for what she had in mind. "Sit down."

Wednesday sat, and Enid straddled her, fitting her knees into the narrow gaps on either side of the chair while bracing her hands on Wednesday's shoulders. Wednesday's cock nudged against her entrance, and Enid sank down slowly, inch by inch, until the fullness became overwhelming.

"Ohhhfuck, youre so deep like this"—

"Enid"—

Wednesday's hands found Enid's ass, squeezing and lifting, and Enid took the hint, starting to move as she rose and sank again, gradually finding a rhythm that made her breathing stutter. The chair creaked beneath them and the radiator hissed, while Enid's tank top rode up to her ribs, allowing Wednesday's mouth to find her nipple through the fabric, sucking hard and circling it with her tongue as Enid gasped.

"Yes, suck my tits ahh"—

Wednesday pulled the fabric down, letting Enid's breast spill free, her nipple already hard, and immediately sealed her mouth around it. Her tongue flicked over the sensitive skin, her teeth grazing it with just enough pressure to make Enid' s hips buck.

"More, your fingers, on my clit"—

Wednesday's hand slid between their bodies, two fingers pressing firm circles against Enid's clit as she rode her, faster now and harder, the chair groaning with every movement. Pale light from the window fell across Wednesday's face, her glasses fogged and her expression desperate.

"I'm close," Wednesday gasped. "Enid, I'm going to"—

"Me too, just keep touching me, don't stop"—

Enid came, the orgasm ripping through her, not as violent as the first but deeper and full-body, her pussy clenching around Wednesday as her head fell back and her cry echoed through the stacks. Her hips kept moving, instinct driving her through the climax, and she felt Wednesday stiffen beneath her.

"Fuck, Enid"—

Wednesday's hands clamped down on Enid's hips as she thrust up into her once, then twice, before she came, hot and thick, pulsing inside her. Enid felt every spurt, every wave, while Wednesday's forehead dropped to her shoulder and her breath came in ragged gasps against Enid's skin.

"Ah, fuck"—

Enid kept moving, slower now, milking the last of Wednesday's orgasm while aftershocks still rippled through her own body. The chair creaked beneath them, the radiator clanked nearby, and their breathing mingled in the dusty air of the stacks.

"Holy shit," Wednesday whispered.

"Yeah."

"We just did that in the library."

"I know."

"That was"…

"Insane, reckless, incredible." Enid lifted her head and looked at Wednesday, whose glasses were completely fogged over. A genuine, surprised laugh escaped Enid as she reached up and pulled them off her face. "You can't see anything, can you?"

"Not really."

"God." Enid wiped the lenses on her tank top before handing them back. "You look cute when you're blind."

"You look..." Wednesday swallowed, her eyes lingering on Enid. "You look completely wrecked."

"I feel completely wrecked." Enid slowly lifted herself off Wednesday, and the loss made them both wince as a trickle of cum slid down her

inner thigh. She glanced down and laughed softly. "We made a mess."

"We did."

"In the library."

"I'm aware."

"The east wing, Sociology section, bound periodicals from the nineties." Enid started laughing again, unable to stop herself. "We just fucked in the Sociology section."

A dazed smile broke across Wednesday's face. "Convergence theory in action."

"Stop making academic jokes while your cum is dripping down my leg."

"I can't, it's a coping mechanism."

Enid kissed her, soft and tender, completely at odds with what they had just done. "You're going to need to clean me up, there's a bathroom down the hall."

"Private?"

"Just one stall."

"God."

They rearranged their clothes as best they could, with Enid pulling up her leggings and panties in one motion before grimacing at the lingering wetness, while Wednesday zipped up her black jeans and buckled her belt. The carrel looked like a crime scene, with sweat on the wood and a handprint on the wall, so Enid pulled a tissue from her bag and wiped everything down as best she could.

"Evidence disposal," she said. "Very important."

“You've done this before.”

“Not in a library , but I'm adaptable.”

Thankfully, the bathroom was single-stall, with industrial gray tile, a mirror flecked with water spots, and a dispenser of pink soap that smelled like artificial flowers. Enid cleaned herself up with paper towels and water while Wednesday stood guard outside, and by the time Enid emerged, she felt almost normal again, almost.

“You're still flushed,” Wednesday said.

“So are you.”

“Fair .”

They walked back to Wednesday's table, the one in the main section of the east wing rather than the alcove, and sat down. Her notes were still there, neat and immaculate, and Enid looked at them for a moment, suddenly feeling something complicated that she couldn't quite put into words.

“We should probably study,” Enid said.

“Probably .”

“We're not going to study .”

“No.”

Enid leaned back in her chair, and the groan it made sounded almost affectionate. “I didn't expect this, you, Monday , library sex.”

“Neither did I, my thesis outline is still blank.”

“I ruined your productivity .”

“You ruined my thesis,” Wednesday said, her voice low and steady, the words sounding suspiciously like a compliment. “Worth it.”

The heating vent chose that moment to moan again, *aaaaaaaooooooooooh*, and they both laughed. It was absurd, all of it, sex in the library, the neat notes spread across the table, and a fake relationship that had stopped feeling entirely fake somewhere around session four.

"Wednesday."

"Yeah?"

"This still isn't feelings, but I like you, as a person, as a partner." The word was getting easier to say. "Is that okay?"

"It's more than okay." Wednesday reached across the table and took Enid's hand, her palm still sweaty and her glasses still slightly fogged. "I like you too, as a person, as a partner, and as someone who just rode me in a library chair."

"You're never going to let that go, are you?"

"Absolutely not."

Enid squeezed Wednesday's hand once before releasing it, a small smile tugging at her lips. "Okay, now we study."

They actually studied, with Wednesday walking Enid through convergence theory and emergent norms, her lean, fencer's frame poised and precise even while sitting, dressed in her signature head to toe black. Enid took notes in the margins of Wednesday's neatly written sheets, and by the time noon rolled around, she felt almost prepared for Wednesday's quiz, almost.

"You're going to pass," Wednesday said.

"You sound confident."

"You understand the material, you just need to believe that you understand it."

"That's the hard part."

"I know." Wednesday stood up and slung her messenger bag over her shoulder. "But you've got until Wednesday, and I'll be at your apartment on Thursday, same time."

"Same time." Enid stood too, although her legs were still slightly shaky. She hesitated before looking at Wednesday. "Wednesday?"

"Yeah?"

Enid leaned in, kissed Wednesday quickly on the cheek, and then gently pushed her toward the exit. "Now go, work on your thesis. I need to shower."

"You need a lot of things."

"Don't push it, nerdy."

With that, Wednesday left, and Enid watched her disappear through the library doors before finally letting out a breath.

The east wing settled back into silence, with the heating vent moaning in the background and the fluorescent lights buzzing overhead. Enid sat down and looked at the notes spread across the table, the neat black-ink writing and the tiny diagram in the corner, and felt something unfamiliar settle in her chest, not quite feelings, but close enough to make her pause.

She pulled out her phone and typed a text: *You ruined my ability to study in the library, every time I sit here now, I'm going to think about you.*

Wednesday's reply was immediate: *God, every time I work on my thesis, I'm going to think about you riding me in that chair.*

Enid smiled as she pocketed her phone and packed up her bag, thinking about how Monday had started badly but had somehow ended up pretty fucking spectacular.

Chapter End Notes

No books were harmed but the furniture, unfortunately, had a rough day.

Chapter 9: The Variables Shift

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mia Carter had been watching Wednesday for seventeen minutes, not that she was counting. She wasn't the type to count minutes, too pragmatic and too focused on soil composition reports and water quality data sets to track something as imprecise as the amount of time she had spent observing a classmate. Still, she'd looked at her phone when she first noticed Wednesday emerge from the east wing stacks, and she'd looked again when she finally gathered the courage to stand up from her study carrel, and the difference between those two glances was seventeen minutes.

Seventeen minutes of watching Wednesday, the girl from Sociology 201 who always sat in the third row, the same Wednesday who had somehow transformed over the past few weeks from a hunched, glasses-fogged ghost into someone who walked as though she finally belonged in her own body.

She moved differently now, with her shoulders back, her jaw relaxed, and the messenger bag slung across her chest instead of being clutched to her side like a shield.

Mia had noticed it at the party, and so had everyone else. Sophie had practically shouted about it, *"Oh, you look like a completely different person!"* while Katie had stared at Wednesday's arms with the kind of intensity usually reserved for lab results that confirmed a hypothesis.

But Mia had noticed the change before the party, back in class, when Wednesday answered one of Professor Walsh's questions about emergent norm theory without stammering. She had pushed her glasses up her nose and delivered a perfectly coherent explanation about crowd behaviour and collective identity, while Enid, campus

legend and professional distraction, hadn't even looked up from her notes.

That was the strangest part. Enid always looked up, always had something to say, some witty interjection or some way of recentering the room around herself, but she'd just kept writing, her pen moving steadily across the page while Wednesday finished her answer, and the moment passed without any fanfare.

Mia had filed it away, because she was good at filing things away.

But now Wednesday was walking out of the library at noon on a Monday, her hair slightly mussed, her glasses a little askew, and a flush on her cheeks that hadn't been there when she'd entered the building two hours earlier. Mia had seen Wednesday go in, and she'd been at her usual spot near the periodicals, not the east wing, because nobody went to the east wing when the heating vent made that noise, and she'd watched Wednesday pass by with her messenger bag and her neatly written notes.

She'd almost said hello then, almost, but Wednesday had been walking with purpose, Mia had had a paper to finish, and now it was noon, Wednesday was leaving, and Mia was already standing up from her carrel and walking toward her before her brain had finished calculating the probability of this going well.

"Wednesday."

Wednesday stopped and turned, and the smile that spread across her face was genuine. Mia had gotten good at reading genuine smiles versus polite ones, a survival skill she'd developed over three years of department mixers and faculty networking events.

"Mia, hi."

"Hi." Mia adjusted her glasses, a nervous habit she was aware of but did anyway. "I saw you leaving and thought I'd say hello."

"Oh. Yeah, I was just—" Wednesday gestured vaguely toward the east wing. "Studying."

"In the east wing?"

"The heating vent scares people away, so it's good for focus."

Mia felt her mouth twitch. "I thought I was the only one who knew about that."

"Enid told me. She studies there."

The name landed between them with unexpected weight, and Mia filed that away too, noticing the way Wednesday said it, casual but familiar, like she'd said it a hundred times before, like the name belonged in her mouth.

"Right, Enid." Mia shifted her weight from one foot to the other, even though environmental science majors didn't fidget, and yet here she was, fidgeting. "I actually wanted to ask you something."

Wednesday's expression flickered, surprise, maybe, or perhaps curiosity. "Okay."

Mia Carter had always believed in directness. The scientific method applied to all aspects of life, form a hypothesis, test it, and accept the results regardless of whether they confirmed your expectations. She'd spent three years at this university watching Wednesday watch her, noticing the glances, the stammering, and the way Wednesday would turn bright red whenever she asked to borrow a pen. Mia had filed all of it away under "data points" and had never done anything with them, at least not until the party.

The party had recalibrated something. Wednesday in a black ensemble instead of her usual oversized hoodies, Wednesday laughing with Sophie and the other girls, Wednesday catching Mia's eye across the room and smiling, actually smiling, rather than giving

the nervous grimace Mia was used to, and then shaking her head when Mia had tried to wave her over.

Mia had replayed that head shake for days, the polite decline, the easy confidence of it, and the way Wednesday had simply turned back to her conversation without a second glance.

t had stung, not because Mia felt entitled to W ednesday's attention, because she knew she wasn't, but because she'd always assumed she'd be there, waiting, available, a constant in the eqation of her college experience.

And now the constant had changed.

"I was wondering," she said, "if you wanted to get cof fee sometime."

The words hung in the air as midday sunlight streamed through the library's tall windows, catching dust motes in its path, while somewhere behind them, the heating vent in the east wing let out a muffled groan.

Wednesday blinked. "Cof fee?"

"Or lunch, or a walk, I don't know the protocol for this." Mia laughed, her usual wind-chime laugh that had always made her blush, although it sounded different now, more nervous and less certain. "I've never actually asked someone out before. People usually make the first move."

"Really?"

"Usually ."

"Right, of course they do." W ednesday pushed her glasses up her nose, the gesture familiar even though the expression behind it wasn't. She wasn't blushing or stammering, she was just thinking. "Mia, I—"

"You don't have to answer right now. I know this is sudden, we've barely talked outside of class, and I've probably completely misread the situation, but you seemed different at the party, and I kept thinking about it, and I figured I'd rather know than spend the rest of the semester wondering." Mia stopped and took a breath before adding, "That was a lot of words."

"A lot of good words."

"I'm usually more concise."

"You're usually more everything." Wednesday said it without irony or the self-deprecating edge she would have layered over it a month ago, simply stating it as an observation. "You were my dream girl, you know."

Mia's breath caught. "Was?"

"Yeah," Wednesday said with a soft, almost apologetic smile. "Was."

The past tense hit Mia harder than she expected. She'd prepared herself for rejection, because she was a scientist and knew how to account for unfavourable results, but she hadn't prepared for the gentleness of it, the kindness, or the way Wednesday was looking at her as though Mia were something precious that she had simply stopped needing.

"I don't understand," Mia said.

"Neither do I, not completely." Wednesday shifted her messenger bag higher on her shoulder. "I had this crush on you for, God, two years? Maybe longer, since freshman orientation, when you asked a question about carbon sequestration and Professor Walsh didn't know the answer, and you corrected him with a citation, I thought, that's it, that's her, that's the smartest person I've ever seen."

"You remember that?"

"I remember everything about you, or I did, the way you take notes with different colored pens, the way you laugh at Professor Walsh's jokes even when they're not funny because you feel bad for him, and the way you always sit on the left side of the lecture hall, third row from the front, because the light is better for your eyes."

Mia's throat tightened. "Wednesday."

"I spent two years trying to figure out how to talk to you. I rehearsed conversations, planned scenarios, and had this whole fantasy about how it would go, where I'd say something brilliant about sociological theory, you'd be impressed, we'd start studying together, and eventually I'd work up the courage to tell you how I felt." She laughed, not bitterly, but with amusement at her own past self. "I never actually did any of it."

"And now?"

"Now ..." Wednesday looked at her, really looked at her, and Mia could see that her eyes behind her glasses were the same earnest brown they'd always been, but there was something steadier in them now, something settled. "Now I can say all of this to you without my heart racing, without my palms sweating, and without wanting to disappear into the floor."

"That's a good thing, isn't it?"

"It's a weird thing." Wednesday adjusted her glasses again. "You're amazing, Mia. You're brilliant and funny and kind, and you have the most incredible laugh, it sounds like wind chimes. I used to think that was a stupid metaphor, but it's actually just true, and I should be freaking out right now. I should be saying yes, because any version of me from a month ago would be saying yes."

"But you're not."

"I'm not."

Mia nodded slowly, processing it. "Because of Enid."

The name landed again, heavier this time.

"It's not-" Wednesday stopped, then started again. "It's not because of anyone, it's because of me. I've changed, and I didn't expect to, but I have, and the person I am now doesn't want the same things the person I was a month ago wanted. Does that make sense?"

"It makes perfect sense." Mia meant it. "People change, circumstances change, the variables in an equation shift, and the outcome shifts with them."

"That's a very scientific way of putting it."

"I'm a very scientific person."

They stood there for a moment, two people in a library lobby at noon on a Monday, surrounded by the smell of old paper and the distant hum of fluorescent lights. The heating vent in the east wing moaned again, a long, ridiculous aaaaaaaooooooooooh, and Mia found herself laughing.

"That sound is ridiculous," she said.

"It really is." Wednesday laughed too. "I don't know how Enid studies there."

"There it is again, Enid."

"Sorry."

"Don't apologize, I asked a question, you gave me an answer, that's how it works." Mia pushed her glasses up her nose, unconsciously mirroring Wednesday's gesture. "For what it's worth, I think she's lucky, whoever gets to be the person you're thinking about instead of me."

Wednesday's expression shifted, something flickering behind her eyes, surprise perhaps, or gratitude. "That's a really generous thing to say."

"I'm a generous person, especially when I'm not terrifying everyone with my citation skills."

"You never terrified me, I was in awe of you."

"Awe is terrifying in its own way."

"Yeah, it is." She smiled, letting the words settle between them.

A group of students pushed through the library doors behind them, laughing about something as their voices echoed off the high ceiling. The noise broke the bubble of their conversation, and Mia felt the moment slipping away, along with the strange, unexpected intimacy of standing in a lobby with someone she'd barely spoken to for three years and having the most honest conversation she'd had all semester.

"I should go," Mia said. "I have a soil composition report due on Wednesday."

"Of course you do."

"It's very exciting, lots of dirt."

"I bet you make dirt fascinating."

"I absolutely do." Mia adjusted her bag on her shoulder before looking back at Wednesday. "Wednesday?"

"Yeah?"

"I'm glad I asked, even though you said no, and even though I'm probably going to replay this conversation in my head for the next six months and cringe at every single thing I said."

"You didnt say anything cringe."

"I said, Ive never actually asked someone out before.' That' s textbook cringe."

"It' s textbook honest." Wednesday reached out and touched Mia's arm, brief and friendly, nothing more. "Thank you, for asking, and for being brave enough to do something I spent two years being too scared to do."

Mia looked down at Wednesday's hand on her arm, then back at her face, at the girl, the woman, who had once blushed every time Mia glanced in her direction and was now standing there, comforting her through her own rejection.

"You really have changed," Mia said.

"Im trying."

"It' s working." Mia stepped back, and Wednesday's hand fell away. "Goodbye, Wednesday. Ill see you in class."

"See you in class."

Mia walked away, her footsteps echoing across the polished floor, confident and steady, the gait of someone who knew exactly where she was going even when she didnt. The library doors swung shut behind her, and the lobby settled back into silence.

Wednesday stood there for a moment longer, then adjusted her messenger bag and walked toward the exit.

She didnt see Enid, who was on the third floor in the east wing, standing at the window overlooking the library's main entrance. Enid had come to retrieve her phone charger, which shed forgotten on the table, tangled in the legs of her chair, and had paused at the window to check the time. Instead, shed seen Wednesday, and Mia Carter.

They'd been standing close, not intimately close, but comfortably close, the kind of closeness you achieved after an honest conversation. Mia had been smiling, Wednesday had been smiling back, and then Mia had touched Wednesday's arm, briefly and gently, and something in Enid's chest had clenched.

Not jealousy. She didn't do jealousy, because jealousy implied ownership, and she didn't own Wednesday, didn't want to own Wednesday, and had spent her entire sexual career avoiding anything that resembled ownership.

But something was there.

Enid watched Mia walk away, then watched Wednesday stand alone in the lobby for a beat too long before heading toward the exit, taking in the whole quiet, tender, incomprehensible scene from her perch above it all. The heating vent groaned, aaaaaaaooooooooooh, and Enid muttered, "Shut up."

The vent, predictably, did not shut up.

She found her phone charger wedged between the seat cushion and the chair frame, while the screen of her phone remained dark. She'd forgotten to charge it last night too, too distracted by thoughts of Wednesday and the library and the way his cum had felt sliding down her thigh, so she shoved the charger into her bag without checking her messages.

She should go home, she had homework, a quiz on Wednesday, and a thousand things to do that didn't involve standing at a library window watching her partner have an emotional conversation with her former dream girl.

Partner, the word still felt strange, inaccurate, like a placeholder for something she refused to name.

She walked down the stairs slowly. The east wing staircase was narrow and poorly lit, another reason nobody came here, and her

footsteps echoed through the enclosed space. By the time she reached the ground floor, she'd convinced herself that she wasn't going to ask Wednesday about it, wasn't going to text her , and wasn't going to do any of the things a girlfriend would do.

Because she wasn't W ednesday's girlfriend.

They were partners, and it was different, simpler, just sex and studying and the occasional library hookup, with feelings explicitly not being part of the arrangement.

Except Mia had touched Wednesday's arm with a gentleness that suggested intimacy, and they'd been talking for a while, at least three minutes, maybe longer, because Enid had been watching from the window, and the conversation had looked serious, important, like the kind of conversation you didn't have with someone you'd barely spoken to for three years.

Unless something had changed, unless Wednesday had finally done what she'd spent two years being too scared to do, unless Mia had asked her out.

The thought landed in Enid's stomach like a stone.

She pushed through the library doors and stepped into the midday sun. The quad was busy , with students walking to and from classes, a Frisbee game happening on the far lawn, and a campus tour group listening to a guide talk about the history of the science building, all normal Monday things, the world continuing to turn.

Enid pulled out her phone and stared at the dark screen before remembering it was dead. "Fuck," she muttered to no one in particular.

A student walking past glanced at her, and Enid glared at him until he walked faster, then she went home.

The walk to her apartment took twelve minutes, twelve minutes of sunlight and birdsong and the distant hum of traffic, and the entire time she kept picturing Wednesday's hand on Mia's arm, the way Wednesday had smiled at her, and the way Mia had laughed, that wind-chime laugh Enid had heard in Sociology dozens of times, always irritating in its perfection, always making her roll her eyes.

But today it hadn't been irritating, it had been soft and vulnerable, the laugh of someone who'd just admitted something difficult.

God, she was losing it. She was standing at a window, analyzing the laugh of a woman she barely knew because she'd been watching her partner talk to that woman from three stories up, like some kind of deranged gargoyle.

Her apartment was quiet when she opened the door, and the kitchen counter gleamed in the afternoon light, the same counter where Wednesday had eaten her out last Thursday, the same counter where Enid had made coffee that morning while thinking about the library hookup she'd have later. The fruit magnets on the fridge smiled at her with their painted-on cheer.

She plugged in her phone, waited for it to boot up, and checked her messages, but there was nothing from Wednesday.

Not that she expected anything, because Wednesday didn't owe her a play by play of her day, and they weren't that kind of...whatever they were. Still, Enid had texted her earlier, after leaving the library, with that joke about not being able to study without thinking about her cock, and Wednesday had replied immediately. Now, two hours later, Wednesday had potentially had a life-changing conversation with the woman she'd been in love with for two years, and she hadn't mentioned it.

Maybe it wasn't life-changing, maybe it was nothing, maybe they'd just been talking about the weather.

Mia Carter didn't seem like the type to talk about the weather.

Enid sat on her couch, the same couch where she and Wednesday had eaten Thai food last Thursday, naked except for sweatpants and a tank top, with Enid's hand in Wednesday's while they studied collective behavior theory. The cushions still smelled faintly of green curry, but instead of thinking about the memory fondly, Enid found herself wondering what Mia and Wednesday had been talking about for so long, what Mia had said to make Wednesday smile like that, and whether Wednesday had looked at Mia the way she sometimes looked at Enid.

She stared at her phone, trying to convince herself that she didn't care, that whatever had happened outside the library wasn't her business, because Wednesday didn't belong to her and they weren't dating, and Enid had no right to feel jealous over a conversation between two people who had barely spoken outside of class. Except she was jealous, painfully and embarrassingly so, and the more she tried to reason herself out of it, the more she kept picturing Mia standing close to Wednesday, touching her arm, making her laugh.

She did not text Wednesday, at least not for the next three hours, because asking about Mia would make it obvious that she'd been watching, and admitting that she'd been watching would mean admitting that she cared far more than she was supposed to.

At 3:47 PM, she broke.

Saw you talking to Mia outside the library, everything okay?

She hit send before she could talk herself out of it, then threw her phone onto the other end of the couch, stood up, walked into the kitchen, poured herself a glass of water, and drank it too fast, giving herself brain freeze before she cursed loudly.

Her phone buzzed.

Enid lunged for it, actually lunged, as if it were a grenade about to explode rather than a text message from a girl she was absolutely, definitely, categorically not developing feelings for, even though the

fact that she was this desperate to know what Wednesday had said to Mia was starting to make that lie considerably harder to believe.

You saw that? Why didn't you come say hi?

I was in the east wing. By the time I got downstairs, you were gone.

A pause followed, and the three dots appeared, disappeared, then appeared again before the next message finally came through.

She asked me out.

There it was, and the stone in Enid's stomach seemed to grow heavier.

What did you say?

I said no.

Enid exhaled, only then realizing she'd been holding her breath long enough for her lungs to start burning. The relief that washed through her was immediate and embarrassingly strong, and she hated how much better those two words made her feel.

Can I ask why?

Because I didn't want to say yes. She was my dream girl for two years and I finally had the chance, and I didn't want it. Is that weird?

No, Enid typed, trying to keep her response casual. *It's not weird at all.*

She was really cool about it. She said people change and that's just variables in an equation shifting.

She said that?

She's a scientist. She talks like a scientist. It was actually kind of adorable.

Adorable. Wednesday had called Mia Carter adorable, and the word made the stone in Enid's stomach do something complicated, because apparently relief and jealousy could exist at the same time, and apparently Enid was going to feel both of them over a woman she'd supposedly had no reason to care about.

Do you regret it? she asked.

No. The response came immediately, without hesitation. *I don't regret it. I feel... lighter. Like I finally closed a chapter I've been stuck on for two years.*

That's good, Wednesday. That's really good.

Are you okay?

Enid stared at the question for a moment, because why was Wednesday asking if she was okay? Enid wasn't the one who'd just rejected her dream girl, and she wasn't the one who'd had a life-changing conversation in a library lobby. She was just the person who'd watched it happen from three stories up like a complete lunatic, and apparently she'd been obvious enough for Wednesday to notice.

I'm fine. Why wouldn't I be fine?

You saw me talking to another woman, a woman you know I used to have feelings for. I thought maybe you'd be upset.

Enid's jaw tightened as she read it, because the irritating part was that Wednesday was right, at least partially. She had been upset, she'd been jealous, and she'd spent the last few hours trying to convince herself that she had absolutely no right to be.

I don't get upset about stuff like that.

Okay.

I don't.

Okay .

Enid threw her phone onto the couch again, harder this time, and when it buzzed thirty seconds later, she didn't lunge for it. She made herself wait a full minute, then two, then three, as if refusing to check the message could somehow prove that she wasn't sitting there obsessing over what Wednesday might have said next.

You're a terrible liar, Wednesday had written.

I'm an excellent liar . I've been lying to everyone for years.

You're an excellent liar to everyone except me. I can tell when something's bothering you, your texts get shorter .

My texts are always short. I'm a concise person.

Enid.

Wednesday.

Do you want me to come over?

Enid stared at the screen, and the stone in her stomach had been replaced by something else, something warmer and more dangerous, something that felt a lot like the thing she'd been refusing to name for the past three weeks. The offer alone made her chest tighten, because part of her wanted Wednesday to come over, wanted to see her and have her close and maybe forget about Mia Carter entirely, but admitting that would mean admitting far more than she was ready to.

No, she typed. *I have homework, and you have a thesis outline that's still blank.*

It's still blank because of you.

Flattery will get you nowhere.

t's gotten me pretty far so far .

Enid laughed, alone on her couch and surrounded by the smell of Thai curry and the memory of Wednesday's hands on her body, the sound escaping before she could stop it.

Thursday , she typed. *Same time. Don't be late.*

Im never late.

You were late once, our second session. You overslept.

That was one time.

t still happened.

Goodnight, Enid.

t's 4 PM.

Goodnight anyway .

Enid stared at the final message, and despite everything she'd spent the afternoon telling herself, she couldn't stop the small smile that tugged at her mouth.

She didn't reply, instead putting her phone down and leaning back into the couch cushions as she stared at the ceiling. The water stain in the corner had gotten bigger, and she'd need to tell the landlord, adding it to the list of things she'd been meaning to do but hadn't gotten around to.

Mia Carter had asked Wednesday out, Wednesday had said no, and Enid had watched the whole thing from a library window like a character in a bad romantic comedy, except this wasn't a romantic comedy, because this wasn't romance. t was sex and studying and an arrangement that had stopped being an arrangement weeks ago.

"Fuck," she muttered to the ceiling, and the ceiling, predictably , did not respond.

Thursday couldn't come fast enough.

Across campus, in a cramped apartment with a water-stained ceiling that made Enid's look like the Sistine Chapel, Wednesday sat at her desk and stared at a blank document titled "Thesis Outline," the cursor blinking at her like it was mocking her. She hadn't written anything, not a single word, and with the outline due in two weeks, she had less than a page of notes and a head full of Enid, the way she'd sounded in the library alcove and the way her texts had gotten shorter whenever Enid was pretending not to be upset.

Wednesday knew Enid had been upset, because she could tell. Enid's texts got clipped, almost brusque, whenever she was feeling something she didn't want to admit to, and it was one of the things Wednesday had learned about her over the past few weeks, one of the small tells that cracked through Enid's practiced composure.

Another time, Wednesday would have obsessed over Mia's question, replaying the conversation a hundred times and analyzing every word, every gesture, and every possible way she could have handled it better. A month ago, she would have said yes, and she would have said it so quickly that her head would have spun, then spent the rest of the day floating on the impossible reality of Mia Carter asking her out.

But a month ago, W ednesday hadn't known what Enid's face looked like when she came, hadn't known the sounds she made when her fingers found the right spot inside her, and hadn't known the way she laughed when she was genuinely laughing, rather than using the performative laugh she brought out at parties. She hadn't known the way Enid studied either, with her brow furrowed and her pen tapping against her bottom lip, revealing a completely different person from the campus slut everyone thought they knew.

A month ago, Wednesday had been a different person too, lean from fencing but hidden beneath layers of black fabric, feeling like a ghost in her own skin until Enid started seeing her for exactly who she was.

"You're staring at a blank screen again," Bianca said from the couch.

Wednesday didn't turn around. "I'm thinking."

"You've been thinking for three hours, and thinking doesn't write a thesis."

"Thank you for that insight."

"I'm full of insights." Bianca crunched loudly on a potato chip before adding, "You want one? A real one?"

"Not particularly."

"Too bad, here it is: you're not going to finish that outline tonight because you're too distracted by whatever's going on with you and Enid."

Wednesday spun around in her chair, her lean frame poised but relaxed in her all-black attire. "There's nothing going on with me and Enid."

"Right, and I'm the Queen of England." Bianca tossed another chip into her mouth. "Ed, you've been different for weeks, happier and more confident, and you're actually showering regularly."

"I've always showered regularly."

"Debatable." Bianca sat up on the couch, crumbs scattering across her rumpled T-shirt. "Look, I'm not going to pry. You want to keep your thing with Enid private, that's fine, but whatever's happening, it's good for you. You're less..." She waved her hand vaguely, searching for the right word. "Chihuahua-ish."

"Chihuahua-ish?"

"You know, jumpy, nervous, always looking like someone's about to kick you." Bianca shrugged, then continued, "Now you're more like a golden-retriever version of yourself, confident and relaxed, still a little dorky, but in a charming way."

"Thanks, I think."

"My point is—" Bianca crunched another chip before continuing, "whatever you're doing, keep doing it, and also maybe eat something. You've been at that desk since lunch."

Wednesday looked at the clock and realized it was 6:32 PM. She'd been staring at the blank document for four hours, not three.

"Yeah," she said, finally looking away from the screen. "Maybe I'll take a break."

"There's leftover pizza in the fridge. It's been there since Friday , so it might be sentient, but it's still good."

Wednesday didn't go to the fridge. Instead, she stayed at her desk, staring at the blank document while thinking about Mia Carter and wind-chime laughs, and about the way Enid's texts had gotten shorter whenever she was pretending not to be upset.

Enid had been watching her from the window, and she hadn't come down to say hello. She'd waited three hours to text Wednesday, and when she finally did, her messages had been clipped and careful, full of all the things she wasn't saying.

Enid, campus legend and professional unbothered, had been bothered, and worse, she'd been bothered by Wednesday, by the thought of Wednesday being with someone else.

The realization settled into her chest with unexpected warmth. She wasn't proud of it, because she didn't want Enid to be upset and certainly didn't want to be the cause of any distress, but there was

something undeniably satisfying about knowing Enid cared enough to be affected by the thought of Wednesday with someone else.

Wednesday pulled out her phone, scrolled through their conversation, and reread Enid's texts, lingering on the one she'd sent earlier.

I'm fine. Why wouldn't I be fine?

Liars, she thought, they were both liars. She'd told Mia that she'd changed, and it was true, but she hadn't told Mia the whole truth. She hadn't said, *I've changed because Enid changed me.* She hadn't said, *I can't say yes to you because there's someone else, and even though we're not dating, even though we're not romantic, even though we're just partners who study and have sex and pretend not to be falling-*

She stopped, letting the unfinished thought hang there as the word *falling* settled in her mind, like a stone dropped into a pond, sending ripples outward.

She wasn't falling. They'd agreed on no feelings, and whatever existed between them was supposed to be simple, temporary, something that benefited them both. But temporary arrangements didn't make your heart race when you thought about the other person, and whatever this was between her and Enid had started to feel like much more than sex and studying, with neat black-ink notes, leftover Thai curry, and spontaneous library hookups that left them both breathless and laughing.

And whatever they were, it didn't make sense that Wednesday could say no to her dream girl without a second thought, unless there was someone else she wanted more.

"Fuck," she said quietly.

"What?" Bianca called from the couch.

"Nothing."

"You said fuck."

"I stubbed my toe."

"You're sitting at your desk."

"The desk stubbed my toe."

Bianca snorted. "Whatever, girl, eat the pizza."

Wednesday didn't eat the pizza. She stayed at her desk, staring at her phone and thinking about Thursday, about Enid, and about everything she was still refusing to call by its name.

Thursday couldn't come fast enough.

Chapter End Notes

> Yes guys, this inexperienced virgin (who isn't a virgin anymore) nerdy Wednesday really rejected her dream girl because apparently, one blonde gave her such unexpectedly amazing sex that it completely changed her priorities.

Chapter 10: The Fallout

Wednesday morning started with a pop quiz that Enid absolutely crushed. There were eleven questions on collective behaviour, emergent norm theory, and value-added theory, and she knew every answer, not because she'd crammed until her eyes bled, although she had done that too, but because she actually understood the material. Wednesday's neat, carefully organized notes, all written in black ink, had somehow seeped into Enid's brain through some kind of pedagogical osmosis, and when Enid wrote her name at the top of the page, she didn't feel the usual spike of anxiety. For once, she felt ready.

Professor Walsh collected the quizzes with his usual monotone drone about grading timelines and office hours, and Enid walked out of the lecture hall with a swagger she hadn't earned yet but was claiming anyway. The sun was shining, the birds were singing, and the campus quad stretched out before her like a green carpet of possibility, making everything feel lighter than it had in days.

She pulled out her phone and immediately started typing a message to Wednesday: *Crushed it, I actually knew the answers, like, knew them. Your notes are magic.*

Her reply came within seconds. *Not magic, just good teaching, congratulations.*

Enid smiled at the screen before typing back, *Modest now, are we?*

I learned from the best.

She smiled at her phone again, remembering Tuesday night, when she'd come over for an emergency study session and they'd spent two hours going through flashcards and practice questions on the couch, Wednesday's knee pressed against hers, with Enid's hand occasionally finding Wednesday's thigh whenever she got an answer

right. There had been no sex, just studying, just partnership, and somehow, it had been nice, really nice, the kind of nice that made Enid forget they weren't supposed to be feeling things.

Thursday was tomorrow, and Enid had been planning the glasses thing for a week and a half. Something about the way they sat on Wednesday's face, making her look so earnest and focused, made Enid want to do unspeakable things to her. She'd even bought a new pair of black lace panties specifically for the occasion, the kind that looked innocent until you got close enough to notice the detail work.

Enid was walking across the quad with her phone still in hand when she heard her name. "Enid! Hey, Enid!"

She turned to find Yoko approaching, her dark hair pulled back into a ponytail, warm eyes sparkling with the particular gleam of someone who had gossip and was dying to share it. "Yoko, what's up?"

"Oh my god, I just heard the wildest thing." Yoko fell into step beside her and lowered her voice to a theatrical whisper. "You and Wednesday, the fencing star? Are you seriously hooking up?"

The world didn't stop spinning, the birds didn't stop singing, and the sun kept shining, but something inside Enid went very, very still. "Where did you hear that?"

"Divina told me, she said Bianca, that's Wednesday's roommate, right? Bianca told Katie at the gym yesterday, and you know Katie, she tells everyone everything." Yoko laughed, that warm, conspiratorial laugh that usually made Enid feel included, but now it felt like a spotlight. "Is it true? Because honestly, I didn't see that coming, she's so, you know, quiet? And you're so, you know, not quiet?"

"I don't know what you're talking about."

"Oh, come on, you can tell me, I won't judge." Yoko leaned closer, lowering her voice again. "Is she good? She looks like she'd be

good, with that lean, athletic build from fencing, you know?"

Enid stopped walking, her heart doing something complicated in her chest, not racing or pounding, but squeezing, constricting, like a fist closing around something fragile. "It's not, we're not..." She took a breath, trying to steady herself before asking, "Who else knows?"

"Um, basically everyone?" Yoko's expression shifted from excited to uncertain. "Divina told Sophie, Sophie told the whole fencing team, Katie told her entire study group, and you know how those people talk. It's probably on, like, three different group chats by now, maybe more." She paused, looking at Enid carefully. "You didn't know?"

"No, I didn't know."

"Oh." Yoko's voice softened, and she looked genuinely sorry. "I'm sorry, I thought you'd be, I don't know, I just thought you'd be okay with it. You're usually so open about everything."

Usually, Enid was the one controlling the narrative, the one deciding what people knew and what they didn't. Her sexuality was something she wielded as a weapon, something she could control and use on her own terms, not a rumor that happened to her and spread without her permission.

"It's fine," she said, and her voice sounded normal, which was something she was quietly proud of. "I have to go, I have class."

"But it's Wednesday. You don't have-"

"I have to go."

She left Yoko standing on the quad, mouth open and confusion written across her features, then walked toward the library, her refuge, her secret spot, except it wasn't really secret anymore because Wednesday knew about it. Wednesday had found her there, had seen the part of Enid she kept hidden from everyone else,

with her color-coded notes and that smile that could make Enid forget she was supposed to be guarded.

The heating vent moaned as Enid climbed the stairs, stretching the sound into an obnoxious, drawn-out, "Aaaaaaaooooooooooh."

"Shut up," she muttered, but the vent, predictably , did not shut up.

Enid sat at her usual table, dropped her bag onto the floor, and put her head in her hands as the reality settled over her. Everyone knew, everyone, the fencing team, the study groups, the group chats, everyone was talking about her and Wednesday, about what they were doing and, worse, about what they were.

Except they weren't anything, and that was the whole point. They were partners, it was an arrangement, sex and studying tied together by an agreement not to feel anything, an agreement Enid had been breaking for weeks without wanting to admit it to herself.

And now everyone thought they were...

Her phone buzzed, pulling her out of her thoughts, and when she looked down, she saw a text from Wednesday: *Well i am so proud of you so let's celebrate tonight? Thai food? my treat this time.*

Enid stared at the message, feeling the fist around her heart squeeze tighter as she typed, *Can't, busy.* She put the phone down, only to pick it up again a moment later and type, *Did you tell Bianca about us?*

The three dots appeared, disappeared, then appeared again before Wednesday's reply came through. *Not intentionally , she figured it out. Ididn't confirm anything, why?*

Enid stared at the screen for a moment before replying, *Everyone knows, Wednesday, everyone.*

What? How?

Bianca told Katie, Katie told everyone. It's all over campus.

There was a pause, longer this time, before the three dots appeared, disappeared, and appeared again, followed by Wednesday's message. *I'm sorry, I didn't mean for that to happen, do you want to talk about it?*

No, I'll see you Thursday.

Enid shoved her phone into her bag and made a point of not looking at it again.

Thursday arrived warm and golden, the kind of spring day that made students skip class and lie on the quad with their shoes off. Enid spent the morning chain-drinking coffee, staring at her sociology textbook without actually reading a single word, her thoughts far too tangled up in everything that had happened.

By 4 PM, she'd worked herself into a state of controlled fury, not at Wednesday, not exactly, because Wednesday hadn't done anything wrong. Bianca had figured it out, Bianca had told Katie, and Katie had told the world. It wasn't Wednesday's fault that her roommate was a gossip who couldn't keep her mouth shut, but the fury needed somewhere to go, and Wednesday was the closest target.

She changed clothes four times before she arrived, finally settling on yoga pants and a cropped tank top, the same outfit she'd worn during their second session, back when this was still a transaction, still simple, still under her control. The outfit felt like armor, like a return to something she'd lost.

Wednesday knocked at 5:59 PM, because she was never late.

Enid opened the door and found Wednesday wearing the contacts and the glasses, exactly as she'd requested. Her messenger bag was slung across her chest, and she was dressed entirely in black as always, wearing a slim-fitting black shirt that clung to her lean,

athletic fencer's frame and black trousers. Her forearms were on full display, the lean muscle of her arms striking against her pale skin.

"Hey ," Wednesday said, "I brought Thai food, green curry , your favorite."

"Come in."

Wednesday stepped inside, and the familiar scent of her, something clean, like ozone and light soap, filled the apartment. She set the bag of takeout on the kitchen counter before turning to face Enid.

"I'm sorry about the rumors. I talked to Bianca this morning and told her it wasn't her place to share my business, she feels terrible."

"It doesn't matter ."

"It does matter , you're upset, I can tell."

"I'm not upset." Enid crossed her arms over her chest. "I'm just... this wasn't supposed to get out. This was supposed to be private, our arrangement, our sessions. Nobody was supposed to know."

Wednesday's expression flickered. "I know , and I'm sorry , but is it really that bad? People knowing we're... whatever we are?"

"We're not anything."

The words came out harder than Enid meant them to, sharper than she'd intended, and she saw Wednesday flinch, barely a micro-expression, but she saw it.

"I mean, we're partners," Enid amended. "That's what we agreed, but people don't understand that. They think we're dating, they think we're together , and I don't do together . I don't do relationships, I don't do people thinking I'm someone's girlfriend, that's not who I am."

Wednesday was quiet for a moment, then set her messenger bag on the couch and pushed her glasses up her nose, the gesture that had

once been nervous but was now simply familiar. "What's so bad about that?"

"About what?"

"About people thinking we're together, about being someone's girlfriend, about being with me."

The question hung in the air, and Enid didn't have an answer, at least not one she could say out loud. She had a thousand answers, but none of them were the right one.

"It's not about you," she said. "It's about me, I don't do relationships. I don't get attached, that's not how I operate. I have sex and I move on, that's who I am."

"That's who you were."

"Excuse me?"

Wednesday stepped closer, not aggressively, just present, standing there in Enid's space with her earnest eyes, her stupid glasses, and the lean line of her arm that Enid had thought about for two weeks straight.

"People change," Wednesday said. "You told me that, you told me I could be anyone I wanted to be, that I didn't have to be the nervous, stammering virgin forever, that I could follow my instincts and become someone new." She paused, then added, "Why can't you?"

"Because I'm not..." Enid stopped and started again, "I'm not like you. I don't change. I am who I am. People expect me to be the campus slut, and I give them what they expect. It's simpler that way."

"Is it?"

"Yes."

"And what does the campus slut want, right now, in this moment?"

Enid looked at Wednesday, at her face and the question in her eyes, and for a moment, she almost told her the truth. "She wants..." Her voice cracked, and she hated that it did. "She wants people to stop talking about her like she's public property, she wants her privacy back, she wants"—

She wants Wednesday, she wants this, she wants whatever this is becoming, but she couldn't say that, because saying it out loud would make it real.

"I think we should end this," Enid said.

The words landed like a slap, and although Wednesday's expression didn't change, something behind her eyes went very still.

"End what?"

"This, us, the arrangement, the partnership, whatever you want to call it."

"Because people know about it?"

"Because it's gotten too complicated, because I can't," Enid swallowed, struggling to get the words out. "I can't do complicated, I told you that from the beginning, no feelings, no attachment, just sex and studying, that was the deal."

"And now?"

"Now there are feelings," she said it like an accusation, even though she wasn't sure who she was accusing. "On your end, on my end, both, and I don't want them. I didn't sign up for feelings, I signed up for teaching a virgin how to fuck, and you learned, and now you're good at it, and you don't need me anymore."

"That's not true."

"Now there are feelings," she said it like an accusation, even though she wasn't sure who she was accusing. "On your end, on my end,

both, and Idont want them, Ididnt sign up for feelings. Isigned up for teaching a virgin how to fuck, and you learned, and now youre good at it, and you dont need me anymore."

"Thats not true."

"It is true, look at you, you rejected Mia Carter , Mia Carter, your two-year dream girl. You dont need my help anymore, youre confident, youre capable, youre..."Enid gestured at W ednesday, at all of her, at the person shed helped shape. "Y ourre done, curriculum complete, you graduated. You can go back to Mia, Im sure shell be very happy to date you, Wednesday."

Wednesdays jaw tightened. "Thats not your decision to make, and you dont get to decide how Mia feels about me either , Irejected her because Ididnt want her , Enid."

"Actually , it is, Im the teacher , Idecide when the lessons are over ."

"And what about me, what about what Iwant?"

"What do you want, W ednesday?"

"Y ou,"the word came immediately , without hesitation or a stammer, just the truth delivered directly . "Iwant you, not just the sex, not just the studying. Iwant the Thai food on the couch, the library hookups, the way you laugh when the heating vent moans, the way you look at me when you think Im not watching, Iwant all of it, Iwant..."

"Stop-"

"...to be with you, actually with you, not partners, not an arrangement, together, Iwant to be together ."

The word echoed in the silence, *together*, the thing Enid had spent her entire adult life avoiding, the thing that meant vulnerability, dependency, and the possibility of getting hurt. It was the same thing

she'd watched her parents destroy with their bitterness and affairs, followed by a divorce that left everyone broken and no one happy.

"No," she said.

"No?"

"No, I don't do together, I don't do relationships, I don't..." Enid's voice was rising, and she could hear it happening, but she couldn't stop it. "I don't want to be your girlfriend, I don't want to be anyone's girlfriend. I'm not some conquest you can claim because you finally figured out how to talk to women without stammering."

"That's not what this is."

"Then what is it, what do you think happens now? We date? We hold hands on the quad? We go to parties together, and you introduce me as your girlfriend while everyone thinks I've been tamed, that the campus slut finally settled down?" She laughed, but it was an ugly sound. "That's not happening, that's never happening, I'm not going to be your happy ending, Wednesday."

Wednesday's face went pale. "I never said you were."

"You didn't have to, I know how this story goes. The nerdy virgin loses her virginity to the experienced slut, she teaches her how to be confident, and then she goes on to find her dream girl, but somewhere along the way, you got confused. You think this is more than it is."

"It is more, you know it's more. You said yourself, you said there were feelings."

"I was wrong." Enid crossed her arms tighter, her nails digging into her biceps, and she felt the sting without pulling away from it. "Whatever I felt, it's gone now. This was a mistake, all of it, the arrangement is over, we're done."

"Enid-"

"Don't." She stepped back, away from Wednesday, away from the scent of soap, the earnest eyes, and the lean arms she'd spent weeks obsessing over. "Just don't, get your bag and leave, we're not doing this anymore."

Wednesday stood frozen, her chest rising and falling too quickly, her hands clenched at her sides. The glasses Enid had asked her to wear were slipping down her nose, but Wednesday didn't push them back up.

"You don't mean this," Wednesday said quietly. "You're scared, you're scared because people found out, and you're scared because what we have is real, and that terrifies you."

"I'm not scared of anything."

"You're the most scared person I've ever met."

"Get out."

"Enid-"

"Get the fuck out of my apartment!"

The words ripped out of Enid, loud, jagged, and completely, utterly unhinged. She heard herself scream them, and some distant part of her was horrified, but the louder part, the part that had been building ever since Yoko stopped her on the quad, didn't care.

Wednesday didn't move for a long moment, as if some part of her was still waiting for Enid to take it back, to say anything that would make her stay, but when nothing came, Wednesday slowly picked up her messenger bag and walked toward the door, each step feeling heavier than the last. She paused with her hand on the handle, her shoulders tense, and for a second she simply stood there with her

back to Enid, breathing quietly as though she was trying to collect whatever was left of herself before she walked away.

"I know you don't mean this," Wednesday said, her voice steady and quieter than Enid had ever heard it. "And when you're ready to talk, when you're ready to admit that this is more than an arrangement, I'll be here, but I'm not going to beg, and I'm not going to chase you. I care about you too much for that."

There was a long silence after that, and Enid couldn't make herself look at her. She kept her arms crossed tightly over her chest, staring somewhere past Wednesday's shoulder because looking at her felt like admitting something she wasn't ready to admit. Wednesday waited another moment, then opened the door, and just before stepping through it, she looked back at Enid one last time, her expression painfully unreadable except for the hurt in her eyes.

"Goodbye, Enid."

Then Wednesday was gone, and the door clicked shut behind her with a quiet finality that somehow hurt more than if she had slammed it. Enid stood there, still frozen in the middle of her living room, listening as Wednesday's footsteps faded down the hallway, growing quieter with every second until there was nothing left to hear.

The silence that followed was absolute, nothing like the comfortable quiet of the east wing, but instead the crushing silence of an apartment that had suddenly become too big and too empty, as if Wednesday had taken all the warmth with her when she walked out. Enid's arms were still crossed tightly over her chest, her nails digging into her biceps as if the pain could somehow keep her grounded, while the smell of Thai green curry continued to waft from the takeout bag on the counter, her favorite, the one Wednesday had remembered because she always remembered. Enid's chest heaved like she'd just run a marathon, each breath coming harder than the last.

She'd done the right thing, she'd ended it before it could get worse, before they got in deeper, before she could hurt Wednesday or Wednesday could hurt her, before they could become like her parents, bitter and broken and hating each other. She had done what she was supposed to do, what was safest for both of them, so why did it feel like she'd just ripped out her own heart?

Her phone buzzed, but she ignored it. When it buzzed again, Enid ignored that too, and by the third time, she finally looked.

The first message was from Divina: *Heard about you and Wednesday! never would have guessed but good for you guys!*

The second was from Sophie: *EDWESD Y?! RO That's wild! Katie told me everything!*

The third was from Yoko: *Im so sorry about yesterday, Ididn't mean to upset you, Ithink it's actually really sweet that you two are together, she seems like a good girl.*

Sweet, good girl, together. The words twisted something deep in Enid's chest because everyone thought they were together, everyone thought Enid was someone's girlfriend, and everyone thought the campus slut had finally been domesticated, tamed, claimed.

She threw her phone across the room, and it hit the wall before clattering to the floor, the screen cracking as a spiderweb of fractures spread from the corner. Enid stared at it for a moment, at the damage she'd done and the evidence of her own lack of control, before walking into her bedroom, slamming the door behind her, and sitting on the edge of her bed as the darkness slowly gathered around her.

Across campus, in the dorm room, Wednesday sat on the couch with her head in her hands. Bianca was at her boyfriend's place, leaving the room silent except for the hum of the refrigerator and the distant sound of traffic outside.

She'd walked home in a daze, past the quad, past the library, past the coffee shop where Enid worked double shifts, and every landmark on campus felt like a memory now, every corner, every building, every stretch of sidewalk somehow touched by Enid.

She kept replaying the last hour in her head, wishing she could go back and do it differently, but what would she actually change? Would she avoid telling Enid the truth, pretend she didn't have feelings, or go back to being the nervous virgin who couldn't look Enid in the eye? None of that was possible anymore, because Enid had changed her too much, and Wednesday wasn't that person anymore.

You're done, the curriculum is complete, you've graduated, and Mia will be very happy to date you.

Enid had said it like it was a good thing, like she was proud of her work, but the subtext was clear: *I've taught you everything I can, and now you don't need me.*

But Wednesday did need her, not for the lessons and not for the sex, though God, the sex had been incredible, especially with the unique way their bodies fit together. She needed Enid for the Thai food on the couch, the flashcards, the way she laughed at the heating vent, the way she'd held Wednesday's hand during study time, and the way she'd kissed her at the door and told her to bring her glasses.

Enid had been planning something with those glasses, something playful and sexy and completely Enid, and now Wednesday would never know what it was.

Wednesday put her phone aside and stared at the ceiling of her dorm room, her eyes fixed on nothing in particular. She sat there in the dark while the refrigerator hummed and traffic passed outside, the world continuing to turn as if nothing had happened. Thursday had arrived warm and golden and full of promise, but now it was just dark.

At 2 AM, Enid was still awake, having retrieved her phone from the floor, and the crack across the screen made everything look fractured, every message, every notification, every photo. She opened her camera roll and began scrolling through the pictures she'd taken over the past few weeks, pausing on a photo of her sociology notes, then moving to another selfie she'd taken after the party at 1427 Magnolia, her dress still unzipped and her lipstick smeared. There was also a picture of the fruit-shaped magnets on her fridge, pineapple, watermelon, grapes, the stupid little collection she'd sent to Wednesday as a joke.

I can't look at my fridge without thinking about your cock.

God, I can't look at library carrels without getting hard.

Enid had laughed when she'd read that, actually laughed as she sat alone in her apartment with her phone in her hand, grinning like an idiot at a text message from a girl who looked like a gothic dream but loved her with an intensity that terrified Enid to her core. She'd thought the fear meant something was wrong, that wanting someone this much meant giving them the power to hurt her, and that if she ended things first, she could still walk away before it became something she couldn't control.

But now that Wednesday was actually gone, Enid could finally see what she'd done, she'd mistaken being scared for not wanting her, mistaken vulnerability for weakness, and convinced herself that ending things was the safest choice when all she'd really done was tear away the one person who had made her feel seen.

And now Wednesday was gone. Enid had pushed her away, screamed at her to get out, told her the arrangement was over and that she wanted nothing to do with her, even though the truth was the exact opposite, she wanted everything to do with Wednesday, so badly that it scared her, and that was the problem. She didn't want the arrangement to end, she didn't want the late-night studying or the Thai food on the couch or the ridiculous library hookups or Wednesday's quiet presence in her apartment to disappear, she

didnt want Wednesday to become someone she used to know, and for the first time, Enid had to admit that what terrified her wasnt losing herself in someone, it was losing Wednesday.

Her phone buzzed again, and Enid glanced at the time, 2 AM. Who the hell was texting at 2 AM? When she looked at the screen, she saw it was Wednesday.

You're probably asleep but Ineed to ask you something. Iknow you said we're done and the arrangement is over but Idon't think we actually settled what happens now . Imeant what Isaid about wanting to be with you but if you don't want that, Ill respect it. Ill transfer to another Sociology section, find somewhere else to study and stay out of your way. Ijust need a clear answer from you, not something you said while you were angry. Do you want me to go? f you do, Ill go, and Iwon't bother you again.

Enid read the message three times, then a fourth, then a fifth, letting every word sink in until she could practically hear Wednesdays voice saying them.

Her fingers hovered over the keyboard as she typed, *Iwant you to go,* but after staring at the words for a moment, she deleted them. She tried again, *t's better this way ,* but that disappeared too, and when she finally typed, *Idon't know what Iwant,* she deleted that as well.

Enid put the phone down, but picked it up again almost immediately, staring at Wednesdays message until the words blurred in front of her. She knew Wednesday was asking for a simple answer, something she could give her if she was really certain about what she wanted, but Enid wasnt certain anymore. She had spent the last few hours telling herself that ending things was the right choice, that pushing Wednesday away would protect them both, yet now that Wednesday was giving her exactly what shed demanded, the chance to walk away for good, Enid couldnt bring herself to say yes.

She didnt respond, because she couldnt.

Friday morning arrived gray and drizzly, the kind of weather that matched Enid's mood perfectly. She dragged herself out of bed at 10 AM, pulled on the same sweatpants she'd been wearing for three days, and shuffled into the kitchen, where the Thai food was still sitting on the counter, the green curry she'd ordered with Wednesday still in its takeout container. The smell had faded overnight, still there but faint, and soon it would be gone entirely, just like everything else.

Enid made coffee, drank it black, and stood by the window, staring out at the rain sliding down the glass. Her phone buzzed, and when she checked it, there were messages from several students around campus asking about her and Wednesday, how long they'd been hooking up and what had happened between them.

One message in particular made Enid's jaw tighten.

Iheard you and Wednesday were hooking upis she actually good in bed? Because Ilike her and honestly , Id love to tire her out.

Enid stared at the message for a few seconds, jealousy burning hot enough to cut through the exhaustion weighing on her. *Tire her out? Please, only Ican tire her out like that.* The thought came so naturally that it only made her more annoyed because she knew exactly how much stamina Wednesday had, and the idea of some random girl discovering it for herself made something ugly and possessive twist in her chest. *Not that it's any of your business,* Enid thought, even though she was already far more bothered by the message than she wanted to admit.

She blocked the girl's number without replying, because she didn't owe anyone an explanation, and she certainly wasn't going to sit there while some random girl talked about Wednesday as if she were available for the taking.

The words *hooking up* still made Enid pause, because they'd never even been together, yet people were already talking about them as if they had been, and the rumour mill had somehow spun an entire

narrative about them meeting and hooking up, all without any input from the actual people involved.

She opened her messages with Wednesday and reread the text from the night before. *Do you want me to go?*

Yes, she thought, then no, then yes again, because she wanted Wednesday to stay, she wanted Wednesday to leave, and part of her even wished Wednesday had never existed in the first place, because then she wouldn't have to feel like this, cracked open, hollowed out, and completely, utterly lost, so Enid put her phone down and went back to bed.

At noon, someone knocked on her door. Enid ignored it, still lying in bed in the same sweatpants, staring at the ceiling. The water stain in the corner had gotten bigger, and she should probably call the landlord, just like she should probably do a lot of other things.

The knock came again, harder this time.

"Enid? It's Yoko, I know you're in there. I brought coffee and bagels, so please open the door."

Enid didn't move.

"I'm not leaving," Yoko called through the door. "I'll sit in this hallway all day if I have to. The neighbours are already giving me weird looks, and one of them has a cat that keeps trying to get in my lap."

Enid groaned, finally rolling out of bed and shuffling toward the door before opening it a crack.

Yoko stood in the hallway holding two cups of coffee and a paper bag, her expression soft with concern, with no judgement and no gossipy gleam, just genuine worry.

"Hey," Yoko said, looking her over. "You look terrible."

"Thanks."

"I brought carbs." She held up the bag. "Everything bagels, your favourite."

"How do you know my favourite bagel?"

"You told me last semester before the coffee shop became your second home. You said everything bagels were the only good thing about mornings."

Enid had no memory of that conversation, but it sounded exactly like something she would have said.

"Come in," she said, stepping aside.

Yoko walked in and immediately headed for the kitchen, setting the coffee on the counter next to the Thai food and the fruit magnets, right beside all the evidence of Wednesday's last visit, before pulling the bagels out of the paper bag.

"Sit down, eat, and talk to me."

Enid sat at the kitchen counter, the same counter where Wednesday had eaten her out two weeks ago, the same counter where she'd sat just last week, eating Thai food with Wednesday's hand in hers.

"I don't want to talk," Enid said.

"Too bad, you've been holed up in here for almost twenty-four hours, and people are worried, I'm worried."

"People?"

"The people who care about you, which is more people than you think." Yoko slid a coffee across the counter. "Drink it, it's a vanilla latte with an extra shot."

Enid took a sip, the coffee was good, warm and comforting, everything she didn't feel like she deserved.

"I screwed up," she said quietly.

"What happened?"

"Wednesday happened, Bianca told Katie, Katie told everyone, and I..." Enid stopped and swallowed before forcing herself to continue, "I panicked, I told her the arrangement was over, I told her I wanted nothing to do with her, and I screamed at her to get out of my apartment."

"Arrangement?"

"The sex tutoring, the studying, all of it, it was supposed to be a transaction, she helped me with Sociology, and I helped her with sex, but it stopped being a transaction weeks ago and I didn't want to admit it."

Yoko was quiet for a moment, taking a bite of her bagel and chewing thoughtfully before looking back at Enid.

"So you have feelings for her."

"I don't—"

"Enid, come on, I've known you for two years, you don't scream at people unless you care about them, and you don't push people away unless you're terrified of letting them in." Yoko took another bite, then nodded toward her. "So, feelings, yes or no?"

Enid stared down at her coffee as the foam slowly dissolved, the vanilla smell fading with it.

"Yes," she whispered. "I have feelings for her, a lot of feelings, feelings I don't want, feelings I didn't ask for, feelings that make me want to crawl out of my skin and disappear."

"That's called being human."

"It's called being weak."

"No, it's called being human," Yoko reached across the counter and placed her hand over Enid's. "You've spent so long pretending you don't care about anyone that you've convinced yourself it's true, but it isn't, you care about Wednesday, you care about me, and you care about all the people you pretend not to notice, you're not the campus slut, Enid, you're Enid, and Enid is scared of getting hurt."

Enid's throat tightened. "I'm not—"

"You are and it's okay. Everyone's scared of getting hurt, but pushing people away doesn't protect you, it just leaves you alone." Yoko squeezed her hand gently. "Do you want to be alone?"

No, she hadn't, because she'd been alone her whole life, surrounded by people who wanted her body but not her thoughts, her attention but not her time, her reputation but not her reality. She'd been alone in crowded rooms, alone at parties, and alone in the library with her books, her notes, and the heating vent that moaned like a dying whale.

And then Wednesday had shown up, with her earnest eyes, her neat black-ink notes, and those lean, fencer's forearms Enid couldn't stop thinking about. Wednesday had seen her, actually seen her, not the campus slut, not the party girl, not the legend, just Enid, her E-nid.

And she'd screamed at Wednesday to get out.

"I don't know how to fix it," she said.

"You start by admitting you were wrong."

"I was wrong."

"Not to me, to her." Yoko pulled out her phone. "Call her, text her, something but don't let this sit. The longer you wait, the harder it'll be."

Enid looked at her phone, at the cracked screen and the spiderweb of fractures running across it. She picked it up, opened her messages, and stared at Wednesday's last text.

Do you want me to go?

She typed, *No,* then deleted it.

She tried again, *I don't want you to go,* but that disappeared too.

Finally, she typed, *I'm sorry.*

Her thumb hovered over the send button, her heart pounding as her palms grew sweaty, while everything inside her screamed at her to stop, retreat, and protect herself.

"What if she doesn't forgive me?" she whispered.

"What if she does?" Yoko asked.

Enid looked at the cracked screen, at the message, and at the possibility sitting there in front of her, then pressed send.

The message delivered, but the three dots didn't appear, and there was no immediate reply.

She stared at the screen, waiting, but nothing happened.

"She's probably in class," Yoko said. "Or at practice. She's a fencer, right? She'll respond when she can."

"Right. Yeah. Probably."

But the silence stretched on, one minute, then two, then five, then ten.

Enid finally put her phone down and pushed her coffee away, the vanilla latte already gone cold.

"She's not going to respond," she said. "I broke it. I broke us, whatever we were."

"Give her time."

"I don't deserve time."

"Maybe not, but you still deserve to try." Yoko stood up and grabbed her bag. "I have class in twenty minutes, but I'm going to text you in two hours, and if you haven't left this apartment, I'm coming back to check on you myself."

"You're coming back?"

"You're not alone, Enid, even if you want to be."

Yoko left, and the door clicked shut behind her as the apartment settled back into silence, leaving Enid at the kitchen counter with the Thai food still sitting there, the fruit magnets still smiling, and the rain still sliding down the window. Her phone buzzed, and she grabbed it so quickly that she nearly dropped it, but it wasn't Wednesday, just an automated text from campus parking services reminding them to renew their permit. Enid threw the phone onto the counter and buried her face in her hands.

At 7 PM, Wednesday finished her session at the salle. She'd been fencing for two hours, bout after bout, pushing her lean, athletic body until her muscles screamed and her lungs burned. The rhythmic clash of steel and the focused precision of the sport were the only things that made sense anymore, the movement, the silence behind the mask, and the way her thoughts finally quieted when she was moving fast enough to outpace them.

She checked her phone in the locker room, still dressed in her black gear, her skin glistening with sweat beneath the dark fabric, and saw a text from Enid that had been sent hours ago.

Im sorry.

That was it, just two words with no follow up and no explanation, only *Im sorry*. Wednesday stared at the message, her dark hair clinging to her neck, damp from exertion, her hands steady even as her mind suddenly became very, very awake. She was sorry, but sorry for what, for ending things, for screaming at Wednesday, for pushing her away, or for letting herself feel something she hadnt wanted to feel?

Wednesday wanted to respond, God, she wanted to respond. She wanted to call Enid, text her, go to her apartment, knock on the door, and tell Enid that she forgave her, that she understood, and that she wasnt going anywhere.

But shed told Enid she wouldnt chase her, and shed promised to wait for Enid to come to her.

Ineed you to tell me, do you want me to go?

Enid hadnt answered that question, not really. *Im sorry* wasnt an answer, but it was a placeholder, a first step, a crack in the door, and Wednesday couldnt help wondering if it meant Enid was finally starting to open it.

Wednesday needed Enid to open it all the way, but she knew she couldnt force her to.

She left the locker room and walked across the darkening campus, wrapped in her favorite oversized black coat. The rain had stopped, leaving the sidewalks slick and glistening beneath the streetlamps, while the air smelled clean, like wet concrete and spring flowers, with the faint scent of the gym still clinging to her skin.

She passed the library, where the lights were still on in the east wing. Someone was in there, studying in the secret spot that had once belonged only to Enid, and Wednesday found herself wondering if it was Enid, if shed gone back to the one place that felt safe, sitting at her table, taking notes, eating granola bars, and listening to the

heating vent moan. t could just as easily have been a stranger who'd discovered the spot on their own, completely unaware of its history and everything that had happened in the alcove behind the bound periodicals.

Wednesday didn't go inside because she wasn't ready to see Enid, not yet. Instead, she walked back to her dorm, climbed the stairs to her floor, and opened the door to find Bianca on the couch, watching TV with a bag of chips open on her lap.

"God, W ednesday, you look like death," Bianca said, looking up at her.

"Thanks," W ednesday replied, dropping onto the couch.

"Long practice?"

"Something like that."

Bianca muted the TV and sat up, "Look, I know I screwed up, I told Katie, she told everyone, and now everything's messed up between you and Enid, I feel like shit about it."

"It's not your fault," W ednesday said.

"It is my fault, I shouldn't have said anything, I was just, I don't know , I was excited for you. Y ou've been so much happier lately , and I thought it was a good thing that people knew, I didn't realize she'd react like that."

Wednesday sat down on the opposite end of the couch, her posture still rigid and poised despite the exhaustion weighing on her. "Neither did I, and I don't know what I'm supposed to do now ."

Bianca looked at her for a moment before asking, "Is there anything I can do?"

"No, it's between me and her ."

"Are you going to be okay?"

Wednesday looked down at her phone, at the cracked screen and the silence surrounding Enid's last message, *I'm sorry.*

"I don't know," she said, her voice quieter this time, "I really don't know."

She went to her room and closed the door behind her, then lay down on her bed and stared up at the ceiling as she typed a response.

I know you're sorry and I forgive you, but I need more than sorry. I need you to tell me what you want. Do you want me to come back, or do you want me to stay away? I'll respect whatever you choose, but I can't keep waiting for an answer you won't give.

She pressed send and waited.

At 3 AM, Enid's phone buzzed on her nightstand, and she was still awake, though her body felt like it had stopped belonging to her hours ago. She'd been awake for almost 48 hours, running on too much coffee, adrenaline, and the stubborn ache in her chest that refused to let her settle. Her eyes burned every time she blinked, her head felt heavy and strangely hollow, and she'd lost track of how many times she'd gotten out of bed only to wander around the apartment before returning to the same spot again. She was exhausted enough to feel sick, but every time she closed her eyes, her mind dragged her straight back to Wednesday, to the argument, to the door closing behind her, and to every word she'd said that she wished she could take back.

When the phone buzzed again, Enid reached for it slowly, her fingers clumsy with exhaustion, and read Wednesday's message, then read it again and a third time, because for a few seconds the words seemed to blur together before her tired eyes could make sense of them.

Ineed you to tell me what you want.

Enid stared at the screen, blinking hard as she opened the keyboard and typed, *Iwant you.* She was too tired to overthink it, too exhausted to build another wall around the truth, so she didnt delete the message, and after a moment, she typed again, *Iwant you to come back.*

She left that there too, her thumb resting against the screen as she struggled to keep her eyes open, and after another long pause, she added, *Ijust want to be Enid, Y our E-nid.*

Enid stared at the words, and something inside her loosened, just a little, because for once she wasnt trying to be the campus slut, the girl everyone expected her to be, or the person who always had everything under control. She was just Enid, W ednesdays E-nid, and that was the truth shed been running from.

She pressed send before she could change her mind, then let the phone fall onto the nightstand, pulled her knees to her chest, and rested her forehead against them, too tired to do anything else as she waited for the sun to rise.

Chapter 11: Choosing Each Other

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The flyer was neon orange and completely obnoxious.

Enid found it stapled to the bulletin board outside the sociology building, where someone had pinned it at eye level between a poster for a vegan bake sale and a flyer for a lost cat named Chairman Meow. The paper was already curling at the edges from the morning drizzle, but the text was impossible to miss.

MA TLANI C I NERCOLEGI A TE FENI N CHAMSHI P
Saturday, April 15th - 2:00 PM
Campus Athletic Complex
Featuring: Women's Individual Foil

She stood there for a full minute, rain misting her hair as students jostled past her on the sidewalk, and when someone's elbow caught her shoulder, she barely noticed.

She'd heard in passing that the campus team was competing, and Wednesday was competing tomorrow. Enid had known Wednesday fenced, obviously, considering the lean strength in her arms, the precise way she carried herself, and the disciplined stillness of her posture, but she'd never asked about competitions, her rank, her bouts, or whether she got nervous before a match. She'd been too busy using Wednesday, too busy pretending she didn't care.

The flyer featured a little cartoon fencer in a lunging position, looking happy and confident, like she had her life together and wasn't waiting for a text from a girl who'd screamed at her to get out of her apartment.

Enid's phone buzzed in her pocket, and she pulled it out, the cracked screen covered in spiderweb fractures, checking the notification only to find that it wasn't Wednesday, just Yoko asking if she wanted to grab lunch.

She didn't want to, as Enid hadn't eaten anything substantial in two days, and the Thai food was still sitting on her counter, cold and congealed, probably growing something that would require a hazmat team, but she hadn't been able to throw it away because doing so meant acknowledging that Wednesday wasn't coming back.

Enid looked at the flyer again, at the cartoon fencer and the promise that Wednesday would be there, competing. One thought settled in her mind, clear and impossible to ignore. *Broke it, fix it.*

She'd broken whatever they had, and now she had to fix it, or at least try. Enid had never been good at fixing things. She was the campus slut who left when things got complicated, burning bridges and dancing in the ashes instead of trying to rebuild them.

But Wednesday was different, she'd told Enid she wanted her, she'd typed those words and sent them into the void, and now there was nothing but silence and the faint hope that Wednesday had read them and understood.

Yoko's voice echoed in her head, *What if she does forgive you?*

Enid pulled the flyer off the board.

Saturday dawned too bright and too early, and Enid had slept maybe four hours, her first real sleep in three days, a desperate crash into unconsciousness that left her groggy and disoriented, reaching for a body that wasn't there. The other side of her bed was cold, which shouldn't have mattered because she'd slept alone for years, but the absence felt different now, intentional, like the bed itself was judging her.

She showered, washed her hair, and actually used conditioner instead of just standing under the water and staring at the tile, something she'd been doing a lot lately. The water stain on her bedroom ceiling had definitely gotten bigger, and she'd even named it Clive, the only male presence in her life right now, who happened to be a mold spore.

It was 1:45 PM, the competition started in fifteen minutes, and the athletic complex was a fifteen minute walk from her apartment, so she could still make it if she hurried.

She stood in front of her closet for too long, wondering what you wore to a fencing match, what you wore to apologize, and what you wore when you were the girl who'd screamed "get the fuck out" and then texted "I want you" at 3 AM, only to receive no reply for over twenty-four hours.

She chose a sundress, pale yellow and simple, the kind of dress that said *I'm not trying too hard* while also making it obvious that she definitely had. Enid pulled her hair back into a ponytail and kept her makeup minimal, just mascara and lip gloss, enough to look human without looking like she was performing.

The walk to the complex passed in a blur, with the quad packed with students enjoying the spring sun, frisbees flying, picnic blankets spread across the grass, and the occasional ambitious person attempting to study while simultaneously getting a tan. Enid wove through them without really seeing anyone, her focus narrowed to a single point, the glass-and-steel building at the far end of campus where a neon orange flyer had promised her a chance.

The venue smelled of floor wax and adrenaline, its vast interior echoing like a cathedral.

Enid slipped through the double doors at 2:07 PM, already late and breathless, to find the bleachers half-full of parents with video cameras, students wearing school colors, and other fencers wrapped in warm-up jackets and nervous energy. She scanned the crowd for

familiar faces and spotted them clustered near the front, Sophie with her loud voice carrying over the ambient noise, Divina leaning back with her arms crossed, Katie with her hair pulled into a messy bun, and a handful of other teammates Enid recognized from parties.

She didn't see Bianca, which was probably for the best, because Enid wasn't sure she was ready to face Wednesday's roommate, knowing Bianca would likely have a few things to say about how she'd treated Wednesday.

Enid found a seat alone in the back corner of the bleachers, hoping to remain invisible, or as invisible as she could ever be, which wasn't much. Even in a pale yellow sundress with minimal makeup, she still drew glances, as she always did, and it was exhausting.

The announcer's voice boomed over the PA system, introducing the next bout, "Wednesday Addams, representing our very own home team."

Enid's heart did something complicated, not racing or pounding, just squeezing with the same fist clenching sensation she'd felt when Yoko told her the rumours were everywhere, only this time it felt tighter and more personal.

Wednesday walked onto the strip, and Enid realized she'd seen her a hundred times before, in her apartment, in the library, and in the third floor bedroom at 1427 Magnolia. She'd seen Wednesday naked, aroused, vulnerable, confident, and everything in between, but she'd never seen her like this.

Wednesday was dressed entirely in black fencing gear, the protective jacket fitted sharply against her slender frame and the black breeches emphasizing her athletic legs. Her dark hair was pulled back as she adjusted her glove with the same precise, economical movements she seemed to bring to everything.

For a moment, before Wednesday lowered her mask, Enid could see her calm, focused face, so different from the nervous virgin who'd

stammered through their first session or the earnest girl who'd brought Enid Thai food and stacks of neatly organized notes, all in black. This was someone else, someone Enid had helped create.

"Strip one: Wednesday Addams versus Maya Bennett."

The crowd erupted, with Sophie's voice cutting through the noise as she shouted, "LET'S GO WEDNESDAY! TAKE HER DOWN!" Divina joined in, yelling, "DESTROY THEM!" while Katie waved a small handmade sign that read *GO Wednesday GO* in glittery letters.

Enid sat frozen in the back corner, her hands clenched on her knees as her sundress suddenly felt too thin, too yellow, too everything, because Wednesday looked hot.

Not just pretty or beautiful in the way Enid had gotten used to noticing, but something else entirely, because seeing Wednesday dressed in black fencing gear, foil in hand, shoulders squared and posture perfectly controlled, made Enid's brain go completely blank.

She shouldn't have come, it was a mistake, an invasion of privacy, and showing up uninvited to an event she'd only learned about because of a neon orange flyer she'd torn off a bulletin board was probably the worst decision she'd made all week.

But she couldn't leave, and she couldn't even make her legs work as she remained anchored to the bleacher, watching Wednesday step onto the strip, raise her foil, and settle into position. Enid swallowed, thinking, *Oh, God, she looks good.*

Broke it, fix it.

"En garde!" the referee called, and the next few minutes became the longest of Enid's life.

Enid didn't know anything about fencing, including right-of-way, parry-ripostes, or the difference between a touch and a point, so all she could do was watch Wednesday's body move with a lethal, feline

grace, a blur of black as her foil snapped forward with mechanical precision and her feet danced across the strip in a series of lightning-fast advances and retreats.

Wednesday was fast, even Enid could tell that, and she dominated the space with movements so fluid they looked like choreography. The crowd was on its feet, Sophie was screaming herself hoarse, and Katie's glittery sign was shaking so hard that it was shedding sparkles.

Enid could only watch Wednesday's lean thigh muscles flex as she lunged, the sharp angle of her wrist as she scored another point, and the absolute, chilling confidence with which she moved. Enid had once had her hands on that waist, dragged her nails down those lean shoulders, and pressed her lips against that neck, and now she was the same girl who'd screamed at Wednesday to get out of her apartment.

The final point came with Wednesday locked in a tense stalemate against her opponent, both girls circling and breathing heavily as the air thickened with anticipation. The noise inside the complex was deafening, with the acoustics amplifying every shout, cheer, and stomp of feet against the metal bleachers, while Enid leaned forward, gripping the edge of her seat with her heart pounding in her throat.

"Come on," she whispered, repeating the words under her breath. "Come on, come on, come on."

Wednesday suddenly lunged forward in an explosive movement, a flash of steel followed by the electronic buzzer's wail as the light on her side turned green, signalling victory.

The crowd exploded, Sophie vaulted over the railing and nearly fell onto the strip, Katie cried with actual tears streaming down her face, and Divina pumped her fist into the air while shouting something unintelligible.

Wednesday pulled off her mask, glanced up at the scoreboard, and smiled, and Enid had never seen her smile like that before. It wasn't the shy, nervous smile of the virgin who'd asked Enid to keep their arrangement secret, nor was it the proud smile of the partner who'd made her come twice in one session, but something entirely new, raw and unfiltered, filled with a joy that seemed to come from somewhere deep inside her.

Enid wanted to be the reason Wednesday smiled like that, and she wanted to deserve that smile, too. She didn't, not yet, but maybe she could.

The competition continued with more events, more fencers, and more cheers, but Enid remained in her seat in the back corner, watching the rest of the meet without really seeing any of it as her mind circled the same thoughts over and over, *I broke it, I fix it, I broke it, I fix it.*

At 4:30 PM, the competition ended, with the home team winning overall and Wednesday's individual gold playing a major part in their victory. The fencers gathered their gear, posed for photos, and accepted congratulations from friends and family as the bleachers slowly emptied.

Enid stood up on shaky legs, her mouth dry from nerves and the fact that she hadn't brought any water , carrying nothing but her cracked phone, her pounding heart, and the desperate hope that she hadn't ruined everything.

She made her way down the bleachers, passing parents, students, and glittery signs, before reaching the floor, which was chaotic with fencing gear, white jackets draped over benches, mesh masks resting on tables, and the sharp scent of sweat and ozone lingering in the air. Near the locker room entrance, she spotted the team gathered around Wednesday, who stood at the center of the group.

Wednesday had partially unzipped her fencing jacket, leaving the heavy white fabric hanging open to reveal her black athletic gear

underneath, while her hair was a damp mess from being tucked beneath the mask. Sophie had an arm around her shoulders, Katie was still holding her sign, and Divina was talking animatedly about something, probably the final touch, as she replayed every move in obsessive detail.

Enid hung back, waiting because she couldn't simply walk up to Wednesday in the middle of her victory celebration, that would be selfish, another way of making everything about herself when this wasn't about her , not anymore. This was about Wednesday, about fixing what she'd broken.

She retreated to the far end of the floor, near the equipment racks where the crowd was thinner, leaned against the wall, and checked her phone, but there were no new messages, which she hadn't expected anyway.

Five minutes passed, then ten, and as the crowd around Wednesday began to thin, Sophie waved goodbye and headed for the exit, Katie gave Wednesday a hug before making her way to the women's locker room, and Divina clapped her on the shoulder before jogging off to catch up with someone else.

Wednesday was finally alone, gathering her gear, including her bag, foil, and water bottle, when Enid pushed away from the wall and slowly walked toward her.

Wednesday noticed Enid before she could reach her, and her hands stilled on the gear bag as her expression shifted from surprise to confusion, with something else Enid couldn't quite name beneath it. She straightened slowly, her black athletic shirt clinging to her lean frame and her dark hair still a damp mess from beneath the fencing mask.

"Hey ," Enid said, her voice coming out steadier than she felt, which was something, at least.

"Hey ," Wednesday replied, her voice neutral and guarded, like someone who'd been hurt and wasn't sure if it was safe to stop hurting.

"Congratulations, you were..." Enid gestured vaguely toward the strip, the scoreboard, and the entire athletic complex, struggling to find the right words before settling on, "Really good, the best, obviously, you won."

A ghost of a smile twitched at the corner of Wednesday's mouth. "Thanks."

"I didn't know you were this good, you never told me."

"You never asked."

The words landed like a punch, clean and precise, and Enid knew she deserved them.

"No," she admitted, lowering her gaze briefly , "I didn't, I should have."

Silence settled between them as the gym air grew heavy with the scent of floor wax and exertion, while somewhere in the distance, someone laughed and the PA system crackled with static, leaving the moment stretched between them, thin and fragile, like a soap bubble about to pop.

"I got your texts," Wednesday said finally, "the ones at 3 AM."

"I figured."

"I didn't respond, and I'm sorry ."

"You don't have to apologize, I'm the one who—" Enid stopped, swallowed, and tried again, forcing herself to say what she should have said from the beginning. "I'm the one who needs to apologize, for Thursday, for screaming at you, for telling you to get out, for all of it."

Wednesday pulled her gear bag closer and shifted her weight. "Why did you?"

"Because I was scared."

"Of what?"

"Of this, of us, of whatever we were becoming." Enid crossed her arms over her chest, the same defensive gesture she'd made on Thursday, the same armor she couldn't seem to shed. "People found out, the rumours started, everyone knew, and I couldn't control any of it. I couldn't control the narrative or what people thought of me, and I hate that, I hate not being in control."

"I know ."

"And I hate that you know that, I hate that you see me, actually see me, not the campus slut or the party girl, just me, Enid, scared and broken and pushing people away because it's easier than letting them in."

Wednesday's expression remained unchanged as she listened, really listened, the way she'd listened when Enid taught her to kiss and guided her through her first time, patient and attentive, waiting for Enid to finish without interrupting.

"You said you wanted to be E-nid," Wednesday said, referring to her text, "what does that mean?"

Enid slowly uncrossed her arms and let them fall to her sides, leaving herself vulnerable and exposed without the armour she'd been hiding behind.

"It means I don't want to be the campus slut anymore, I don't want to be the girl who uses sex as a weapon or the girl who can't have a real relationship because she's too scared of turning into her parents." Enid let out a laugh, a real one this time, nothing like the ugly laugh she'd forced out on Thursday , something softer and more

honest. "I just want to be the girl who eats Thai food on the couch with a girl who brings her black notes, the girl who laughs at heating vents, the girl who has a favourite bagel, the girl who—" Her voice cracked, but she let it, refusing to hide behind another joke or pretend she was fine. "The girl who's allowed to have feelings for someone and not run away from them."

Wednesday stood very still, her eyes fixed on Enid's face. "What are you saying?"

"I'm saying—" Enid took the biggest breath of her life, the kind of breath you take before jumping off a cliff into water when you can't see the bottom. "I'm not changing overnight, relationships still freak me out, feelings still gross me out, and the idea of being someone's girlfriend, of being yours, makes me want to crawl out of my skin and disappear."

"Okay."

"But I want you." The words tumbled out, clumsy and desperate but completely honest. "I want you more than I've ever wanted anyone, I want your lean strength, your glasses, your black notes, the way you look at me when you think I'm not watching, the Thai food, the study sessions, and the way you kiss me like I'm the only person in the world." Enid paused to catch her breath, her heart pounding as she forced herself to keep going. "I want to try, to be better and do better, to stop running away when things get hard. I can't promise I'll be good at it, and I can't promise I won't freak out again, but I can promise I'll try, if you'll let me."

The athletic complex was quiet now, the last of the crowd having filtered out, leaving only the distant echo of footsteps in the corridor and the steady hum of the ventilation. Enid stood in the middle of the floor, her sundress clinging to her skin and her heart hammering in her chest as she waited for Wednesday to respond.

Wednesday remained silent for a long moment before stepping closer, close enough for Enid to catch the sharp scent of the salle

mixed with soap and the indefinable warmth that was uniqely hers, close enough to see the determination in Wednesday's dark eyes.

"Willingness and ef fort," Wednesday said, "that's all I can ask of you, and that's all I've ever asked of you."

"Really?"

"Really." Wednesday slowly reached out, giving Enid enough time to pull away, before taking her hand. Her fingers were slender and strong, while Enid's trembled slightly, but their hands fit together anyway. "I'm not asking you to be my girlfriend, to hold my hand on the quad, attend every fencing meet, or suddenly become someone you're not. I'm asking you to stop running, to stop pushing me away every time things get real, and to try."

"I can do that, I think, and I want to do that."

"Then we're good."

"We're good?"

"We're good." Wednesday smiled, not quite the shy smile Enid knew from their earlier moments together, nor the openly joyful one she'd seen on other occasions, but something in between, something hopeful. "Now come here, I've wanted to kiss you for three days, and I'm not waiting any longer."

Enid stepped closer, letting Wednesday wrap her arms around her, and rested against her firm, lean chest beneath the black shirt, the softness of Enid's pale yellow sundress contrasting with Wednesday's dark clothes in a way that felt strangely right.

Wednesday kissed her, and it wasn't the tentative first kiss of their second session, the hungry kiss they had shared at the party at 1427 Magnolia, or the desperate one from Thursday afternoon, just before everything fell apart. This kiss was something new, something

steady, carrying the promise that *we're okay, we're going to be okay, and Im not going anywhere* .

Enids hands found W ednesdays face, tracing her jaw before slipping into the damp strands of her hair, and she kissed Wednesday back with everything she had, pouring into the kiss all the apologies sheld left unspoken, all the fears she hadnt admitted, and all the feelings sheld spent weeks trying to escape.

When they finally pulled apart, both were breathing hard, their foreheads resting gently against each others as they stood close, neither of them in a hurry to move away. Wednesdays foil was still tucked inside her gear bag, and the gym remained silent around them as the world continued turning.

"So," Enid said, her voice still a little shaky , "I ruined our Thursday session, does that mean Iowe you a make-up class?"

Wednesday laughed. "Y ou dont owe me anything."

"Seriously , Ihad plans, glasses plans, very elaborate, very sexy glasses plans, and then Iscreamed at you, threw my phone at the wall, and didnt sleep for two days."

"Y our phone?"

"Long story ." Enid pulled it out of her pocket, showing W ednesday the cracked screen as it caught the fluorescent light. "This is what happens when you have feelings you dont want to have."

Wednesday gently took the phone and turned it over in her hands. "Y ou threw your phone at the wall?"

"Across the room, it was dramatic, and Im not proud of it."

"I kind of wish Id seen it."

"It wasnt my best moment."

I've seen a lot of your moments, and this one sounds pretty entertaining."

Enid snatched the phone back, narrowing her eyes at Wednesday. "You're making fun of me."

"A little." Wednesday grinned, clearly enjoying herself. "You screamed at me to get out of your apartment, that calls for at least a week of gentle mockery."

"A week?"

"Minimum."

Enid tried to glare at Wednesday but failed, the expression melting into a smile instead, a real one, not the performative smile she used at parties or the seductive one she used to get what she wanted, just a smile that belonged to her, just Enid.

"I missed you," Enid admitted, the words feeling strange and unfamiliar in her mouth, leaving her vulnerable in a way she wasn't used to, but she said them anyway.

"I missed you too." Wednesday squeezed her hand, her expression softening before she added, "Now, tell me about these glasses plans."

They walked back to Enid's apartment together as the sun began setting, painting the campus in shades of gold, pink, and orange. The quad was quieter now, with the afternoon crowd having dispersed to dining halls and dorm rooms, heading off to whatever Saturday night plans awaited them. Enid's sundress had a few smudges from the gym floor, pale marks on the yellow fabric that would probably never come out, but she didn't care.

Wednesday carried her gear bag over one shoulder, having changed out of her fencing whites into black jeans and a black T-shirt, her lean, striking silhouette standing out against the sunset. Every few

steps, their arms brushed against each other, and each time it happened, Enid felt the urge to reach for Wednesday's hand and hold it, but she didn't, not yet, baby steps.

"So, about those glasses plans," Enid began as they turned onto her street, "I had this whole elaborate thing planned, I bought new underwear, black lace, very expensive, and I was going to do this whole..." She waved her hand vaguely , searching for the right words. "Scene, roleplay , teacher and student, you'd keep the glasses on, and I'd pretend to be a strict professor who needed to give you private tutoring."

Wednesday made a strangled sound. "Private tutoring."

"Mm-hmm, I had a script and everything, well, not exactly a script, more like a loose outline. I was going to sit you down at my kitchen table and lecture you about, I don't know , biology, anatomy, the reproductive system, and you were going to be a very eager student."

"The reproductive system."

"I thought it was clever ."

"It is clever , it's extremely clever." Wednesday glanced at Enid, a hint of amusement in her expression. "Are we still doing this?"

"You still want to?"

"Enid, you just described a roleplay where you're a strict professor in black lace underwear teaching me about the reproductive system, yes, I still want to."

Enid laughed, the sound surprising her with how bright, genuine, and completely unforced it was. "Okay , good, because the black lace is still in my drawer, I almost threw it out on Friday , but I couldn't bring myself to do it."

"Thank God for your inability to throw things away."

"I'm pretty sure the Thai food is still on my counter."

"It's been three days."

"I know, it's probably sentient by now."

They climbed the stairs to Enid's apartment, number 42B, where the door looked the same as it always had, with its scuffed paint, brass numbers, and the faint outline of a previous tenant's Welcome mat still imprinted on the landing. Yet something felt different this time, lighter, as though the door itself knew that when Wednesday walked through it, she wouldn't be walking out again in anger.

Enid unlocked the door and pushed it open, revealing an apartment that was an absolute disaster, with dishes piled in the sink, clothes scattered across the floor, and the takeout bag of Thai food sitting exactly where Wednesday had left it, now giving off a smell that was definitely no longer green curry.

"Ignore the mess," Enid said, glancing around the apartment. "I had a minor breakdown."

"I can see that."

"The Thai food is going straight in the trash, I promise, I'll do it right now."

Enid grabbed the takeout bag with both hands and carried it to the kitchen trash can, holding it at arm's length as though it were radioactive, which, honestly, it probably was by this point. The bag landed at the bottom of the can with a wet thump, and Enid straightened with a satisfied look.

"There, one step toward being a functional human being."

"A monumental achievement."

"Shut up."

Wednesday set her fencing bag by the door and looked around the apartment, taking in the pile of ungraded sociology notes on the coffee table, the fruit-shaped magnets on the fridge~~pin~~eapple, watermelon, and grapes~~sti~~ll arranged in the same configuration as Thursday, and the crack in the wall where Enid's phone had hit before clattering to the floor.

"You really threw your phone at the wall," Wednesday said.

"Across the room, I did mention that."

"Across the room."

"There's a dent, do you want to see the dent?"

"Yes, actually, I really do."

Enid led Wednesday to the spot, where a small dent, no bigger than a dime, marked the drywall. Apparently, the phone had hit at exactly the wrong angle, leaving a surprisingly deep divot for something that weighed less than a pound.

"That's impressive," Wednesday said.

"I was very angry."

"At me?"

"At everything, at the rumors, at myself, at the fact that I had feelings I couldn't control." Enid touched the dent with her fingertip, studying it for a moment before looking at Wednesday. "You weren't wrong, you know, when you said I was the most scared person you'd ever met, you were right. I've been scared my whole life, scared of ending up like my parents, scared of being vulnerable, and scared of letting someone in only to have them leave."

Wednesday rested a hand on the small of Enid's back, her touch light and reassuring, simply present without pushing her to say anything more.

"And now?" Wednesday asked.

"Now I'm still scared, but I'm more scared of losing you than I am of getting hurt, which is..." Enid let out a shaky laugh, struggling to believe she'd actually admitted it. "Terrifying, actually, I hate it, this is the worst."

"I'm sorry."

"Don't be sorry, you didn't do anything wrong, you were honest and vulnerable, you told me how you felt, and I screamed at you." Enid turned to face Wednesday, looking at her with a pleading expression. "Can we just agree that I'm the asshole in this situation, so I can stop apologizing and we can move on?"

"You're not an asshole, you're someone who's been hurt and hasn't learned how to trust people yet."

"That's a very generous interpretation of me screaming at you to get out."

"I'm a generous person."

"You're an annoyingly generous person." Enid stepped closer, Wednesday's hand still resting on her back, and placed her own hands against Wednesday's chest, feeling the warmth of her skin beneath the black fabric of her fitted shirt. "Can we do the glasses thing now? I really need to do the glasses thing, I've been thinking about it for two weeks, and I feel like I'll die if I don't do the glasses thing."

"The black lace?"

"The black lace, the strict professor , the reproductive system, all of it."

"Right now?"

"Right now , unless you need to eat first or hydrate or"—

Wednesday kissed Enid in the middle of her sentence, moving her hand from Enid's back to her hair and tangling her fingers in her ponytail as she pulled her closer. Enid made a small sound against Wednesday's mouth, a mixture of surprise, relief, and hunger , before kissing her back with everything she had.

When they finally broke apart, Enid was breathless, barely managing to get the words out. "I'll take that as a yes."

"That's a yes."

"Go sit at the kitchen table, I need to change." Enid gently pushed Wednesday toward the kitchen, already backing away. "Give me five minutes, don't move, don't touch anything, and don't look at the dishes in the sink, they're judging me, and they'll judge you too."

"Five minutes?"

"Five minutes."

Enid disappeared into her bedroom, and the door clicked shut behind her, leaving Wednesday standing in the middle of the kitchen, surrounded by fruit magnets and dirty dishes, with the lingering smell of three-day-old Thai food that even the trash couldn't contain, smiling to herself as she waited.

Five minutes later, Enid emerged from her bedroom wearing the black lace panties she'd promised, the delicate, sheer fabric sitting low on her hips, with intricate details that looked innocent until someone got close enough to appreciate them. She'd paired them with a matching black lace bra, equally expensive, and nothing else,

except for the glasses she'd stolen from her costume drawer , an old pair of reading glasses with thick black frames that she'd bought for a Halloween costume three years ago and never thrown away. They sat slightly crooked on her nose, completely ridiculous and utterly perfect for what she had planned.

Wednesday was sitting at the kitchen table exactly where Enid had told her to wait, wearing her own glasses, the real ones Enid had asked her to bring on Thursday, the ones that made her look earnest, focused, and completely edible. Her fencer's physique was lean and lithe beneath her signature black clothes, giving her a presence that was both commanding and elegant.

When Enid walked in, Wednesday looked up, her mouth opening before closing again, only to open once more as she struggled to find her words.

"Professor ," "W ednesday finally managed.

"Ms. Addams." Enid kept her voice cool and professional, like a woman who had never screamed at anyone to get out of her apartment. "Thank you for staying after class, your recent performance has been concerning."

"My performance?"

"Y our grades are slipping, your attention is wandering, and I've noticed you staring at me during lectures instead of taking notes." Enid walked toward Wednesday slowly, her bare feet silent against the linoleum. "That's a problem, Ms. Addams."

Wednesday swallowed, her eyes fixed on Enid, taking in the black lace, the borrowed glasses, and the deliberate sway of her hips. "I'm sorry, Professor, I didn't mean to"—

"Didn't mean to what?" Enid stopped in front of her , close enough to see Wednesday's pulse jumping in her throat. "Didn't mean to

fantasize about me, didn't mean to imagine what I look like under my clothes?"

"I—"

"Stand up."

Wednesday obeyed immediately, rising from her chair as it scraped against the floor. Enid stood close enough that she had to tilt her head up to maintain eye contact, and when the borrowed glasses slid down her nose, she pushed them back into place with one finger.

"You're a very bright student, Ms. Addams, top of the class, but intelligence isn't everything, and sometimes you need—" Enid reached up and traced a finger along Wednesday's jawline, "private tutoring."

Wednesday's breath caught. "Private tutoring?"

"Mm-hmm." Enid let her finger trail down W ednesday's neck, over her collarbone, and to the center of her chest through the black fabric of her shirt. "I've developed a special curriculum just for you, and it covers a topic you seem to be struggling with."

"What topic?"

"The reproductive system."

Wednesday made a sound somewhere between a laugh and a groan. "You actually did it, you actually—"

"Quiet, Ms. Addams, students don't interrupt the professor ." Enid hooked a finger into the collar of Wednesday's shirt and pulled her down to her level. "Now , are you ready for your lesson?"

Wednesday kissed her instead of answering, and the borrowed glasses clinked against Wednesday's real ones. The kiss was awkward and clumsy enough that they both started laughing, breaking character, easing the tension, and forgetting everything

except the heat that had been building between them for three days. Enid's hands found Wednesday's hair and pulled her closer, while Wednesday's hands settled on Enid's waist and hips, touching the bare skin above her black lace panties.

"Wait," Enid breathed against Wednesday's mouth. "Wait, wait, the roleplay."

"I don't care about the roleplay."

"We have to, I bought the glasses, I bought the underwear, and I had a script."

"You said you didn't have a script."

"A loose outline, which is basically a script, and we're ruining it."

Wednesday pulled back just enough to look at Enid, her glasses crooked, her shirt rumpled, and her eyes dark with want, though there was something else in them too, something softer that looked a lot like the feeling Enid had been running from.

"We can do the roleplay another time," Wednesday said. "Right now, I just want you, not the professor, not the campus slut, not the character you play at parties, just you, Enid."

Enid's throat tightened. "That's-"

"Too much?"

"No, it's-" She pushed the borrowed glasses up onto her forehead, moving them out of the way. "exactly what I needed, how do you always know exactly what I need?"

"Because I pay attention." Wednesday kissed Enid's forehead, then her nose, and finally the corner of her mouth. "Sit on the table."

"What?"

"Sit on the table, I want to taste you."

A shiver ran down Enid's spine. "The kitchen table? Again?"

"Yes, again."

"This is becoming a habit."

"A good habit." Wednesday guided Enid backward until her bare thighs touched the edge of the table. "Sit, please."

Enid sat down, the cool Formica pressing against her skin as Wednesday stepped between her knees and slid her hands up Enid's thighs, her thumbs tracing circles over the sensitive skin just below the black lace.

"I've been thinking about this for three days," Wednesday murmured, her gaze fixed on Enid's face. "About you, about us, about what I'd do if you ever let me back in."

"What would you do?"

Wednesday answered by hooking her fingers into the waistband of Enid's panties and pulling them down slowly, letting the black lace slide over her hips, thighs, and knees. Enid lifted her hips to help, and the panties dropped to the floor before Wednesday's mouth found the inside of her thigh.

"Wednesday—"

"Tell me what you want."

"You, just you, I don't—" Enid's head fell back as Wednesday's lips traced higher. "I don't need the lesson or the roleplay, I just need you."

"Then you have me."

Wednesday's tongue found her, flat and broad, dragging from her entrance up to the swell of her clit in a single, maddening stroke. Enid gripped the edge of the table as the borrowed glasses slipped off her head and clattered somewhere behind her. She would find them later, or she wouldnt, because nothing mattered except the wet heat of Wednesday's mouth and the way she was making Enid feel.

Wednesday moved with a confidence that made it hard to believe she had only been doing this for weeks rather than years, her attention focused entirely on Enid as her tongue traced circles and figure-eights over her clit, each movement leaving Enid struggling to catch her breath. Whenever Enid tried to close her legs, Wednesday tightened her hands around Enid's thighs, her thumbs pressing into the muscles to keep her open and exposed.

"Fuck W ednesday, fuck" The words escaped Enid in a loud, desperate gasp as Wednesday drew her clit into her mouth, sucking gently while her tongue flicked against the sensitive bundle of nerves. Enid's hips bucked, and her hands flew to Wednesday's head, fingers tangling in her hair and gripping hard enough to hurt, but Wednesday didnt stop or pull away . nstead, she slid one hand up Enid's thigh and pressed it against her lower belly, holding her steady as Enid struggled to keep herself together.

"Right there, right oh G d, right fucking there"

Enid was shaking, her thighs trembling against Wednesday's shoulders as her stomach clenched and her breath came in short, sharp gasps. She was so close that she could almost taste it, but before she could fall over the edge, Wednesday slid two fingers inside her, curling them exactly the way Enid had taught her and pressing against the spot that made her see stars.

Enid came with a sound caught somewhere between a scream and a sob, her whole body arching off the table as she pulsed around Wednesday's fingers. Wednesday didnt stop, continuing to lick and suck her through the intense waves of pleasure until the trembling

finally subsided and Enid collapsed against the cool Formica, boneless and gasping for air.

"Holy shit," Enid breathed, still trying to catch her breath.

Wednesday looked up from between Enid's thighs, her glasses completely fogged and her chin glistening, a satisfied smile spreading across her face. "Good?"

"Get up here, right now, pants off. I need you inside me."

Wednesday stood and unbuckled her belt, letting her black trousers drop to the floor. Enid remained sprawled across the kitchen table, her legs dangling over the edge, her body still sensitive and aching for more. Wednesday's cock was already hard, straining against her underwear, with a damp spot of pre-cum darkening the fabric.

"Condom?" Wednesday asked.

"I'm on the pill." Enid replied, giving her an impatient look. "We've done this before, Wednesday."

"I just wanted to make sure-"

"Wednesday." Enid propped herself up on her elbows and met her gaze. "Stop being a gentlewoman and fuck me."

Wednesday slipped off her glasses and placed them on the counter beside the table before stepping between Enid's thighs, her cock nudging against Enid's entrance, warm, hard, and achingly familiar. She gripped Enid's hip with one hand and guided herself inside with the other.

The first inch made Enid gasp, the second drew a moan from her throat, and by the time Wednesday was fully seated, buried to the hilt, Enid was gripping the edge of the table so tightly that her knuckles had gone white.

"Fuck," Enid whispered, looking at Wednesday with an expression that left no room for doubt. "You feel so good, you always feel so good."

"You're so tight," Wednesday said, her voice strained. "God, Enid"—

"Move, please, move."

Wednesday began moving, slowly at first, each deliberate thrust drawing a gasp, a moan, or a broken version of her name from Enid's lips. The wet sound of her movements filled the kitchen, obscene and perfect, while the fruit-shaped magnets rattled on the fridge with every impact, the table creaked beneath them, and the dishes in the sink clinked against each other as if they were still judging them.

Wednesday gradually found a steady rhythm, her hips rolling against Enid's as her fingers gripped Enid's waist hard enough to leave bruises. Enid wrapped her legs around Wednesday, pulling her closer and urging her deeper, the angle so perfect that every thrust hit a spot inside her that made her vision blur and her toes curl.

"Harder," Enid gasped, tightening her hold on Wednesday. "Please, harder."

Wednesday obeyed, driving into her with enough force to send the table slamming against the wall and make the fruit magnets rattle even louder. Somewhere in the back of Enid's mind, she worried about the neighbors, but the concern disappeared when Wednesday slid her hand between their bodies and found her clit, still sensitive from her first orgasm and throbbing beneath Wednesday's fingers.

"That's it," Wednesday murmured, her voice low and steady. "Come for me, I want to feel you come again."

Her thumb traced small, precise circles over Enid's clit as she continued moving against her, each thrust deep and steady, filling Enid over and over until she could barely think straight.

"Fuck, Wednesday, I'm—"

"I know, let go, I've got you."

Enid let go, the orgasm ripping through her, bigger and longer than the first, the sensation spreading through her entire body until she felt it everywhere, from her clit and pussy to the soles of her feet and the top of her scalp. Her legs clamped around Wednesday's waist, her nails dug into Wednesday's shoulders, and loud, broken moans escaped her lips, completely beyond her control.

"Ahh, ahn, fuck, Wednesday, yes—"

Wednesday came a heartbeat later, her body shuddering against Enid's as she spilled inside her. Enid felt every spasm and desperate pulse, while Wednesday buried her face in Enid's neck, breathing raggedly with her fingers still resting against Enid's clit, gentler now as she coaxed her through the aftershocks.

They stayed tangled together for a long moment, breathing hard as the table creaked beneath them and the refrigerator hummed in the background, the fruit magnets finally still.

Then Enid started laughing.

"Did we just do that on the kitchen table?"

"Again," Wednesday mumbled against her neck. "We did it again."

"This is absolutely becoming a habit."

"The best habit."

Enid pushed gently against Wednesday's chest until she pulled back enough to look at her. Wednesday's hair was a complete disaster, and her expression was dazed and satisfied, but there was something deeper in her eyes, something that looked a lot like the feeling she had practically screamed at Enid for admitting.

"I'm not going to be good at this," Enid said quietly, her gaze fixed on Wednesday's face. "The relationship thing, the feelings thing, I'm going to mess up, I'm going to freak out, and I'm probably going to scream at you again at some point."

Wednesday looked at Enid for a long moment before answering, "Then I'll remind you that you don't have to be good at it."

Enid blinked, confused by the simple certainty in her voice. "What?"

"You don't have to know what to say or what to do," Wednesday explained, brushing her thumb over Enid's cheek. "You just have to stop assuming I'll leave the moment you get something wrong."

Something in Enid's chest tightened as she looked at Wednesday, struggling to find the right words. "Wednesday-"

"I know you're scared," Wednesday continued, her voice quiet and almost hesitant. "I'm scared too, and I have no idea what I'm doing, but I know that when I look at you, I don't want to be anywhere else."

Enid stared at her, caught off guard by the honesty in her words. Wednesday glanced away, as if the confession had become embarrassing the moment it left her mouth, but she continued anyway.

"And I know I want to wake up next to you, hear you complain about my coffee, watch you steal my shirts and leave your things everywhere, and—" She paused briefly before looking back at Enid. "I want you to stay."

Enid's eyes began to sting. "That's a lot of things."

"Yes, I'm aware."

"And you're saying you want all of that? With me?"

Wednesday met her gaze without hesitation. "With you."

For a moment, Enid couldnt speak, overwhelmed by the certainty in Wednesday's answer. Then she let out a small, shaky laugh and pulled Wednesday into her arms, catching her off guard enough that Wednesday went completely still.

"Enid"—

"Shut up."

"I wasnt going to say anything."

"Good."

Enid held her tighter, pressing her face into Wednesday's shoulder as the familiar scent of her shampoo and the warmth of her body brought her a sense of comfort she hadnt realised how badly she needed. She could feel Wednesday breathing steadily against her, and for once, nothing about being this close to her felt complicated.

After a moment, Wednesday wrapped her arms around Enid, initially careful and almost tentative before pulling her closer, holding her as though she had no intention of letting go anytime soon.

That was what finally broke Enid, not the kiss, not the words, and not even the way Wednesday had said *with you* as though choosing Enid was the simplest thing in the world. It was the way Wednesday held her now, as though Enid wasnt something temporary or a mistake she would eventually regret, but someone worth keeping.

Enid closed her eyes and whispered, "You're really doing this."

Wednesday rested her cheek against Enid's hair. "Yes."

"Even though I'm a disaster?"

"Especially because you're a disaster."

Enid laughed against her shoulder. "That's so romantic."

"I thought so."

She pulled back just enough to look at Wednesday, taking in her messy hair and the faint scratch on her cheek. Wednesday regarded her with the same serious expression she seemed to wear for everything, and Enid had never seen anything so beautiful. Before she could overthink it, she leaned forward and kissed her softly.

When Enid pulled away, Wednesday's eyes followed her face, her attention lingering long enough for Enid to notice.

"What?" Enid asked.

"Nothing."

"You're staring."

"I know."

Enid smiled, and for the first time in three days, she didn't feel the urge to run. She no longer wanted to pretend their relationship meant nothing, hide how scared she was, or deny that she wanted something more, because the truth was that she wanted Wednesday, along with the awkward conversations, the arguments, the quiet mornings, and the ridiculous amount of coffee. She wanted to learn how to make this work, even if she got things wrong along the way or needed time to figure it out.

Wednesday was still here, looking at Enid as though she wanted to stay, and that was enough to make Enid believe they might actually have a chance. She leaned forward and hugged Wednesday again, this time without saying anything, while Wednesday settled her hand against the back of Enid's head.

"You're going to have to let me go eventually," Wednesday murmured.

"Nope."

"Enid."

"Five more minutes."

Wednesday sighed, but after a moment, she gave in with a quiet, "All right."

Enid smiled into her shoulder, feeling the tension slowly leave her body as she held on a little longer. The kitchen was still a mess, the apartment was still a mess, and their relationship would probably be a mess for a while too, but Enid found that she didn't care nearly as much as she thought she would.

A month after their reconciliation, following weeks of healing, honest conversations, and slowly learning to trust each other again, Wednesday and Enid found themselves standing in the same kitchen where everything had nearly fallen apart. They began talking about their feelings, and before either of them could properly plan what to say, they ended up asking each other to officially be girlfriends at the exact same time. Neither had known the other was planning to ask, but both wanted to make their commitment clear. They were serious about each other, and neither wanted to walk away anymore.

Three weeks later, they moved into an apartment together. It was a beautiful place, with intact ceilings, properly insulated walls, and neighbours who were blessedly quiet. After everything they had been through, having a peaceful home felt almost too good to be true. For Enid, who had grown up associating domestic life with shouting, slammed doors, and the constant fear of another argument, the quiet was especially meaningful.

They decorated the apartment together, combining Enid's colourful style with Wednesday's darker taste, filling the rooms with soft blankets, matching mugs, and little decorative pieces while keeping a few darker touches that Wednesday refused to compromise on.

Gradually, their belongings mixed together until neither of them could remember whose things were whose.

As they settled into their new home, they developed comfortable routines, shared meals, and spent lazy mornings tangled together in bed. Enid grew familiar with Wednesday's habit of making coffee at odd hours, while Wednesday became accustomed to finding her shirts scattered around the bedroom because Enid kept stealing them. Living together also meant they could be affectionate whenever they wanted, and their sex life remained active and satisfying as they grew more comfortable with each other over the following weeks.

They also established a tradition of Thursday date nights, determined to keep making time for each other even when their schedules became busy. Sometimes Wednesday planned elaborate restaurant outings, pretending her research was purely practical, while Enid happily dressed up and took pictures of everything they ordered.

On other days, they visited cafes and bookstores, watched movies, or simply wandered through the city holding hands. Their conversations ranged from classes and future plans to the ridiculous things Enid had seen online, with Wednesday pretending to find most of her stories unnecessary while always listening anyway.

Over time, they began collecting matching things, including phone cases, keychains, hoodies, and eventually rings. Enid considered them romantic, while Wednesday insisted the rings were simply a sensible reminder of their commitment. Enid loved pointing out whenever they wore similar colours, even when Wednesday denied planning it, and Wednesday gradually became just as affectionate in her own quiet way, instinctively matching Enid's pace and moving closer whenever Enid reached for her hand.

During these first few months together, Enid also began spending more time with Wednesday's parents, Morticia and Gomez Addams. They welcomed her warmly, treating her as though she had always

belonged in their family. Gomez made sure she never left the dinner table hungry, while Morticia remembered the smallest details Enid mentioned in passing. Both seemed genuinely delighted whenever Wednesday brought her home, and Gomez soon began calling Enid their future daughter-in-law, much to Wednesday's amusement and Enid's embarrassment.

At first, Enid struggled to accept their affection. She kept expecting criticism, conditions, or arguments, just as she had experienced growing up. Instead, she witnessed parents who could disagree without tearing each other apart, express affection without using it as a bargaining tool, and show their love through ordinary gestures. Watching Morticia and Gomez together gradually helped her understand that love did not have to be loud to be real, and it did not have to hurt to mean something.

With Wednesday's encouragement and the support of the Addams family, Enid also began seeing a therapist. She started working through the memories she had carried since childhood, including her parents' constant fights, the physical violence that sometimes accompanied their arguments, and the betrayals caused by both parents cheating on each other. Growing up surrounded by anger and dishonesty had left her convinced that relationships were never safe, that love always came with a catch, and that getting attached to someone meant giving them the power to destroy her.

Therapy did not erase those memories overnight. Even after moving in with Wednesday, Enid sometimes found herself bracing for an argument that never came or searching for signs that Wednesday would eventually grow tired of her. However, she gradually learned to recognise those fears as remnants of her childhood rather than proof that her own relationship would end the same way. She began to understand that she had never been responsible for her parents' choices and did not have to repeat their mistakes.

Wednesday remained beside her throughout the process, listening when Enid struggled and reassuring her without making her feel ashamed of her fears. Their relationship was not perfect, but it was

honest, and Enid was slowly learning that she could have difficult days, make mistakes, and express her feelings without automatically losing the person she loved.

Eight months after choosing each other again, Wednesday and Enid had built a life that felt entirely their own. Their Thursday date nights had become a tradition, their apartment was filled with little things they had collected together, and their private jokes could turn even an ordinary evening into something worth remembering. They still had disagreements, but they had learned how to work through them without letting fear or pride push them apart.

For Enid, the biggest change had been learning that love did not have to be earned by being easy to love. With time, she began to accept what she had once struggled to believe: that she could make mistakes, ask for help, and be vulnerable without risking everything she cared about.

She had spent so much of her life expecting happiness to be temporary that she had never learned how to simply enjoy it. Now, she could watch Wednesday reading beside her on the couch, listen to Gomez and Morticia bicker affectionately over dinner, or fall asleep beside the woman she loved without wondering how long it would last.

For once, Enid didn't need to prepare herself for goodbye. She had Wednesday, a family that wanted her around, and a home she no longer felt the need to run from.

And that was enough.

Chapter End Notes

And that's a wrap on Extra Credit!

Thank you to everyone who read, commented, left kudos and bookmarked this fic. Your support means a lot to me, and I'm so happy you stayed with Enid and Wednesday until the end. They

started with an arrangement and somehow ended up catching feelings.
Thank you for reading 3

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